

CREATURE COMFORTS

CAST:

REXAS

LADY GOTH

PAULETTE

JUNIA

SYONA

DR. CORBEAU

In the delectable service of:

LADY MORRIGAN

written by

YOURS TRULY

In
THE LADY MORRIGAN SERIES

Titled:
CREATURE COMFORTS

1st Edition

Circa 2026



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The following work is inspired for someone special
May this fantasy be fantastic, fun, and tastefully erotic
Because this wouldn't be done for anyone else

Without further ado
Welcome to Goon™

REFERENCE MATERIAL & FOOTNOTES:

¹ The FOUND ART clause was first recognized in Jill v. Jayne; the defendant's lawyer convinced the jury that the plaintiff's nude paintings should be submitted into defense and that he was totally 'asking for a friend'.

² For more info, visit <https://www.downbad.fk/mikkmadd>, regarding Technical Humanities, Indulgence, and Really Smutty Topics (THIRST).

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for
loving what is wrong with us

BOOK ONE

I

There had been at least half of a hundred proposals made by the time Lady Morrigan was ready to go to the gala. Letters had come to her from prospects far and wide, and others had sent envoys and family emissaries who had bowed at the threshold of her home.

In just three days since the invitations had been sent out, scores of men had lined up to take her on as their accompanying date. There were flowers from Berlin, hothouse camellias cultivated under glass, wild heathers from Ireland, and Surrey's Winter Roses—with hellebore still clinging to them. Chocolates arrived from Belgium, cloths and linens came in from Poland and Spain, spices were sent straight from the Indian subcontinent to bring flavor to the winter. There were dresses sewn with gold-laden accents and silk gowns that flowed like honey against her skin. Necklaces encrusted with jade, emerald and ruby bracelets, rings made from blood diamonds; everything she could ever dream of.

And yet, she could have all those things if she had wanted, all without giving in to the men that had sent her these propositions conditioned with expectation.

She had tried a few gowns. In the full-length mirror of her bedchamber, they truly had looked exquisite, but Lady Morrigan didn't want to appease anyone who would try to buy her off.

There is no price for my hand, nor is there anyone to sell me off. If I decide to go, I must do so on my own terms, and as much as I hate to admit it, using my own collection of dresses.

She stood in front of the mirror in her chemise and corset, the rejected gown laid across a settee. It was a beautiful piece of emerald silk with gold embroidery, sent by some rentier whose name had already been forgotten.

Wearing it felt like accepting a down payment. The fabric was lovely, but there it was again, conditioned expectation woven into every thread. It suffocated her.

She reached for her own cream-champagne-colored underdress when a light, hesitant knock came from the door.

“Enter.”

The door opened, and her lady-in-waiting stepped inside, her head lowered as was her habit. She wore trousers and a loose shirt beneath her overalls, her copper curls pinned back in a hasty knot, several strands escaping to frame her face.

“My Lady Morrigan, I—” Paulette’s words caught in her throat.

Lady Morrigan turned, her arms adjusting the corset laces, and the thin fabric of her chemise doing little to obscure her shapely frame. She caught Paulette in the mirror, seeing the young woman frozen at the threshold, her crystal-blue eyes wide and fixed on the sight before her, and her cheeks flushing a deep, crimson red.

“Paulette?” Lady Morrigan asked, turning to face her.

The young woman was startled, and she jerked her gaze to the floor with an almost violent swiftness as if she might strain her neck. “I—my apologies, milady. I didn’t realize—I should come back—”

“No need for that,” Lady Morrigan said, noting the tremor in the young woman’s voice, the way her hands clutched at the doorframe. “Close the door and come.”

Paulette obeyed, shutting the door with a soft click, and slowly made her way towards her. Her gaze was fixed to the floor, but she stole a few glances towards Morrigan, wearing her nervousness on her sleeve.

“Pauli, look at me,” she said softly, a hint of amusement in her voice. “In spite of what your title suggests, waiting is not what you’re supposed to do.”

She reached for the underdress and slipped it over her head. The fabric settled around her hips, and she raised her arms, making way for assistance.

“Now come help me with this and tell me what has you so flustered.”

Paulette took a shaky breath, her chest rising and falling beneath her shirt, and finally lifted her chin. Her eyes met Lady Morrigan’s, then darted away, and returned as if drawn by the magnetism of the woman before her.

“I have something for you, my lady,” Paulette said, reaching into the pocket of her trousers and producing a small envelope with a subtle tremble to her fingers. “A correspondence.”

Lady Morrigan took it. It had the wax seal of the Académie de Genève, and no mention of who exactly it was addressed to. She broke the seal and read the contents within with her own expression being unreadable.

‘Meet me after the ball, I’ll place a trail for you to follow.’

Swiftly, she closed the letter. “Did you receive it here?” she asked her lady-in-waiting.

“No, milady. I was summoned to collect it under pretense of fetching one of your gifts.”

“Good.” She stepped closer to the young woman, who took another sharp breath at the proximity. “Tell no one of it, Pauli.”

She extended her hand slightly, bringing the letter close to Paulette. “Burn this away and do so in secret.”

Paulette nodded, her throat working as she swallowed. She brought her hand close and her fingers curled around the letter, brushing against Lady Morrigan’s hand. Lady Morrigan could feel the woman’s pulse racing, her quickened breath making her shoulders rise and fall.

“Now then—” slowly, Lady Morrigan turned, presenting her back to Paulette. “Help me with this gown, will you?”

Paulette retrieved the gown and came up behind Lady Morrigan, guiding her arms into the sleeves with careful touches. Her fingers brushed against Lady Morrigan’s bare skin on more than one occasion, at times her touches being entirely unnecessary, and every contact sent a warmth through Lady Morrigan as well.

In the mirror, she saw Paulette work at the laces of her dress, the lady-in-waiting taking her time to tie each of them, being almost too delicate, at times not making it as tight as they needed to be. Her hands were gentle, careful. They lingered at Lady Morrigan’s waist as she tightened the corset and secured the dress. The champagne-colored dress fell in long, uninterrupted lines across the woman’s body, yielding to her form and gathering faintly at the waist before drifting outward.

As the last of the laces were tied, Paulette’s hands found their way back to Lady Morrigan’s waist. She looked as if she could not bear to remove them.

Lady Morrigan took her hands in her own, squeezing them, bringing them—and Paulette—closer to her as she had the young woman embrace her from behind.

“Are you well, Pauli? Letters like those are hardly cause for concern. You needn’t worry. I simply appreciate discretion and return it in kind to its sender.”

Paulette cleared her throat. “No—yes—yes, I am, milady.” She stammered. “It’s just that—you look beautiful in that dress.”

Lady Morrigan brought one of Paulette’s hands up to her lips and pressed a light, lingering kiss to her knuckles. It was slow and deliberate on her part. Morrigan did often enjoy the young woman grow jittery in her presence, and downright breathless in proximity.

She slowly brought Paulette’s hand below, resting it against her chest, where her heart beat steady and strong beneath silk and skin.

“Your admiration is appreciated, Pauli,” she murmured. “It sends my pulse racing.”

She paused. Her thumb traced the delicate bones of Paulette’s wrist, feeling the young woman’s pulse. “Though here I feel as if yours hammers with greater fervor.” Her eyes gleamed with wicked amusement. “Is the dress that captivating, I wonder?”

“It’s not the silk that captivates, my lady, but who it clings to.” She spoke softly, the hand on Lady Morrigan’s waist roaming, feeling the texture. “You would take anyone’s breath away even without the dress.”

Lady Morrigan’s lips curved in a wicked smirk. “Without a dress, I’m sure I would.”

“N—No! I meant—”

“As would you, Pauli.”

Paulette gulped, the sound loud as it filled the silent room. “Milady?” she breathed, her inquisitive voice low in a whisper.

Lady Morrigan leaned back, letting her full weight settle against Paulette's slightly smaller frame, tilting her head until it rested on the woman's shoulder. Paulette had to quickly tighten her arms, holding on to keep them both upright, her fingers splaying across Lady Morrigan's waist while the other pressed against her chest.

"We could go dressless," Lady Morrigan purred, her voice honeyed and warm against Paulette's neck. She felt the heat radiating from the woman. "Perhaps even naked as the day we were born. Two beauties taking the world's breath away." She turned her head just enough to let her lips brush the shell of Paulette's ear. "What say you, Pauli? Shall we scandalize all of Geneva?"

Paulette's arms tightened, her fingers digging slightly into the silk. "I'm certain I wouldn't even hold a candle—"

"Oh, nonsense!" Lady Morrigan gracefully spun in Paulette's grasp, catching the woman's wrists and pulling her forward until they stood before the mirror, face to face, their breath mingling with each other's. She released her hands from Paulette's only to grab her waist with both, a firm grip yanking her close—close enough that their bodies pressed flush, hip to hip, breast to breast.

Paulette gasped, her crystal eyes wide, her cheeks burning even brighter than before.

"Look," Lady Morrigan commanded with insistence. She turned them slightly, angling Paulette toward the glass. "Set your eyes on what I see before me."

She saw Paulette staring at her own reflection—her copper hair was disheveled, her lips parted, eyes bright and slightly hazy, as if staring deeply into something. Lady Morrigan's head rested beside her own, dark-red locks framing her sharp features and golden eyes as they met Paulette's in the mirror. The young woman shivered as their eyes met.

“One of these days, Pauli,” Lady Morrigan whispered, her hands sliding from Paulette’s waist to grip her hips, pulling her even closer, “I am going to drape you in one of my own gowns. They fit you well enough.”

One of her hands snaked down to Paulette’s trousers, flowing against her thighs. Once it reached just below her knee, she brought her leg up, draping it around her own waist. “When you feel silk against your skin, Pauli, when you feel the touch of another against it as they graze your body wantingly, then...you will see what I see.” Her fingers then traced upward, back to her waist and above, following the line of Paulette’s ribs. “You will see how beautiful you are. How utterly irresistible.”

She leaned in, her lips brushing Paulette’s ear again, her voice sending shivers down the young woman’s spine. “Your lover will touch you like so, Pauli—” Her hand slid down, cupping Paulette’s backside with bold familiarity. “They will not be able to resist—”

Smack!

The sound cracked through the room, sharp and sudden. Paulette yelped, jumping in Lady Morrigan’s grip, her eyes going wide with shock, and her hands gripping at Lady Morrigan’s arms.

Lady Morrigan held her there for a moment longer, her hand still resting on the curve she had struck, her palm pulling Paulette into her. Then she laid a soft kiss on the woman’s cheek, before pulling back.

“Yet the world could not handle our beauty,” Lady Morrigan said, turning away as if nothing had happened, adjusting her gown in the mirror. “That, and I have a gala to prepare for.”

She glanced back at her lady-in-waiting. “Thank you for your help, Pauli. Now, inform the driver that I’ll be there in due time, and to get the carriage ready.”

Paulette nodded, bowing ever so slightly. “Yes, my lady,” she managed, her voice rough. “Immediately.”

“Good girl,” Lady Morrigan purred. Then she turned fully back to her reflection, her eyes in the mirror watching Paulette’s retreating form with a hunger.

Did I go too far this time? Perhaps I need not worry, though at this moment my concern falls upon whether I can attend the gala without my womaned-up scent giving me away.

II

The ballroom had a distinct, sweet aroma, thick scents of beeswax and a metallic tang that Lady Morrigan felt at the tip of her tongue. The ice cutters had brought in large blocks that had been chipped and placed in silver bowls, bottles of all sorts of wines resting atop them, chilling among the cold slush.

A few bottles from Chasselas were prominently displayed among bouquets of wildflowers to match their petrichor scent. On another table, Claret's metallic-iron scents juxtaposed against the serenading sweetness of Tokay spirit. A few bottles of Tuscan red were placed at the edge, where Lady Morrigan's eyes were drawn.

That one was her favorite, the Italian selection. It always felt distinct from the prudence of the elite, always a little wild and untamed. It brought memories of all the times she wanted to be a little wild herself, a little less hindered by the trappings of being a Lady of her own little demesne, so to speak.

She had one poured into a crystal glass, bellied wide, and with it in hand, sauntered to the edge of the ballroom. An orchestra of violins and dark woodwinds was playing. The guests moved in a slow waltz to match the pace and rhythm. Tonight, they were opting for little more than gently swaying to the hum.

The low light of the candelabras and chandeliers didn't help, and the patricians weren't too happy about the gloom. Lady Morrigan leaned into the shadow of a high-backed velvet chair, her eyes scanning the crowd. The voices were all a dull murmur, but she was able to discern some of their vicious barbs as they cut through the low hum of the music.

"An outsider he is—some highly irregular lineage, I've gathered." A woman's voice hissed from behind a painted fan. "He seems like a ghost in his own house."

"I thought this was the city! I would have deigned not to attend if all I received was a miserable twilight. If I'd have my say, the lamplighters would have been stripped of their commissions and licenses before dawn!" Another voice, a man's, grumbled.

"How much does a few more light fixtures cost, Mikel? Ten florins? He splurges on this yet forgets to let us gaze on the splendor, this feculent miser..."

"Perhaps it is so. Why else would he set this up to begin with? I hear there are Dutch bonds up for appraisal worth half a million francs alone..."

This gala was, certainly, different than most. It had been arranged through anonymous invitation, using this rentier's property for a temporary abode. Some mysterious executor had rented this massive property as his hosting ground, but there was never such an event held without an ulterior motive.

Despite that, Lady Morrigan considered herself far too unimportant and uninterested in such matters. She was here because of her own reasons, and one of them included finding something, anything, to strike her fancy or even become a passing interest. She had seen through the rabble, however intricately they adorned themselves. They were all poor candidates for a muse, but she knew at

least one of them would be interesting; a doctor who she knew was in attendance. A certain expert—as she had heard rumors of—in all things that screamed *‘forbidden science.’*

“Is it just the look that makes you seem abandoned? Or perhaps this wilderness truly has you lost?”

And then, she felt a presence—like shadow before the sun, an eclipsing force that consumed what little light remained in the ballroom, and she heard a low and smooth voice that came with it.

A woman stood before her, in dressed up in ebony and velvet hugging tightly across her skin, and wielding a voice that breathed a lilting, hypnotizing tone. Her eyes were a shade between violet and pitch, heavily kohled as if to appear vast and fathomless. Her lips were curved in a smile—blood-red, plump lips, inviting her to explore between them with her own, to find every sin that lay in the world beyond them when her eyes lay on those lips curved upwards.

She cut through the rest of the gilded opulence as her own shone like a black sun, and her hair glinted against the light of the candelabras in a severe, glossy-black. It was pulled back into a tight, intricate coil at the nape of her neck, emphasizing the lines of her face.

“I can concede on lost, but I’ll have to deny on abandoned.” She managed, though her own voice betrayed her, in a breathless, uneven lilt.

“A thing most fortunate, then, for it would’ve been rather curt of me to do this.” The woman came closer, extending a hand, and the music slowed along with the world.

Fortunate it was for Lady Morrigan. It was a moment she wanted to linger in, staring into the eyes of the woman who had just come up to her.

She could have looked into her eyes for a lifetime, gazing through those eyes of mauve and melancholy into a world inhabited by this woman—and only this woman.

Then, she glanced at the hand, gloved and extended her way. Seeming well and truly lost for a moment, it took a while for Morrigan to gather her thoughts. “Uh, ahem.” She cleared her throat. “Pardon?”

“I have come to claim you, my lady. Spoken for or not, I’ll have this dance, and you as well.”

Every iota of her voice was melodically breathy, an unsettling musical note that Morrigan couldn’t get enough of.

Without a second thought, or even a first that registered to question any acceptance of that command wrapped in courtesies, Lady Morrigan found herself placing her own hand in the gloved palm before her.

She inhaled sharply.

Even gloved—the touch sent a jolt of electricity through her entire body. From her fingertips it started, and she let out a breath, tingling sensations wrapping themselves around her as the woman’s long fingers curled possessively, drawing her close.

“Shall we?” the woman murmured—*we shall*, her eyes said—her thumb tracing slow circles against Lady Morrigan’s wrist. Such a maddeningly simply act it was, and so maddeningly devastating to her senses.

First Pauli, and now her. What is happening to me?

The woman didn’t wait for Lady Morrigan’s answer. With a simple tug, she swept her onto the floor and set her arm around her waist. Layers of fabric separated that touch, and yet her knees buckled and trembled as Lady Morrigan moved her own hand to this woman’s waist for support. She returned the act and put her own hand around

this woman, the heat from her body apparent even through the exquisite black velvet she adorned.

She almost tumbled forward, and their bodies met, the woman moving her firm hand and placing it at the small of her back. The other hand was still holding Lady Morrigan's own, just as this woman's pale, slender fingers laced together. Lady Morrigan's hand moved just above the side of her hip.

The contact was still walled by the fabrics of their dress, the material of their gloves, as they danced, though it was no less warm the way every bit of her lightly collided against Lady Morrigan. She had always led, always commanded, as was often a conscious requirement for the lady of a house. Yet now, holding and being held by this captivatingly unknown entity, she was effortlessly following, being guided by this woman with an imperceptible pressure, giving her free reign of herself as she felt the other woman's legs get closer and closer with the waltz, until their thighs met and the woman slid them between Lady Morrigan's.

There was no invitation requested. It was a simple case of acceptance until denial is given—and that word no longer existed in Lady Morrigan's vocabulary. In fact, the act itself had left the lexicon of human thought and action.

No singular touch asked anything of her. It only told her what she would feel next, give instruction on how to move, how to act, and how to give herself to this woman, to be *hers* in entirety.

"You tremble, my lady." She observed, pulling herself close to Morrigan and setting her lips to her ear. Her breath stirred the fine hairs as her words sent shivers. "Is it something you're afearred of or perhaps?"

"Frightened I am *nnoo---ah!*" Her words stopped halfway through as she took another sharp breath in. The woman's hand on her back

had begun exploring in earnest, and had found a way to her backside, and there was no subtlety in what this woman was doing.

The woman's figure moved with the music against the cream-champagne of her own dress, hips swaying on occasion, breasts colliding against breasts as she felt her own erect nubs brush against the woman's enticing bust.

Lady Morrigan had both imagined and experienced attempts at courting and serenading her countless times before, though she did admit to herself that it had never before been by a woman, especially by one so decidedly feminine herself. In fact, even in all this time, she had not even seen two women be so familiar with one another as this lady was being with her.

Nor had the crowd, by the looks of it. They had that stare that amalgamated hunger and disgust confusingly wrapped together in the same way Lady Morrigan wanted to be wrapped around her, legs tangled and bodies mingling in divine sensations.

"Is it hunger, or starvation, I wonder, that makes you writhe like so. My touch is but a touch, Lady Morrigan."

Lady Morrigan touched the woman's arm that was around her and reaching behind her hips. "You're a stranger to me, yet you find in me all kinds of intimacy. I'd prefer not to be at such a disadvantage."

"Oh, I'm sure you *hate* this." The woman breathed into her neck, and when Lady Morrigan's hand found hers, she dug her fingernails into her tighter, eliciting a sound between a gasp and a moan from Morrigan herself.

They both moved as if being guided by the music. Lady Morrigan had completely forgotten that there were others dancing alongside them, a few halting their own movements to gaze upon the salacious pair. Others only stole glances while a few slaps could be heard, and some stern statements about licentious leers.

“You feel it, don’t you?” The woman said, “The warmth of the summer breeze in the middle of a wretched winter.”

She gulped. Her mind went through a million thoughts, unable to grasp on any single one. She went halfway to being limp in her arms, and the hand on Lady Morrigan’s back pulled her back up against this woman, bringing them even closer. They were now cheek to cheek, and she felt a delicate whisper in her ear as Morrigan closed her eyes involuntarily.

She felt the woman remove the glove from her hand.

“The seasons change, and a new day dawns, Lady Morrigan. Open the windows. Step out into the light it brings. Feel the morning dew against your skin and let the summer kiss your tender flesh.”

As she said it, Lady Morrigan felt their bare hands touch, and the woman tangled their fingers together.

It was tender and soft. Firm and inviting and warm against the cool air.

Oh, so...

The words failed to come to her mind, her senses unable to focus on any one thing as that touch began to engulf every part of it. It invoked something that had been held there, dormant and untouched, held for a long time in places that Lady Morrigan had locked away, losing the hope that someone might come and turn their sacred key to open that lock.

Her presence was one thing, drawing her to this unknown woman, but her touch...

A sudden floating feeling took over her, her legs unable to stay grounded, her thighs trembling, and her core jittering and twisting.

The woman’s hands caressed her fingers, and it was clear what was happening then.

The already-dim lights of the ballroom grew dimmer still, and she suddenly found herself alone with nobody around her but this woman.

There was only Morrigan, and there was only *her*. This beauty whose name she had yet to learn, whose name she would scream into the night as they would lock in passionate embrace, whose name would adorn the walls of every room in her estate, every cave out in the wild, every little garden patch she could lay her down in to bring erotic pleasure. The two people in this world. The only two that mattered.

It had been something that irked her, at times. The strange, unfamiliar feeling of one's touch, that first contact with skin on skin that decided if she'd feel the warmth of their presence, or the lifeless cold of their demeanor. The only woman whose touch possessed even a fraction of the warmth she felt now, was...who?

Pauli, who I call a dear friend as much as my wait staff? Is this woman 'dear friend' as well, then?

And her heart was *thumping*, quaking and pounding at the lightness of her contact, at its warmth.

Let the summer kiss your tender flesh.

She heard the words, felt them inside her. Was she the summer? Was Morrigan the flesh? Would she kiss her to give her the warmth she so desired?

Would she feel the warmth *everywhere* as she would kiss her? How exactly would she kiss her? When? Now, their lips and mouths and tongues so close as their cheeks touched? Would it be somewhere else more private perhaps, or would this woman prefer to bring the entirety of Geneva to witness their kiss and their coupling, demanding that such heated love never be locked away but celebrated, basked in, awed and admired from near and far, documented and

recorded for the generations and epochs and eons to know; here lay Lady Morrigan and her lover, and here she would reach the brink and pinnacle of pleasure a million times in one single night.

Legends would be told of how she screamed this woman's name as she shivered and climaxed, and marriages for the next hundred generations would be ruined because none could ever match the love Lady Morrigan was given. Oh, how she'd so lovingly utter her name every time she could.

A shiver ran down her spine, a quiet feeling in her gut that made Lady Morrigan weak at the knees, but as soon as that moment started, the woman pulled back, a warmth still on the small of her back where her hand had been.

Before she could bring up that question of the name, that touch had vanished, and Lady Morrigan found herself alone in the dance floor.

III

The ballroom had become suffocating, and the air was thick and pungent. She felt stares around her, a thousand eyes lecherously leering at what had just been displayed, the perfumed scents getting stronger and stronger. Lady Morrigan needed escape, a moment to catch her breath before she dissolved entirely into the ache that the woman had just left throbbing between her thighs.

She slipped through the crowd as quickly as she could, her mind too hazy to think about where any one of the exits to some veranda or garden might be. She left the ballroom into a large hallway, empty and shadowy, lit even dimmer than the ballroom. There were no guards, no lookouts or staff assisting the guests or keeping them restricted to one part of the estate. It was strange, and entirely out of sorts—but this was not the moment to dwell on such inconsequential details.

She found a small door on a shadowy end of the hallway, half-hidden behind a velvet curtain, and stumbled through it.

Her body was still thrumming with the aftershocks when she glanced across the rest of the room. It looked to be a small gallery, or rather, a storage closet that had all sorts of paintings stored there.

Some were covered with tall white sheets, and a few frames—some a few feet tall and others larger than her own self—adorned the room.

Her skin felt too tight, her cream-gown too constricting as her mind hazed over with the memory of the gala-woman's bare hand on her, her breath against her throat, against her ear...

She placed a hand at the center of her sex, above all the threads that made her wish she could tear it off and make do with her hands what she wanted that woman for, closed her eyes, and put her other hand to her mouth as if to stifle a moan.

A soft sound then reached her, an uncontrolled gasp, as her eyes landed on a particular corner of the room.

On a settee next to a painting covered almost three-quarters with a white sheet, sat a woman. Her gown only reached up to her chest, and her shoulders bare, and her bust pushed up for display. Her shoulders shook with silent sobs, her face buried in her hands, and dark-golden hair falling forward to hide the grief that clearly swelled in her eyes.

For an instant, Lady Morrigan wanted to retreat from there, but something in the hitch of those shoulders pulled at her. She moved forward in soft steps, her own need for contact translating into an offering of it.

"Miss?" she whispered.

An *uncannily* young face looked up at her, startled. Her head jerked up and her hands fell away. She was young, or perhaps appeared so, though her stillness might have suggested an older sorrow.

Her face was smooth, too. Free of wrinkles and imperfections that anyone of age would have possessed. In her aching need, Lady Morrigan noticed the attractiveness of the woman's face, teary and wide-eyed, though her beauty felt more of an acquired taste than with

the prominence of the woman she had just danced with, or even Paulette.

Storm-cloud eyes, red-rimmed and glistening, widened at the intrusion, and for a few seconds, she was still composing herself. Then she hastily wiped her cheeks with trembling fingers, though the tears didn't stop.

"Oh—apologies—this is unforgivable," she choked. "I shouldn't—"

"Hush," Lady Morrigan said, and before she could think better of it, she found herself sitting beside this woman on the settle. Her body burned still from the touch of the woman on the dance floor, and her hands reached out instinctively. "There is no shame in grief, miss."

Wiping her tears, the woman looked at her, and something in her expression shifted. She began to stare at Lady Morrigan, in the way one would lay their eyes on something they have coveted for a long while. Her gaze traced the sharp lines of her jaw, the golden-brown eyes, and the mouth still slightly swollen from biting back moans not too long ago.

"You are," she breathed, her tears momentarily forgotten, "a thing of beauty most exquisite."

The words landed strangely upon Lady Morrigan. They did not feel flirtatious in the moment, yet she imagined the woman-from-the-gala speaking them to her. Uttered from her lips, their meaning would have been entirely different.

Her mind's eye flashed images of it, of an imagined woman in heavy velvet whispering sweet nothings. A worship of words, whispered into ears and necks and lips and mouths.

She felt heat rise to her cheeks. "You are upset, miss..." She said softly, reaching out. Her hand settled on the woman's bare shoulders.

“Junia.” she answered, leaning into the touch heavily. Her hand reached for Lady Morrigan’s knee, gripping it. Her body edged closer to Lady Morrigan’s as if seeking warmth with an urgency that bypassed thought.

The doctor.

Lady Morrigan had heard about Doctor Junia, about her madness and antics and how she had suddenly appeared here in Geneva, an aloof madwoman whom you were more likely to find hunched inside a laboratory than here, dress like...that. Lady Morrigan liked to remind herself that people were not often so simple.

“Morrigan,” she said in a low voice, her mind occupied with the hand on her knee, and her own on the bare, warm shoulder of...Junia. “It’s a lovely name.”

“Thank you, I suppose. Yours is as well. A lovely name for a lovely woman.”

Then Junia’s hand moved upward to Lady Morrigan’s thigh as the woman leaned her head on Lady Morrigan’s shoulder, and the hand migrated further upward to her waist, her thumb brushing the curve of her hip through the silk.

It was a touch too familiar, the kind that bypasses boundaries. Lady Morrigan opened her mouth to say something, to gently extract herself, but Junia made a small, wounded sound and pressed closer, gripping her waist tighter, and the words died in Morrigan’s throat.

In her flustered state, still dizzy from the dance, she said nothing. More than that, she could feel the desperation in the woman’s voice, the loneliness that had driven her to be here, and seek contact without caring who provided it. She could not bring herself to push Junia away.

“What ails you, Miss Junia, if I may ask?”

“I used to go by ‘Mrs.’ or ‘Lady’ then I was reminded of him and found myself here.” She looked around the room, pulling away only slightly from Lady Morrigan, though her hand remained grasping her waist. “Poor choice for escaping him, in a manner of speaking.”

Lady Morrigan looked at her as her head turned, only a few inches separating them, and found herself gazing at a familiar piece of painting.

Beau and Auclair. What is this doing here?

It was a painting of a man and woman, standing atop the flat deck of a tower. They were turned in the opposite direction, so only their backs were shown, and they were bare from head to toe—or heel, in this case. They stood with their arms outstretched, letting the sun bathe themselves in the light.

Lady Morrigan remembered when she painted it. A large man had stood, just like that, alongside a woman. She, too, was quite muscular—by the standards of Genevans, at least. Greek, perhaps, she had thought. She wasn’t titanic by any means, but stood a foot higher than her, and the man, too. It was one of the only times that Lady Morrigan remembered feeling anything remotely similar to how she felt now—*aroused*.

The painting itself was done indoors, though, the light of a fireplace being the only thing that illuminated their bodies, the shadow and silhouettes creating a similar light as if the sun was shining down upon them. Lady Morrigan never saw their faces or knew how either of them were. She had, though, paid extra attention to making sure the pair of them looked exquisite in the painting, every part of their naked selves being something that she herself would have desired, though it only meant to paint what she saw, exactly as it was.

She remembered imagining how each of their legs and thighs would feel as she gently traced a hand along them, letting her feeling

guide her painting hand. She imagined holding their waist, her hands unable to go fully around them. Both of them had magnificent, long hair, and she imagined running a hand through them, taking in the smell. She imagined what the woman would look like from the front, what the man would look like, and how she would feel pressed in between...

“He looked like him, you know,” Junia whispered, her voice breaking. She shifted, turning into Lady Morrigan’s body, and her face pressed against her shoulder. “He was tall and muscular and full of love,” Her hand came up, fingers curling into the fabric of Morrigan’s gown at her back, holding her close. “He was all this and more, and he chose me.” She sobbed, and clung to her, burying her face in the crook of Morrigan’s neck, her tears hot and wet against her skin. “He chose someone who is merely...adequate.”

Her tears fell in earnest, soaking into the silk of Lady Morrigan’s bodice, dampening her chest. Yet Junia held only tighter as her body shook and her hands wandered with that same unconscious seeking. She felt hands on her spine, digging into her hair, down and across her arms, occasionally pressing at the back of her neck to wrap in an embrace.

Morrigan’s heart hammered with arousal and strange confusion. She wanted to say something, to let this woman know that it is improper—even in grief—to be like this. But there was another feeling Lady Morrigan was attempting to ignore, and even to herself it seemed less plausible with every second. She felt Junia’s tears falling on her chest, her breath warm against her throat, and the woman’s breasts pressed against her own with each shuddering inhale.

Lady Morrigan instead found herself wrapping her arms around Junia’s waist, pulling her closer, and offering them both the comfort they demanded—though each seemed to have different motives for it.

For a few minutes, she remained like this, and when the sobs died down ever so slightly, she took both her hands then moved up either side of Junia's face, pulling her back and pressing their foreheads together. Junia's hands drifted down to Lady Morrigan's side, seemingly of their own accord, her fingers tracing the curve of her waist with that same familiarity.

"You are beautiful, Junia." She whispered, one hand reaching down to her back, stroking it, as Junia's found Lady Morrigan's leg again. With a smile, then Lady Morrigan looked at Junia's face and met her eyes. "And if you've ever doubted your beauty and its effects, just look at how wet you've made me."

Her face was ravaged by tears, but Junia managed a laugh, her face flushing crimson. "Aha! Apologies."

"Shhh." Lady Morrigan pulled her face into her own. She did not know why, but it felt right in the moment as they embraced. "Repulsive can be the heart, Junia, not our visage and features. Everything of yours is situated in all the right places."

When she pulled back, Junia's eyes felt different. Her gaze dropped to Lady Morrigan's neck where she had previously buried her face, and traveled down, following the trail of tears to where they had fallen on her chest. A damp spot lay where her eyes lingered, a sudden, sharp awareness in them.

"So are yours, my lady." She said softly and gulped. "In all the right places, though I suppose," her thumb began stroking along her leg and hip, "that I cannot take full credit for that particular effect."

Her eyes lingered on Lady Morrigan's breasts, that wet spot moving as she breathed—and laughed—at the surprising forwardness this woman was displaying now, her grief forgotten even though her tears weren't.

“I suppose not,” Lady Morrigan said, looking away, a slight embarrassment at her flustered state being so obvious. “That would be another’s doing entirely.”

“Mmm.”

Junia did not withdraw her hand. If anything, it only traveled further up along her side, reaching the edge of her breast as it lightly grazed it. “She has good taste.”

Lady Morrigan found herself wondering, looking back at Junia. *She?*

“I saw you dance with her. For a while I couldn’t tear my eyes off you.”

Junia’s hand then found its way to Morrigan’s cheek, her thumb brushing away a loose strand of Lady Morrigan’s dark hair. The touch lingered, and her fingers traced the line of her jaw.

They were both silent as Lady Morrigan wondered where it would go next. She waited with bated breath as it went along the curve of her throat with an intimacy and slowness that made her breath hitch.

“You know, you belong in one of these canvases, painted like the two gazing at the sun bare.” Her gaze pointed towards the painting Morrigan herself had made, and Junia’s fingers found their way to Lady Morrigan’s collarbone, then rested there, feeling her pulse. “I would shed similar tears at that sight, and we’d find ourselves back here again.”

Lady Morrigan covered Junia’s hand with her own, stopping it from wandering further. The thoughts of impropriety and boundaries had long gone, and now, she feared that if she’d let her touch her there, it would be the end of all things. She’d find herself using this woman for her own pleasure.

And she couldn't bear to remove them either. She just held the hands there, holding them against her chest where her heart hammered.

"I wouldn't want to be the subject of a canvas as much as I'd be behind it, Junia. After all, beauty needs to be captured, and just as I painted them, yours would need to be handled so that you'd see yourself as you are; a woman in your own right, beauteous and resplendent."

Junia quivered in shock, "You painted them...? You're...you're Lady Morrigan! *THAT* Morrigan!"

Morrigan nodded, smiling at the woman's enthusiasm.

"*Dynasty of the Sun, Third Day of Her Fever!*?" Then, without waiting for a response, she let go of Lady Morrigan entirely, moving towards the painting with the man and woman looking towards the sun on a tower, naked and painted from behind. Her withdrawal made Lady Morrigan feel strangely bereft. "*Beau and Auclair!* That's by you!"

Junia moved to stand before *Beau and Auclair*, her back to Lady Morrigan, her shoulders straightening.

"Paint me," she said, then turned, the want and hunger in her gaze now readily apparent. She moved back towards her, bowing low towards Morrigan in the settee. She took Lady Morrigan's hands damp with her tears in both of her own and pressed her lips to Lady Morrigan's knuckles. "Paint me like you did them! Oh!" Her tongue flicked out, just barely, tasting the salt of her grief on Lady Morrigan's skin.

"Make me worthy of desire," Junia whispered against her hands. "If anyone can conjure beauty, my lady, it is you, with these hands." She laid another kiss on the top of her fingers, just below the knuckles.

Lady Morrigan's pulse hammered, her hand still warm from Junia's lips, her chest still damp with her tears, and her body still

thrumming with unfulfilled need. “My brush would but tell the truth, and beauty would be found there regardless.”

Junia straightened, her smile turning genuine, pleased. “Then let us arrange it soon.”

But she didn’t step back. Her hands was still entwined with Lady Morrigan’s fingers, and her eyes dried with tears brimmed again.

“I don’t know why,” Junia breathed. “but I can’t let go.”

She swayed forward, her face pressing into Lady Morrigan’s shoulder once more, as Lady Morrigan felt her almost fall onto her in the settee. Her tears came harder, and this time the grief was joined in with a deeper, more carnal yearning as she buried her nose in the nape of Lady Morrigan’s neck, and she felt her own at Junia’s. She breathed her scent in and found a sudden urge to lay a kiss there or perhaps take in an aroma that felt hot and humid.

Then her hands let go, and she clung to Lady Morrigan for balance, and sank into her, her face falling to Morrigan’s chest, just above her heart where Junia had shed her tears previously. The hot spill of tears renewed their damp path down her bodice, and she felt her own control fraying.

Junia’s breath was dangerously close now to her own heart.

This was too much—Junia’s almost-unconscious seeking and once again wandering hands were just an accumulation of what this entire night had entailed. Even before the gala, it was Paulette, then the mysterious woman who made her truly feel the itch of desire, and now Junia, this strange, uncanny woman crying against her breast, craving her without knowing why.

She was drowning in it. Her body ached with a ferocity that made her dizzy. Everything the night had brought was braiding together into a single, overwhelming craving.

“Junia,” she whispered, as she felt the woman’s quivers quiet down, wet, slick sounds coming from her chest as her face shifted, eyes gazing straight on Lady Morrigan’s chest. Junia’s lips parted slightly, as if still in indecision whether to make that final, single movement.

“Junia.” Lady Morrigan whispered again, her voice rough with want she could not hide. She ran her fingers through Junia’s hair, reaching the back of her head, and almost subconsciously pushed her down onto her breasts.

And Junia’s lips involuntarily landed, and she closed them there, kissing the same wetness where her tears had been.

“Junia!” Lady Morrigan cupped at her face with both hands, and brought it towards her, pulling Junia away.

But it only made the situation worse for her when her eyes met Junia’s.

Her face was wet, her pupils blown wide and dark. She did not speak, only stared, and Lady Morrigan felt Junia’s thumb tracing her lower lip with trembling reverence. Her body was leaning into her, their breaths mingling together, and a hand was brought to the wetness on her chest.

She felt Junia’s palm graze her nipples through her gown as she rested her own hand atop hers. She just held it there, and the rest of Junia in suspended animation where the only movement was their breathing and the loud sound of hammering hearts and pulses from them both. Junia’s lips parted, and she leaned in.

“I should return before I’m missed.” Lady Morrigan said, finally, turning her head away and clearing her throat.

“But I don’t want you to...” Junia said, her fingers still clutching onto Lady Morrigan’s lips, then stopped. “I want...” she leaned in again, and placed a kiss on Lady Morrigan’s turned cheek, though she kept her lips there, lingering.

“You are grieving, miss.” Lady Morrigan took both of Junia’s hands and held them together. “And my head swims with uncertainty at all that’s happened tonight. It is not often that ill judgement paired together creates anything regrettable on the morrow.”

With visible effort, she stepped back. “I would escort you back to the ballroom, miss, if it weren’t...” Lady Morrigan gulped. “Let us arrange for your portrait. You can think about a name for it in the meantime.”

Then she was gone, leaving Junia alone.

Just a day prior, Lady Morrigan had been scoffing at yet another empty gesture sent her way in the form of a bouquet of beautiful wild roses, the very idea of love and love-making far from her mind as it only housed thoughts of ill futures with boring misers.

And now, she had three who would take her to bed and chair and garden and wall, and everywhere else love could be made. It did not matter just how different each of them were—only that it had made her more ravenous than she had ever been in her entire life.

IV

The wall-torch on the far edge of the hallway had been sabotaged, and Lady Morrigan proceeded towards it. It marked that she was on the right path.

The hallway veered left, and some of the torch scones were angled in a type of way, enough for her to notice, and know where to go.

She continued onward and stopped at a door just near a burnt-out torch-light. The door was left ajar, unlatched, and she smelt something unfamiliar. Salty, arid scents. Like the shore or a beach. The scent was new, though every other aspect of that door pointed towards her being in the right place.

This one's it.

Lady Morrigan entered through the door, darkness engulfing most of the room. Only the faint light from the hallway outside was present in a thin strip. The light from the door was just enough for her to notice the tall shelves and boxes in the room.

Lady Morrigan reached one end of the room, and turned a corner, past where one of the shelves would obscure her from view if someone entered.

The scent grew stronger and stronger as she neared, walking slowly to the edge of the darkness in the corner.

It was just before Lady Morrigan felt herself being pushed against the wall, a sudden shift of something strong and firm against her, putting her out of breath, and the feeling of a thin, prickly blade grazing at her throat. She smelled salt on her nose, and the air felt damp.

“One should be careful following strangers into dark places.” The voice was low and muffled, spoken through a darkened filigree voixer-mask. She knew the sound already, where it came from.

Morrigan breathed in as she felt the needle-blade press harder, and her hands were twisted and caught—she was unable to move.

“I adore dark places.” Lady Morrigan responded, feeling the prickle of the needle as she spoke, each movement causing a sharp tingle at her throat. “My favorite strangers lurk there.”

“Oh, am I a favorite?” The voice asked.

Lady Morrigan couldn’t help but giggle, even as the blade remained where it was. “I don’t know. Are you a stranger?”

“I’d want to be both today, for the sake of convenience.”

The blade immediately left the vicinity of her throat, and she felt a touch on her shoulder in the darkness.

“Have news for me, Syona?”

“That, I do, Morrigan.”

Lady Morrigan had expected her to take off that device, to let off her mask and step elsewhere, where she could see her. She could never get used to the way Syona disguised her voice, how, at times, she seemed more mysterious than necessary. Right now was one such moment. These tricks and games of subterfuge hardly seemed prudent. At times, it felt like Syona did it simply because she could.

“Are you going to deliver it here? In the dark?”

“On that, I might have to insist. Urgent matters call me elsewhere, but the news was dire enough that I needed to deliver it.”

“Ahem. Very well, then.”

She felt the air shift as Syona backed away slightly, giving her some more space. Not being able to see did have its disadvantage, though Syona did it often enough that it had become their own little game. Still, it was something Lady Morrigan *allowed* to happen. She knew her spy would be a lot more accommodating if she ever commanded it.

“It’s the doctor. She’s hiding something.”

“We’re all hiding something, as you seem to be at the moment.”

“I haven’t put my face on, milady.”

“Oh? Been busy have you? Who’s the lucky...?”

“Ah. Not what I meant.”

There was a brief pause as Lady Morrigan felt Syona move to her side, the salty fragrance and seaweed moving along with her.

“No, I mean...the doctor lady is hiding something in her estate. Something dangerous.”

“Doctor Junia?”

“That’s the one.”

“What sort of something is she hiding?”

“She’s a natural philosopher by most counts, but by my reports, there are rumblings of something unnatural going on in her estate.”

“I saw her after the gala. I wasn’t expecting her to be so young, though her face didn’t seem right.”

Syona did not address that statement. “There have been strange lights and sounds from her labs.”

“Par for the course for a doctor of natural philosophy, Syona.”

“Yes, but these noises are heard at her estate.”

“Then what must I do? She’s asked me to paint her portrait soon.”

“Be wary, and vigilant, Morrigan. That’s all I can say for now.”

V

Lady Morrigan arrived in a silken gown of midnight-Prussian blue, the neckline plunging to reveal her pale skin across the bust. The gown was slit on both sides of the skirt to expose her legs with each step. The slits were asymmetrical, one high above her thigh, and the other just below the knee. Her dark crimson locks were arranged in loose waves for the day, and a lone silver-chained necklace adorned her neck, its pendant disappearing beneath the fabric at the bustline.

Junia met her at the door, her uncannily and strangely youthful appearance standing out against her red-green dress, her stormy eyes widening as she set her sights on Lady Morrigan, traveling the length of her form with undisguised appreciation. Junia's eyes lingered on the exposed line of her collarbone, and her prominent bust pushed up in an extra-flattering manner, and the necklace that was altogether inviting.

"I had witnessed your beauty, Morrigan," she breathed through each word. "But I had forgotten the true extent of your sultry comeliness."

"I will sooner be stripped of all my comeliness if you dress me in an unflattering gown, Junia, though I must admit I forgot our meeting

was for painting. I haven't brought any change of clothes. Or paint, for that matter."

"We can find what you need at the workshop," Junia said, her eyes not meeting Morrigan's and still gazing at the rest of her form. "As for your attire, I'll have something fetched for you. A pauper's clothes they will be, and you will look all the more enticing."

With hurried steps, she led Morrigan to an atelier. It was a drafty, high-ceilinged wing of Junia's demesne, perched above grey-glass waters and a large storeroom underneath. She saw all sorts of garden tools and crafting apparatus in that room as they climbed a central staircase that led up to the workshop, where there was light.

A retainer brought some clothes to Junia, who promptly handed them over to Morrigan.

"There is a dividing screen." She pointed to a corner of the workshop. "You can change there, for privacy."

There was a large mirror in the wall just beside the screen, offset slightly, whether by intention or not, it did not matter. Lady Morrigan saw herself in the mirror, and in the reflection, she saw Junia looking right at her, unabashed and hungry. They locked eyes, and neither looked away.

Lady Morrigan turned slightly, angling her back towards the mirror as her gaze remained fixed on the glass. Beside Junia was an easel and a few paints, next to the atelier's windows. She began to arrange the brushes by the window, absentmindedly and unhurried in her demeanor. On occasion, Junia had to feel around the windowpane for a brush or a paint, as her eyes remained there, on Lady Morrigan, moving only to stare at the rest of her.

Lady Morrigan could have shifted herself slightly, but she stayed where she was, letting Junia see her fully in that silvered glass, feeling the weight of her gaze touch her delicate skin. She reached behind her

back, her fingers finding the fastenings of her gown. The brush in Junia's hand had stilled. Her lips were parted slightly, and her breath was visible as a soft mist in the cool air.

She unfastened the first hook, and she saw Junia perk up with a sharp intake of breath. Then the next hook gave way and another. One by one, the fastenings gave way, and with each, Junia's eyes darkened. Lady Morrigan saw her gulp in her throat, saw the color rise to her cheeks.

The gown loosened, and it slid from her shoulders with agonizing slowness, the midnight-blue silk catching on the curve of her arms. Then Lady Morrigan turned, facing the mirror, and let the gown fall the rest of the way, putting herself on display. It caught in her breasts, held up momentarily by her sensitive nipples, before it dropped to her hips, and finally pooled at her feet in a whisper.

Slowly, Morrigan stepped out of it, standing in her chemise and stockings, the thin cotton doing little to obscure her shapely features.

Junia had stopped pretending to arrange brushes. Her hand now held onto the windowpane, the other reaching for her chest and lingering there, aching to touch. and her eyes locked in the mirror, on the reflection of Morrigan standing nearly bare behind the screen, returning her hungry gaze with a longing of her own.

Lady Morrigan reached for the paint clothes Junia had given her—a frilled cotton shirt, grey trousers, and a smock—folded on a nearby chair. She held Junia's gaze as she lifted the shirt and then let her chemise slide from her shoulders. For a moment, she stood in nothing but her stockings and the silver chain around her throat. She saw Junia lean into the windowpane and use the hand she had been supporting herself with to now reach for her thighs.

Junia had worn a beautiful crimson and forest-green dress with a corset and frilled skirt. It would have been impossible for her to reach where she wanted without significant ruffling.

How cruel, Morrigan thought.

Before she put on her shirt, Lady Morrigan took her breasts in her hands and pressed them together, and extracted a longing, needy moan from Junia, who caught herself just in time. It had been loud, uncontrollably loud, and a smile formed itself around Lady Morrigan's lips as the shirt found its way around her, causing Junia to whimper.

Then, when Lady Morrigan put on the rest of her ensemble and put the smock around her, she saw that it had laces that reached behind her, like an apron, and buttons at the front as well. She fastened the buttons, but when she reached for the laces, she felt a hand grab hers.

"Here, let me." Junia had suddenly appeared behind her, and her eyes were on the laces of the smock. She reached the laces around Lady Morrigan, pressing herself to her back, letting her feel Junia's breasts squeezed into her back. Then she tied the thick lace into a bow, and once the smock was fastened, stayed there.

"You were wrong." She said, her breath hot on the back of Lady Morrigan's neck. "In this unflattering attire, all illusions are removed, and your beauty shines through unrestricted." She ran a single finger through Lady Morrigan's shoulders and to her arms. "A personification of divine substance."

"You flatter me." Lady Morrigan said, looking at Junia. There was a tremor in Junia's lower lips, a flush on her cheeks even more apparent than when she was all the way back towards the window.

"I state fact," she answered. Her chest was rising and falling with quick, shallow breaths. The low cut of her bodice was doing little to

hide how her breasts rose and fell with each intake and exhale of breath. “You bring a familiar feeling to me, Lady Morrigan. One long past and near forgotten.”

Junia’s hand moved to hover near Morrigan’s waist. At first, they lingered there, never touching, as if seeking permission. Then when Lady Morrigan did not pull away, they settled against her hip, pressing into it, her thumb tracing the sharp bone beneath the fabric.

Her other hand came up around Lady Morrigan, her fingers coming up to find the open collar of Morrigan’s smock, playing with the top button. “May I?” she whispered with a rough, hoarse voice.

Lady Morrigan turned around, finding Junia’s gaze, and then nodded silently. Her breath came short, her caution fraying with each passing second. *Am I going to give myself to this woman?* she asked herself.

Junia unfastened the first button, her knuckles brushing against Lady Morrigan’s skin. Then the next, and the next. Her fingers trembled as she pushed the smock open, revealing the cotton shirt beneath, its collar open the shirt unlaced. Morrigan’s bust was on display from the middle, along the length of the hollow of her throat and the edge of her collarbone. Junia licked her lips involuntarily.

Her palms reached inside the smock, but over her shirt, and her palm lay against Lady Morrigan’s breast, right by her heart. She just placed it there, without gripping or holding or kneading.

“I feel your heart.” She said, and her thumb reached the inside of the shirt that lay bare, grazing Morrigan’s breast. “It’s beating as fast as mine.” The fingers on her hips curled, gripping and pulling Morrigan closer.

Lady Morrigan felt both their heat in the proximity, mixed with the desperation in her touch. She found her own hands moving—deliberately and cautiously, but moving, nonetheless. She reached for

Junia's waist, her fingers finding the green-red silk, sliding upward to rest against the curve of her ribs, before they reached her breast and the open, low-cut bust of her dress.

Mirroring how Junia held on to her, Morrigan placed a hand on her heart, but almost instinctively grabbed at the fullness of her breast, drawing out a sharp breath from Junia.

"Yes," Junia breathed. "Touch me. I have forgotten what it feels like, and you, my lady, remind me so well of how he used to."

Junia's body arched into the touch, her hand gripping Morrigan's hips tighter, and the palm on her breast squeezing, reaching inside her frilled shirt to feel skin on skin.

The paints lay forgotten by the windowpane as the two women kneaded each other, feeling each other's heartbeats. "More," Junia whispered, her stormy eyes wildly staring into Morrigan's golden browns. "Please, I need...*more!* *Ummpph!*"

Junia surged forward, her mouth finding Lady Morrigan's throat, her lips hot and open against her pulse. Lady Morrigan took in a sharp, deep breath as Junia's teeth grazed at her, and her tongue tasted the heat of her flesh, the little beads of sweat that had begun to form in spite of the cold.

Morrigan's head fell back, and a moan escaped her as her hand snaked its way inside of Junia's dress to feel bare flesh herself, too. She pulled Junia into her, and the doctor put her hands around Morrigan's waist, sliding her thigh between Morrigan's legs. Her heavy dress was still in the way, and friction was fleeting.

"Kiss me," Junia said, breathing into her neck. "I haven't been so alive since...*oh!*"

Lady Morrigan grabbed Junia's hair and pulled her back, revealing the length of her neck. Her lips pressed into Junia's heated skin, kissing her neck, letting her tongue lay a wet trail through it, moving

lower. She reached her collarbone, and Junia moaned, before her hands migrated to Lady Morrigan's hair. Both women breathed into each other's lips, their mouths hovering with but nary an inch of distance, lips parted. Both of them were trembling with heat, frozen, the cold of the atelier completely forgotten as they remained suspended in that almost-touch.

"Please." Junia whispered. Lady Morrigan felt Junia's lips graze against her own as she spoke, and she ran her tongue through her lips, wetting them in preparation for what might come next.

And then, a scream fractured the relative serenity of the workshop, followed by the jagged screaming and neighing of a horse trotting away in terror.

It came from the manor.

Junia's hands instantly left Morrigan. "Stay here, do not leave!" she pleaded with urgency, and darted.

The swiftness with which Junia moved towards the stairway, ran down below and out the door of the workshop and onto the cobblestone pathway was almost legendary. Her heavy-set gown was almost weightless in the way she nimbly ran.

After a brief pause to gather her senses and take stock of all that had occurred in such a short span of time, Lady Morrigan took after the doctor.

She followed the doctor through the pathways out of the workshop and into the manor. Even for a woman on the shorter side, she was moving at blazing speed, and despite her heavy frilled skirt, too. Junia lifted it in her hands as she ran. Lady Morrigan had trouble keeping up with her in her trousers, even.

Approaching the manor's postern door, Lady Morrigan paused, taking in a breath, steadied herself, and went through the manor's back entrance.

The manor's interior walls were curtained, the light being just low enough that one could see, but a book would be worth no more than a paperweight unless a candle or torchlight was handy nearby. The servants' entrance to the manor had led her to a small corridor, with plenty of doors in between, presumably for storage, pantries, and the like. Before she could fully grasp her surroundings, though, she heard crashing and glass breaking, and the loud *thud* of a large object or a body landing heavily on the marbled-tiled floor.

Lady Morrigan's eyes tried to pierce through the darkened hallway, to get used to the gloom of the corridor, but in the next moment, the shadows at the far end of the hall coalesced and surged forward with terrifying speed. A large shape of a man, impossibly large, filled the narrow space. It moved frantically and with inhuman swiftness, yet the walk almost seemed clumsy, a lurching gait that only added to the fearful and horrific nature of those alien movements.

Before she could even form a scream, the thing was upon her, launching itself at her with the seeming strength of a bull. Lady Morrigan braced, within the moment readying herself for the impact of a battering ram to land against her, ready for the crushing weight and splintering of bone against hard stone and marble.

As that moment of truth came, she felt herself floating in the air.
Is this...am I...

The thought didn't finish. Instead, her mind was distracted by the touch of something vast and surprisingly cool, and something textured like a mixture of smooth wax and the coarseness of scars, close around her upper arm. There was no violence in that touch, no *thud* or push.

A hand.

In one, fluid and *powerful* motion, she was lifted off her feet, as if she weighed nothing at all, and sat down gently to the side of the corridor.

And then she felt the air shift, and a sudden warmth engulfed her as the *thing* passed, almost squeezing through, the body of whatever it was touching her.

It all lasted a second. Maybe two. Or perhaps more. The moment felt like a surreal suspension of time, and Lady Morrigan opened her eyes, her spatial awareness completely lost, her vision darkened with heavy static as she attempted to balance herself against the stone walls. The thing, that creature, whatever it was, was gone.

Lady Morrigan remained frozen, her heart hammering against her ribs.

What was that? And why did it...

She felt as if that thing still had its hand on her arm, a vice grip that was somehow gentle and reassuring, telling her that it didn't want to hurt her. Her arm surged with the jolt of static electricity, impossible in its intensity in the way it almost took over her body. The sensation went through her arm and to her core, and she put her hand where she felt it, right before that sensation found its home between her...

"Lady Morrigan, are you alright?!"

The doctor's voice, sharp with alarm, interrupted her as it cut through the haze of heaviness. Loud footsteps echoed in the narrow corridor as she came running, complete with an entourage of torch-wielding men. Guards and foot soldiers, they looked like, clad in armor and battle-gear, the iron-made chainmail and plating clattering and clacking against each other as the group ran towards her.

I did not hear any footsteps when he...it...

"You're shaking."

Doctor Junia scanned the darkness where the creature had fled, stopping when she approached Lady Morrigan, seeing her chest heaving and her face flushed in the light of their bright torches.

“Did it...are you hurt?”

The words had seemed like a correction, and the latter question did not seem like it was borne of real concern.

Lady Morrigan only shook her head, still struggling to compose herself. She was trying to force an expression of terror on her face, almost attempting to mask the way she felt with fear.

“We should try and follow, miss, before more chaos ensues. Form up, lads!” The guard-captain shouted, the sound almost too loud for the hallway, and in a single file they marched onwards, turning sideways as they passed Lady Morrigan.

The doctor stayed behind.

“Did you see anything?”

The question seemed like a warning, and grieving woman she had met back at the gala’s painting room vanished. Everything was in her low, accusatory tone, full of malice and the promise of consequence should the answer to that question be construed as anything but the single truth that she wanted that encounter to become.

Lady Morrigan steadied herself as she looked at Junia. The torch-lights had gone with the guards, whom Lady Morrigan could hear opening doors and peering through, scanning each room and confirming that it was absent of...*it*.

Yet even in the darkness, those storm-grey eyes forced a calm she did not feel.

“I don’t know. It was dark, and it happened so fast. A shadow, mostly.”

It was the truth, well, almost. She did catch a glimpse of a greenish-white *thing* as it had approached her, right before she closed her eyes.

It looked like a man, too, clad in tattered clothes, though it moved like each of its limbs were independent of each other. Whatever it was, clearly, the doctor would want it kept secret, even if it meant dispatching one particular painter—and Lady Morrigan was the kind of person who'd disappear on occasion, shutting herself off from the world, sometimes within her own estate painting for months on end, imagining a world beyond their own.

“I see,” Junia said. “One of the servants will fetch you and see you safely home.” There was a strangeness to her demeanor, completely removed from the enticement and longing she had for Morrigan back at the workshop. There was danger in her demeanor, and Lady Morrigan felt afraid—not of the thing, but of her.

That was all that the doctor said, before she, too, went off from where Lady Morrigan had come in, beyond the postern gate, and out into the estate gardens.

She had planned on painting her today, to be cautious, to not be so brash and reckless. She remembered Syona's warning, a warning forgotten back at the atelier.

But as the doctor went off, the feeling that remained in Lady Morrigan wasn't fear. That's not what had made her so flustered. It wasn't even how she had been on the verge of laying her lips on the woman she now felt threatened by.

Not one bit.

VI

Lady Morrigan always looked forward to her escapes from the world of exactitude and royal vulgarity that elitism brought with it and being able to enjoy the fresh morning air without having to keep her back straight or her hands clasped together was quite welcome.

Still, it wasn't completely freeing, being hooded and hidden as she rode on with a shirt, trousers, and boots that went all the way up to her knees. This was her comfort clothing, much more preferred to corsets and bodice, though even covered and hooded she turned quite a few heads.

"My lady, you'd bring life and sensual enticement wearing a potato sack." Paulette would say, and she'd answer, "Only because this dress was your selection, Pauli."

She took her at times in her treks to the seamstress and tailors, where she'd get herself fitted and measured to craft something new. Paulette's gaze on her would be anything but subtle, though she knew her lady-in-waiting would desperately try and keep it less obvious. She did not know that Lady Morrigan knew of every stolen glance. Even now, she looked over to her more often than the road itself.

But this morning, she didn't find relaxation as she usually did. Paulette rode next to her, her chestnut warmblood trotting alongside Lady Morrigan's own black cob.

Thump-trot, thump-trot, thump-trot went their hooves, a rhythmic sound against the dirt and stone roads they rode along. These rides were meditative, a sort of metronome of freedom for her, but this morning they matched the beat of her heart, the flow of her pulse as it rushed through her chest and throat. The scent of pine and earth was thin, and Morrigan felt weightless, floaty and ungrounded.

Her mind traitorously refused to be in the present, slipping back to the people she thought about quite often now, and her mind started taking her heart along with it.

She hadn't clearly seen his face but had *felt* him. In the dark hallway his silhouette was darker still, and that mountain of what seemed to be flesh should have inspired terror. It did...only for the moment right before he touched her. She was locked in that primordial feeling of being afraid and on the brink of death, the mind and the heart deciding whether to accept death or to fight it, and her wetness deciding otherwise.

But when he touched her, when he took her up effortlessly, that was a man who knew how to handle power.

So smooth and suave they deemed themselves to be, the men of the court, and the ones asking for her company and companionship, not often in that order. So polished their demeanors were, but she always felt examined under their gaze, assessed for her worth and title and connections. They were the superficial kind of men, all flair and nothing else.

What was *he*?

He had the strength that could tear men limb from limb, yet it handled her gently. The beast would be a primal spirit made real and

would thus carry the desires of flesh. He would want no estate, no title or deed. He would want—no, *need*—only her, and his would be a vast, bottomless need, a longing pure and insatiable that would want to gorge on whatever flesh it found, and Lady Morrigan’s own would be the first and only one it would ever lay its desires upon. Time after time, again and again, the beast would attempt to drink from that proverbial chalice, to try and sate that thirst, and he would remove himself from her for a fleeting moment before need struck and he’d be at her again, and Lady Morrigan herself all too willing to be taken with his wild fervor.

A flush crept up her neck, warming the skin beneath the fabric of her shirt.

That brutality that it was capable of would command her to be *his* and his entirely, yet she’d calm it down, grip it gently and make it whole. She’d have him whisper where he would scream, and have him make love where he would be tearing off her clothes and...

“We’re here, Morrigan.”

Lady Morrigan felt herself shift in her saddle, the friction of their halt a sudden, sharp distraction. Paulette was looking at her expectantly, herself ready to dismount. Her cob tossed its head, and Morrigan blinked as shape of their destination almost faded into her hazy view.

I don’t even know if that thing is real, or a man even, and I’m already...

She felt a tap on her leg. Paulette was looking up to her on the horse, her crystal-blue eyes staring unabashedly. If she’d been back home, in her bedchamber staring at those eyes, she’d have brought them to where she needed touch most.

A good thing I’m not, then. Anyone would find it difficult to draw themselves away from those wide eyes, from those lips, and from the tongue concealed behind them.



Paulette had fetched the spare key from the innkeeper and as Lady Morrigan entered the room, she saw the unmistakably beautiful figure of her spy sitting atop a table, feet perched on the chair with both hands under her chin, supporting herself as she was deep in thought.

She wore what Lady Morrigan had always seen her in, dark clothes meant for outdoor travel, loose and comfortable, though they did little to hide the woman's strength, evidenced by her well-built physique. Her curly dark hair was gathered in a bun yet bathed in the light. She always somehow looked to be more beautiful with each meeting, and Lady Morrigan's current state did little to dissuade her thoughts.

Rid it from your mind! Syona's a friend!

What is Paulette then?

You have enough prospects!

Her mind battled against itself, fighting against this new desire that had settled between her legs, ever-present since that gala and always seeking satisfaction.

Woodsmoke and pale ale permeated the room, the aroma coming in from the inn's air, invading even the private rooms. A few candles were the only source of illumination, and yet they illuminated the hovel in light. A single, large bed, a table and a few chairs, a dresser and a storage chest. Little else was needed in such places.

“Morrig—” Syona began to greet her, a soft, singing voice when done so without the coverings of a voixer-mask, but gave pause as soon as she laid eyes her accompanying woman, bright amethyst eyes staring at the poor girl as if she’d tear through her.

Not unusual for a spy to be prudent even when unnecessary. Good.

“It’s quite alright, Syona. If you can trust me, you can trust Pauli here. Think of her as my better half.”

Syona got up from the table and sat herself on one of the chairs, while Lady Morrigan and Paulette joined her at the opposite end.

Syona looked Paulette over, examining her closely as Paulette gave her a meek wave. Then with a curt nod, the spy began, looking towards Morrigan. “I’m beginning to get reports that may corroborate a few rumors.”

“*May?* Can’t you be sure?”

“It is difficult to get truthful witness accounts, and the staff is rarely helpful in this matter. It seems they know very little of what goes on there, and less still of Junia herself. They do have a curiously similar line, though, almost rehearsed, about the doctor’s pursuits being too complex for them to understand.”

Syona took a little cigarillo from a pouch and lit it with one of the candles on the table. Paulette coughed as the smoke filled the room, her eyes falling low as if her discomfort might offend the spy.

“I see. What do the rumors say, then?” Lady Morrigan asked.

“They claim that the doctor has actually done it—create...life, if you can believe it.”

“Women can often do that.”

“Not like this, Morrigan.”

“You mean to say...?”

“Yes. Life to a...something. A patchwork of remains.”

The words paled Lady Morrigan as the blood drained from her face, and the secret heat in her belly turned to ice. There was a thrill to her fantasies so far, wrapped in a shroud of sensual ambiguity. What she had encountered had seemed like a specter of sorts, a force of nature that she could bring to heel, taming it. So much she had imagined, and all of it involved her and the heat she had felt in that encounter, and in all of it, she imagined him thick and ready and waiting, and she'd take all of him in, repeatedly, without pause or concern for her own health or safety. For days she'd continue, and for days he'd go on for her sake, never stopping, a euphony of moans and groans the only conversation they would ever have from then on.

But a *corpse*? Was *that* what she encountered? Junia's failed—or perhaps even successful—experiment? She had half imagined it to be a man, just one that was uniquely burly yet gentle, an exemplar of irony as this hulking presence showcased remarkable restraint in the way he swayed her about in that hallway.

A dead thing given motion, cobbled together...have I been lusting after a cadaver?

But as soon as the thought entered her brain, that fire in her belly lit up again, and the terrible edge of her desire only sharpened. *Perhaps that is the only method in which men can seem desirable to me. Meat-things. Walking corpses.*

"Milady." Paulette immediately shifted closer. "Are you unwell?" Her hand fluttered towards Morrigan's arm, desperate to offer comfort. Syona, too, looked at her with concern.

"Is something the matter, Morrigan?" The spy asked.

Morrigan took a ragged breath. "I think...I think I saw it."

Syona immediately got up from her seat, and Paulette's hand went to Lady Morrigan's leg, lightly grabbing at her thigh.

"Where? Did it hurt you?" the young woman asked.

Morrigan put her hand over Paulette's and gave it a reassuring squeeze as she looked towards Syona. "Not at all."

She recounted the events at the doctor's estate, about Junia and her uneasiness back at the workshop, and about the encounter with that...creature. "We need to see it, Syona. I need to see it."

"No, milady—" Lady Morrigan looked towards Paulette soon as she protested, who quieted down under Lady Morrigan's gaze.

"She's right." Syona glanced at Paulette. "We should stay away, my lady. Be safe from such things."

"We *should* stay away, yes." Morrigan agreed, giving Syona a knowing look.

"But will we?" the spy asked.

Lady Morrigan smiled, and Syona closed her eyes. The spy knew that this was one of those moments that it was useless to argue against her, an understanding Lady Morrigan appreciated greatly about her. Lady Morrigan herself had given Syona much in terms of leeway. She never addressed her by her moniker, had complete freedom to pin her against walls, dagger by the neck, all without an iota of consequence. She was her trusted friend, and on occasion, Lady Morrigan would ask for a return of such favors, blind trust, even if it meant a little risk to her own life.

'For how long will you spy on boring misers and overtly prudent and prudish women, Syona?'

"Is that how you think I spend my time of leisure?"

"Is it not?"

The spy lowered her eyes in a smile, but Paulette grabbed at her thigh even tighter. The touch made Lady Morrigan quiver. Now was not the place nor the time, or else she'd have requested her lady-in-waiting to settle her hands a bit further up, and a few degrees her way.

She had never asked such a thing, but she knew Paulette would never refuse her.

Lady Morrigan took a gentle hand to Paulette's chin. "You'll go home, Pauli, and be safe. We'll rendezvous back home before dawn." The young woman became a deep, dark red under the candlelight, failing in her attempts to hide her smile.

"We'll leave soon as it gets dark." The spy told her. "I have come to know of a way inside that we can use."

VII

The entrance to the little tunnel-pathways—at least one of the entrances—was hidden behind a false panel in the wine cellar. It was outside of the estate, kept below an otherwise inconspicuous garden shed.

It looked to be the doctor's private collection from afar, but closer inspection pointed towards the possibility of it being a sort of refuse storage for later disposal.

The bottles across most of the shelves looked like any other wine container, but there were the ones behind them that sparked suspicion. The bottles were all unrecognizable, though the liquids were kept in wine bottles. Some had a strange color that seemed ungainly and disgusting. A few looked to have a slimy texture that was altogether unappealing. A peculiar choice for wine it would have been should anyone had assumed that it was wine to begin with, even if so for a personal, curated collection.

“We only were able to identify a few.” Syona told her as she showed Lady Morrigan the exact combination of steps to safely open the panel under torch light. “Just about impossible without tampering with it in some way. We found three bottles of Eszencia before we found the panel for the entrance.”

It had revealed a network of narrow, unlit passages that ran like veins through the estate's foundations. They would have to travel quite a bit of distance on foot to even get to the estate.

"I've yet to map out these tunnels, but they're quite vast. I'm not sure if we'll even find what we're looking for."

They had both changed into simple, dark clothing; a shirt and trousers that allowed them maneuverability and the subterfuge capability they needed.

These sorts of late-night treks were not usual for Lady Morrigan, though this wasn't her first foray into this side of the world, either. She had gone with Syona on one such occasion before, following a member of the military aristocracy through the streets. It was almost laughable, the way that military-man had forgone any semblance of self-preservation or personal security, completely ignorant of the two women that followed in seemingly inconspicuous cloaks. He had separated himself from his entourage, and had made himself quite busy being 'tended to' by a man whose house he had excitedly run towards. In any other circumstance, she would have enjoyed spying on such an encounter, yet this man, she knew, was one of those that didn't practice what they preached. That information had been paramount in the ensuring that Lady Morrigan's estate received less 'official correspondences' from two of his subordinates. It had relieved Lady Morrigan of two quite irritable men who had been dogging her for her company for quite a while.

Lady Morrigan peered inside the tunnel, only to see nothing but blackness. Syona held her by her arm, giving her pause, she looked back at the spy.

"You won't be able to see anything without...these."

From one of her hidden pockets, Syona produced two devices; leather-bound goggles. They were linked with darkened brass,

seemingly like a device a horologist would wear to repair timepieces. As Syona tilted it, the glass of the goggles caught the torch-light and Morrigan saw it was not glass at all. Behind their twin convex lenses, a thick, viscous fluid stirred. It was faintly bioluminescent, sporting a turbidity that seemed to pulse with a life of its own. It seemed to ‘hold’ a glow rather than cast it, the fluid trapped in a cold, alchemical statis.

“Ocular-Eyes, they’re called. One of René’s tools.”

René. The source of Syona’s equipment, an anonymous entity about whom Lady Morrigan knew little else. It was one of the things that Syona had asked Lady Morrigan to keep secret, and a secret that the spy never shared even with her. It could have been that this story was entirely Syona’s creation, even possible that Syona was René herself.

Perhaps she fashioned her own tools, hiding away her talents from those that might exploit them. It was a prudent decision, too, otherwise Lady Morrigan knew of a few ways someone like...René...would be instrumental in machining some of her paint-works.

“They will help you see in the dark without emitting a light of your own.”

“Will it? How so?”

“Give them a shake before you put them on. If you don’t, they are only useful in making you look sophisticated.”

“I look quite sophisticated without them, too.”

“That you do, Morrigan.”

Syona handed her the goggles, and grabbing them by their brass frames, Lady Morrigan wore them atop her eyes, tightening the leather straps.

“Here, let me.” Syona said from behind her, She pulled on a few straps, and put a gentle, reassuring hand on both of Lady Morrigan’s shoulders.

The moment the leather straps tightened, the darkness being replaced by a haunting, liquid illumination.

The pitch-black tunnel had transformed. Lady Morrigan saw thick, emerald fog, like seeing the breath along the ribbed throat of a huge, huge monster. The walls were glowing with a loud, sticky luminescence that seemed to vibrate against her vision.

Sharp, black silhouettes defined the edges of her path, and as she moved, her perspective warped. The ground moved like the deck of a ship as it liquid swirled with her own movement, the organisms inside the convex glass refusing to remain still.

“Be careful.” Syona said from behind her, and Lady Morrigan squealed.

“Aaaaahh!”

Syona instantly took hold of her as Lady Morrigan’s heart started racing, surprised at seeing the large, white-green silhouette of a person where the spy should have been.

“Syona!” she cried, before the spy caught her by the shoulders.

“It might take some time to get used to it.” Syona whispered to her. “No sudden movements, either. The liquid is rather limiting, but I fear we are at the limits of the possible by being able to see in the dark.”

“Of course.” Morrigan answered, gathering back her composure.

“You see the height of these tunnels...large enough for the two of us to stand abreast, too. The doctor uses it to move...the thing...through the grounds, I’d wager.”

“Mmmhmm.” Came the reply.

Large enough for him.

Lady Morrigan had been mostly quiet so far, making as many attempts as she could to convince herself that she was...

No!

‘What manner of lady dons the dark cloth and plays hide-and-sneak among another nobles house?’

I do! And with good reason!

‘The reason is the heat between your legs, you demimonde harlot!’

How dare you?!

‘All those years and have made yourself a hermit, attracted only the foulest of the foul, just like you!’

Shut up!

‘Why else would go so readily go there? Surely, you’d first consider the danger you’re putting yourself into, wouldn’t you? Instead, you saunter in, inconsiderate and brash as women like you will always be!’

Lady Morrigan took in a deep breath, the faint smell of wine still permeating the air as they moved through the tunnels.

‘We could have grabbed a bottle, Syona. It would make for pleasant company, even though I cherish yours, too.’

‘We could, but would defeat the purpose of all this sneaking about. We have to leave the place as we found it.’

‘A shame, then. My thoughts aren’t exactly sobering, and I could use a drink...or a hundred, depending on how many I need to calm my nerves.’

‘A thousand thoughts, I know.’ Syona said, chuckling. ‘We have a long walk ahead of us, and these tunnels have no ears for quite a while yet.’



“This way,” Syona whispered, her voice getting swallowed by the oppressive darkness. The air was thick with the smell of earth and mildew, and Lady Morrigan could hear the scuttling of unseen things in the walls. It was the only sound that wasn’t coming from the two of them.

The tinted colors through the goggles still felt alien to her. Even now, with tired legs after walking for who knows how long, Lady Morrigan still found it difficult to have solid footing. Almost off her own accord, she would slip, and Syona would have to assist her at times to get back her bearings.

“I fear the kind of feelings that he...*it*...awakened in me, Syona.”

“Do not fear your feelings, Morrigan. They’re part of you.”

“It feels wrong...”

“It might be.”

“Do you not find it apprehensive that I feel like so?”

“I have seen what people get up to. What your heart seems to want is nothing short of right in comparison.”

My heart! What do you know of what my heart wants, my sweet friend! It wants everything! I cannot help it.

“And has nobody else made you feel this way before?” the spy asked.

Lady Morrigan paused in her thoughts, her mind taking her to that one—to those several encounters that...

“Well, there were others quite recently, but—”

“*Shhh!*” Syona put a finger to Lady Morrigan’s lips, and she grabbed the spy’s hand in the same instant. “Voices, milady. We are nearing them.”

“I—apologies.” Syona added. “For...”

“Nonsense, Syona.” Lady Morrigan saw, lowering her voice even more, still clutching her hand. “Your familiarity with me is one I welcome most in our friendship. Others treat me too much as royalty.”

They emerged into a small, forgotten alcove behind a tapestry in the main hall. The light coming through the fabric made it almost impossible for them to see anything behind it. It was bright with the goggles on, and Syona tapped her shoulder, indicating to remove them.

The darkness returned, and a strange sense of vertigo claimed Lady Morrigan. Once more, Syona had to help her balance herself, before she composed and took another look at the tapestry. It was acting as a perfect veil for them to survey all across that large room, and remain perfectly hidden. The tapestry was placed several feet above the floor, too. Even if someone looked directly at them, they would not be seen.

From their vantage point, they could see the dining room. A large, long table was situated at the center, ending at the head where Junia sat. Across from the table at the end of the room was a large, grand staircase. Two others were situated in chairs along the long table. One was a man, what little part of his frame she saw was silhouetted, and the other was hidden by the tall-back chair. He sat with his back to the tapestry.

Syona might know who he is, she began to think to herself, right before her eyes landed on...*her*.

It was the woman from the gala, the one who had called her for a dance. The one who had made her feel not that different from how this creature was making her feel.

Today, she wore a dark burgundy red. The coat was worn over a black frilled shirt. Her hair was, once again, tied tightly in a bun behind her head.

“Junia.” The man said in a deep voice that had a growl to it. “I know the value of death. Some things should be kept so.”

“And what? You’d know about death, is it?” Junia asked, her voice slightly taunting. It was surprising for Lady Morrigan to hear Junia like this. There encounters so far—most of them—had made her to be far more...delicate.

“I know that rumors are spreading of what you’re doing here. You know more than most that secrecy is our blood and butter.” The arched ceilings of the dining hall amplified his voice, making sound more threatening, ominous.

“What exactly do the rumors say?” Junia asked, a softness returning to her voice that Lady Morrigan was more familiar with.

Then, the woman from the gala spoke. “These rumors say you’ve brought a man to life, doctor. They fail to mention he is *all* man, though.”

Lady Morrigan smiled, and heard a light giggle from Syona at her side. She looked over, and the spy was enraptured by the boldness of the woman.

And enraptured Lady Morrigan was, too. Even from this distance, she felt herself unable to keep her hands still, almost wanting to reach out and touch the woman-from-the-gala, to pull up a chair beside her and sit there. Or perhaps to dismiss all manners of boundary and

simply find her home in her lap, so that nothing would keep them from being close.

“Then what must I do? It is difficult enough as is, to be on the brink of what is and what we thought could not be.”

“Am I not evidence enough?” The man asked in a domineering tone.

“And all man, too.” The woman-from-the-gala added.

Junia cast an angry glare at the woman-from-the-gala, who only smiled.

“Who is that woman?” Lady Morrigan asked Syona. “The one in the dark red coat?”

“That would be Lady Goth. She’s...peculiar, to be sure.”

“Peculiar?”

“Not how I’d describe her, but people talk. Others have found her to be deliberately ignorant of social etiquette, often teetering at the edge of societal boundaries, for the lack of any better way to say it.”

“Sounds like my kind of woman.”

Syona smiled, but her attention was quickly taken by the voice of the man in the dining hall. “Junia, I implore you to be more careful. You know I want this as much as you do.”

There was a short pause before Junia spoke.

“And why do you want this, Lady Goth? I do understand you came with him, but Da—”

“I want what others cannot have, Junia, and there is plenty in this world that is denied them.” Lady Goth answered.

The man laughed, then slapped at his thighs. “As much as I’d prefer to stay and listen to Lady Goth fiercely defend her desires, I must take my leave. Duty and daylight calls me home.”

He then promptly got up and left, the darkness shrouding his face as he walked off the shadowed dining hall and out of sight.

“Do you wish to retire here for the night, Lady Goth? I do have spare rooms.”

Lady Goth got up and sauntered towards the fireplace in silence.

“Do you—” Junia began, but was cut off by Lady Goth.

“I’ll make my way to one of them in due time. For now, I do believe you are tired, Junia.”

The doctor didn’t respond. Instead, she got up from her chair, turned her back towards Lady Goth, and began to walk off.

“My Lady!” Syona whispered, clutching Lady Morrigan’s arm. “We should go as well.”

But Lady Morrigan didn’t want to leave just yet, or at least, she didn’t want to leave *her*.

“We should separate here, Syona. Follow the doctor. I’ll see to what this woman is up to.”

Syona looked at her. Even in the dim light, Lady Morrigan could tell that Syona questioned her statement at first but then began to sport a smirk.

“Go! It’s much more dangerous for me to be too near the doctor anyway, right?”

“Right.” The spy answered. She put a hand on the side of Lady Morrigan’s neck. “Be safe. We’ll meet back here.”

She seems surprisingly unaffected by me venturing off on my own.

But she had little time to think about that.

“We’ll meet back at my home. Come to me in the night of the full moon on the morrows.” Lady Morrigan said, nodding, putting a reassuring hand on top of the spy’s own, feeling its warmth leave her as Syona continued onward through the alcove towards another tunnel-path that continued, presumably towards where the doctor had gone off to.

VIII

Lady Goth stayed at the fireplace at the far end of the dining hall. She played with idle hands, almost waiting for something, before she began her stride towards one of the exits to the hall. Lady Goth made her way to the edge of the staircase before she took a turn and went to the side and pulled on a small wall sconce. It opened a side of the stone wall, the scraping sound of stone against stone surprisingly muffled in that large hall.

Lady Morrigan slipped from behind the tapestry and dropped down onto a stone ledge. It was then another small drop onto the stone floor.

She was moving already, her body acting almost as if on instinct. Any thought of danger or prudence was left behind in that dark tunnel behind the tapestry, the pull towards Lady Goth being too strong. It was an undeniable magnetic force that defied sense and logic.

What am I doing? She thought to herself as she slowly walked across the hall. Her footsteps were silent against the stone and occasional tiled marble patterns, each step launching her mind in a frenzy. Her thoughts fought against that increasingly familiar feeling.

She watched Lady Goth enter through that wall-hole and waited. Her heart was beating faster as she waited a few, torturously slow seconds, and followed her through. It could have been anything beyond that stone-walled-door. It could be a thousand men clad in armor, weapons in hand, waiting for her. It could be the entirety of Geneva on the other side, pointing a finger at her for attempting to spy on the doctor and being oh-so smitten with another woman. It could be Junia herself on the other side, ready to chide her for her intrusion in her home, not to mention for intruding on her secret...

As soon as she entered, the stone door closed tight behind her. *There must be a way out, too, a handle from the inside, surely.*

She had one of these rooms back at her own estate, one that entered from her own bedroom. It could be seen from the mirror of her dresser, a book on a small shelf that had its letters inversed, so that you could read the cover in the mirror as if one was looking right at it, without the reflection projecting a literal mirror-image.

The Miraculum Ostium, it said. Sometimes, what was in plain sight acted as a natural deterrent from spies.

I wonder if Syona knows about it. She thought. Even if the spy did, she wouldn't reveal it to her, would she?

The room or corridor she had entered was shrouded in darkness; a faint smell of mustiness and stale air permeated the space. At the edge of her vision, though, she saw a light—the bright orange of a torch. She followed it, and once again spotted the woman-from-the-gala walking briskly through the corridor, torch-light in hand.

Lady Goth wore a skirt underneath that burgundy coat, and it swayed with her walk.

I wonder what she'll look like, how her hips would move, if she was walking towards me with such urgency.

She climbed a few steps, and Lady Morrigan quickly followed, hoping to catch her before the light disappeared. She still had her goggles handy, but she didn't want to look at Lady Goth as some large, green *shape* rather than what she was seeing right now.

And I like what I see.

The scent of stale air quickly vanished as they went further, getting replaced by sweet juniper and darkwood incense. Perfume, clearly. No natural occurrence.

The corridor ended towards a small wooden door, cracked and in disrepair. Half of its wooden planks seemed to be broken or missing.

Lady Goth entered, closing the door behind her, and slowly Lady Morrigan followed. She reached the door, but paused just as her hand touched the cold, brass handle. She could look entirely through a few slits and cracks, and...

Lady Goth was right in front of her, standing near the door, and she placed the torch-light on a small wall fixture, and it gave light to the rest of the room.

It looked like a storeroom of sorts, filled with shelves of linens, candles, and dust-covered silver. As the woman-from-the-gala walked through the room, Morrigan saw an incense was lit on a side table close to the door, no doubt meant to bring a certain freshness to the otherwise stale atmosphere.

But as Lady Goth walked off to the side, Morrigan saw what she was obscuring from view.

She took a breath in, loudly, then put a hand over her mouth as she realized what she had done. Thankfully, neither of them reacted to the sound.

Perhaps they didn't hear it.

The large, hulking monster stood still, and in the torch-light, everything was illuminated.

It might have a good two feet on Lady Goth, from the looks of it. Skin that amalgamated in a green-white-blue hue, scars all over its body, and a smooth, waxen texture to the skin. It wore only some dark trousers, half-torn at the shin to reveal heavy, muscled calves. The rest of his upper body was bare...

Oh.

Lady Morrigan almost yelped through her mouth. His body looked chiseled, formed to perfection against the glow of the torchlight. It made his skin glow, further highlighting his bulky chest and the firm, firm muscles of his abdomen.

And then her vision landed on his face.

The waxen skin and the light almost made his face—and his body—shimmer in an ethereal-like luminescence that made him look like a ghost. A very corporeal ghost. Just like the body, the face felt sculpted, nary a trace of anything that wasn't perfect, despite all the scarring and imperfections that came with being a patchwork creature. Everything felt naturally perfect; a strong, wide jaw, thick, full lips, and the eyes...

Before she could completely ogle, though, Lady Goth had closed the distance, and the thing looked at her. There was no fear in the way the woman-from-the-gala moved, and the creature was still, looking at the woman in front of him with a kind of longing, almost like...love?

What could she be doing here? What could...he...be doing here? What purpose do they have in meeting like this?

But Lady Morrigan needn't have put that question to her mind, because Lady Goth put her hand on the hem of his trousers, pulling him by them towards her, and threw herself at him. The creature's head lowered and Lady Goth's tilted up, as their lips met for a kiss.

Mesmerized, Lady Morrigan watched as the woman's lips danced against the hulk's rather clumsy attempts. With a fervent hunger they

grabbed at each other's bodies, and her coat was off in seconds. Both of them got to work on the unfastening the laces of her frilled shirt, right before that, too, was hastily pulled down, revealing the bare, naked back of Lady Goth.

It was a breathtaking violence to her senses. A stark, beautiful terrain of pale skin taut over a delicate architecture of bone and sinew. From shoulder blade to the line of her spine, every part of her looked perfect, firm and yet delicate, casting faint shadows against the light of the torch. She wanted to touch that line in the center that ran along her spine, to trace her fingertip, or better yet, her tongue, through that gorgeous furrow.

Lady Goth was then lifted in the air by him. The woman sent her legs wrapping around his body as he brought her to the edge of a nearby table, setting her down with the same gentleness as he had handled Lady Morrigan herself.

From there, his kisses went lower to her neck, and she arched her back, tilted her head upward in ecstasy, as he went further down and his mouth found the delicate tips of those mounds, to those magnificent breasts that took Lady Morrigan's breath away.

Perfectly round and pale, they were. In that instance, she felt entirely jealous of the creature who was able to put his mouth and tongue to use, giving her pleasure that seemed stolen from Lady Morrigan, pleasure she couldn't give to Lady Goth herself. She put her hand over his head, over the long hair that seemed almost too smooth and too silky to be the natural locks of a patchwork thing, running her fingers along with them. Then Lady Morrigan's vision shifted, to being the one being serviced by him, her own hands running lovingly as he gave her pleasure, locking his mouth over the tips of her own breasts.

Almost with impatient urgency, Lady Goth then lifted her skirt, bunching it up in her hands as the hulking thing assisted her with it.

Are they...oh.

Within seconds, he had torn off whichever piece of fabric was in his way, and his mouth was in between her legs, working away as her back arched and head tilted even more.

Pulses of electricity went through Lady Morrigan, her hands refusing to remain idle as she attempted—however she could—to stifle the aching need she was feeling too. She found her hands wrapping around herself tightly, clutching a breast, running along her leg, up her thigh against the thin layers of the leather trousers she wore.

“Yes, my sweetling!” the woman-from-the-gala cried.

Lady Goth’s moans brought her attention right back. Her legs were on his shoulders, and his hands around her thighs. Once more, she was running his hands along his hair, one hand clutching and kneading at her own breast to maximize the pleasure.

If her gaping lips were not an indication of her ecstasy, her writhing and trembling body was. Her thighs and legs vibrated and shuddered, and his hands travelled across her body, touching where pleasure was guaranteed.

She fell back with a thud, her head smacking lightly against one of the shelves, as her head tilted slightly to the side in sexual satisfaction. Lady Morrigan then realized she was looking in the direction of the door.

Right at her.

And then Lady Goth’s parted lips revealed perfect white teeth as she broke into a smile.

The creature’s head was traveling back up now, laying kisses along her legs, her mound, along her core and up to her breasts. She put a

finger to her lip as Lady Morrigan's breath quickened even more, and a new fire awoke within her.

The heat from between her legs was now unbearable. Her hands ached to find themselves there, to touch until climax was reached.

Still meeting her gaze, Lady Goth and the creature kissed, their bodies now locked in that position that made possible what happened next.

Hip to hip, his trousers lowered, and Lady Goth's own legs wrapped around his sides, and he thrust forward. In a singular, swift motion, he had found himself inside her, and Morrigan wondered what it would look like, what it would feel like, the length, the girth, the texture as it split her open and took her and made her write senseless. Lady Goth opened her mouth with a loud moan, and smiled through it, staring at Lady Morrigan with those dark eyes that told her all she needed to be told.

Don't you dare leave.

She felt her own thoughts to be invaded by this woman, her sultry and lilting tone echoing in the pleasure halls of her own mind, and Lady Morrigan froze in place, still being able to move her hands and legs, but unable to stray from where she was, peering through the slits on the door. She felt phantom forces grip her and keep her there, and the heat and wetness inside her made those forces redundant all the same.

Her hands snaked down, reaching the hem and laces of her trousers and going through it where they were needed most, as the creature thrust more and thrust harder. Delicate, soft moans filled the room, and Lady Morrigan's ears wished it was the only sound she ever heard from now on.

Remove the rest from the universe. This is all I need. The sound of her pleasure and ecstasy.

Lady Goth's eyes never left hers as she put her hands at his hips, assisting in maximizing the force of his movements, propelling into her like a battering ram, but still with a gentleness that Lady Morrigan was becoming increasingly familiar with. With each thrust, she moaned, and with each moan, Lady Morrigan's own pleasure and heat increased.

Her body tightened, her skin felt hot to the touch, and she too, let out a sound. She felt the creature pause then, right as Lady Goth grabbed him by his head and kissed, using her legs to pull him in and urge him to continue.

Their movements quickened, and Lady Morrigan's own did too, the trio reaching a violent crescendo that threatened to break down the manor walls.

Time and time again, her vision shifted between being him and being her. She was the thing, thrusting violently into her, feeling the pleasure of doing so, and the pleasure of being a giver. Then she was Lady Goth, and she was being serviced, taken into the throes of passion with each firm movement, and brought to greater and greater delights.

Then, it would be Lady Goth in place of him, her mouth on her, her tongue buried deep between her legs while they floated in the air, while they both writhed in garden-grass and in underground caverns, in large balls and galas and in private bedrooms and dwellings. She saw herself give joy to the woman, felt the smooth skin of her thighs against her cheeks as the clouds touched her, and she was floating, the sound of the wind thousands of feet in the air drowned out by the way Lady Goth's legs were wrapped tightly around her head.

Then it was Lady Goth before her again, ramming into her as if sporting the creature's appendage, and Lady Morrigan felt her hands

slick and sticky with her inner walls cascading into her fingers, squeezing them as those inner muscles tightened as well.

Then her eyes opened, and she saw them again, herself so far, too far from the pleasure she could feel too, a mix of anger, jealousy, and resentment at the thought, coupled with longing and desire, too.

Her breaths came in ragged pants, her body tensing as his relentless, animalistic devotion to Lady Goth's pleasure pushed her over the edge. She felt it on her, too, the tightness, the convulsion, and tremors took hold of them both.

Then, with his one final plunge, Lady Goth pulled him inside, locking her legs around him, wrapping her hands around his neck, and pulling herself towards him. He lifted her from that table as Lady Morrigan felt her own wetness be met with a brutal force, her body making her cry out.

Right before she crossed that edge, his neck craned all too quick towards the source of the sound, and fear replaced her feelings of bliss, her body still aching in need as she felt shock, then realization. In a glimpse, she saw Lady Goth pull him tighter against her as her mind reeled and jostled against her aching need, the fear overcoming for a moment as she instantly got up and ran.

With weak legs she ran down the stairs, stumbling and finding it difficult to maintain her footing in the dark as she continued on through the black corridor. She crashed against the wall, and threw her hands all over it, desperate to find a lifted brick, a lone sconce, a lever, something to open the wall-door.

She might've touched something, or felt or pulled on it. Perhaps she hadn't. In her urgency, she didn't care about such details, only that the wall was shifting, and that surprisingly muffled sound of stone against stone returned.

With hurry, she squeezed through it before it had even opened a few inches and ran towards the tapestry. She climbed and went behind it, pausing only to attempt to pull out those goggles before she remembered that they were useless at speed. Then she ran past the alcove back to where they had come, in total darkness, her breath low against the trappings of the underground cavernous corridor, and her legs still weak from what had just transpired between a lady of the court and a massive, hulking thing that seemed too good of a thing to be considered an abomination of undeath.

IX

The applause faded into the hush, appreciative murmur of the club's patrons. Lady Morrigan gave them a small, practiced nod, sweeping her gaze over the gathered audience.

She cast a glance at the easel next to her, a large canvas that situated one of her recent works.

On the canvas, a winged creature flew in the dark sky, surrounded by the faint glow of stars and the empty vastness of space. The creature itself had wax-like skin, and the light coming from its front shone through it, lighting its innards with a faint glow. A large glow of amber-light was the source—the sun, and the creature was looking behind it as it flew through space, towards the familiar arc of Earth. The creature's face was one of profound longing, as if remembering something that it would miss as it flew towards the sun, seemingly to its doom.

Sun Dew, Lady Morrigan had named it, though she wanted to call it *Yearning*.

It would reveal too much then, and to the wrong people.

She began to make her way towards the refreshment table as the crowd dispersed, accepting the hollow compliments of her peers.

She picked up a glass of wine, whichever was one closest. She didn't care which one touched her lips tonight, only that it did, turning her mind away from what her heart screamed at her.

She took the wineglass and retreated to a private room at the clubhouse. It was up a flight of stairs at the top floor of the building, the room opening up to a private veranda with a large variety of flowers. It had a bench that Lady Morrigan often idled on, reading a book, or would put an easel against the backdrop, looking over the city as she enjoyed the fresh air and painted concepts that she would then put away, dissatisfied with the piece of an idea that never fully formed.

She sat on the bench, her head unable to find peace. There was only one thought in her mind, wanting only one thing, though the subjects of her desire were—

“I cannot fathom the sun to mean doom.”

Lady Morrigan's neck shot towards the sound of that voice, that sweet, sweet voice. She recognized it in an instant, no need to look at the source. It was her. It was unmistakably her. So sultry, so melancholic and yet musical to her ears.

She was a stark figure lingering by the curtained doorway of the veranda. A strange, electric thrill ran through Lady Morrigan, sharp and welcome.

Lady Goth moved with a liquid grace that seemed to part the very air, the scent of lilacs and wildflowers coupled with the dark stare of the woman's eyes making Lady Morrigan twist her hips in her seat.

“It's quite fascinating, the choice of subject,” she said. For a while, that voice was the only thing Lady Morrigan could focus on. She could hear it until the end of time. It was strangely different, hearing her speak as opposed to being spoken to by her. She hadn't felt this

way with her voice back at the estate, though now it was the only thing that mattered.

That, and the now-close proximity of that woman with Lady Morrigan.

She had walked close now, almost right in front of her at the bench.

“There is beauty in the fight, but there is pleasure in the fall.” Her voice was a low purr that vibrated through her bones. “To give yourself to your doom, knowing you might not come out the other end the same.”

Lady Goth’s lips curled into a faint smile as Morrigan looked up at her. She had stepped even closer now, and her voice turned to a low, conspiratorial whisper—and the warmth of the air as it moved through her words reached and touched Morrigan in ways that made her squirm. “The view from the shadows can be quite illuminating, too.”

Lady Morrigan’s blood ran cold. It could have been such an innocent, ordinary sentence. But with the recency of the last time that they laid eyes on each other, it unmistakably meant only one thing.

I was looking at her through the door. Does she even know it was me? Could she have?

“*Sun Dew* doesn’t illustrate—”

“As talented as you are with a brush, my lady, I am talking about a different matter.”

Her hand reached out and touched Lady Morrigan, and it sent waves through her. Flashes of that night not so long ago came rushing back, flashes of the heat between her legs, of her ivory skin against the waxen glow of the thing that had his head between...

“I...I don’t—”

“*Sshhh*.”

A finger had reached her lips,

Lady Morrigan's own lips parted ever so slightly, her tongue itching to taste the flesh against it. The other woman leaned down towards her face...slowly, ever so slowly.

"I find myself wondering," she whispered, "as you stood there in the dark, your heart pounding," Her finger snaked in Lady Morrigan's mouth, who took it in all too willingly, the taste only making the heat rise, and take her breath away. "Did you imagine yourself as me, splayed out on the table?"

If she wasn't already burning with need, the question lit a fire within her. Her mind reeled between those two fantasies, her desire suddenly spoken aloud, and she could picture it. Her body was answering before her mind could, too, the slickness between her legs unable to be ignored as she pressed her thighs together.

She had never looked at a woman with this kind of hunger, never felt this kind of hunger either—this raw, predatory need. The desire to take and be taken.

Lady Goth leaned even closer, this time her breath warm against Morrigan's ear. "Or did you imagine yourself as him, buried deep inside my flesh?"

A moan escaped Lady Morrigan, muffled by the finger in her mouth, as Lady Goth's mouth reached her ear, and she bit on it, grabbing her earlobe with her teeth. A hand found its way between her thighs, pushing at her legs as Lady Morrigan obeyed the command, and parted them to allow the hand to go where it wanted.

Lady Goth then pulled her finger out of her mouth, and with wet, slick fingers, she used the two that Morrigan was tonguing, and placed them on her chin. Lady Goth tilted her head towards her own, as they stood, eyes to eyes, nose to nose, lips to lips.

She wanted to say something to the woman-from-the-gala, to say anything. Anything at all.

But there was only one thing left to do in that moment. Only one little move forward to ensure that everything that Lady Morrigan had been wanting would happen. One move to sate the fire between her legs, or set off an explosion of ecstasy, driving her to do even more.

More was the only word that came to her mind in this close proximity with her. Too much was not enough. A little more was not enough. Nothing was enough, nothing but her, in her embrace, in her arms, to have her legs wrapped around her, her hands wandering freely, her lips and mouth *everywhere* on her.

She was looking at her, Lady Goth's eyes boring into Lady Morrigan's, and all she could think of was what lay in wait. What did she wear underneath that dark gown she had forgotten to pay attention to? What more manners of ecstatic sounds could that voice create when Lady Morrigan would put her mouth to the places that gave her pleasure?

Lady Goth dragged her wet fingers across her face, once more touching her mouth, pulling at the edge of her lips as Lady Morrigan felt her warm breath on her.

It sent a wave of pleasure through her body, and she felt her breasts feel heavy, heaving as she panted. The air around her had a sweet perspiration mixed with the milky breath of sexual excitement.

"You should know, my lady *Morrigan*..."

Fuck me.

As soon as she said her name, her legs twitched, and she felt them touch against Lady Goth's.

Say my name. Say it more. Say it more!

"...that it's considered bad manners to leave a lady unsatisfied."

Lady Goth's lips touched against hers as she talked, each movement wanting Lady Morrigan to close that distance, but she was afraid. She feared that this woman, who had been throwing herself at her, would say no if she touched her lips with her own.

Why? she asked herself, and her self did answer. Why indeed.

Her wet fingers had dried as they traced along Lady Morrigan's neck, feeling her collarbone, the base of her throat, caressing her chin with the thumb.

"When you were there, against that door, contemplating whether to touch yourself..."

Their foreheads touched.

"It was all I could do to not go to that door and drag you inside, and replace your hands with my own."

Both of Lady Goth's hands went to her chest, feeling her breasts through her dress.

"I mustered the effort that a thousand men cannot bring, to not take you as I danced with you."

She pressed at the tips of her breasts through Morrigan's dress.

"I wished it was you, when he dug his tongue in between my legs."

Her hands found their way back to her, one going around her head, and the other resting above her collarbone, the heat palpable and—

"I wished it was you, when he kissed me."

And it was done. Lady Goth kissed Lady Morrigan.

Soft lips.

Demanding, soft lips. A bold tongue, tasting of wine mixed in with something bitter.

Morrigan thrust her hips towards Lady Goth, desperate for them to find something, a leg, a hand, a touch—something to meet with,

something to grind against, to bring friction to the slippery slope she was falling into.

Her tongue pushed through into Lady Morrigan's mouth, and she met it with her own. Their tongues danced together under the smell of nightshade and juniper, under the night sky that had seemed to brighten, losing some of the darkness that had taken hold of it.

She felt herself breathing through her nose, desperate to not break away from the kiss. She was losing control, of herself and of her kisses as they became more and more sloppy and salivated, leaving wet trails of her tongue and saliva around Lady Goth's mouth. Almost on instinct, she answered with similar sloppiness, though hers were practiced and perfect, each movement designed to be sensual rather than the raw need Lady Morrigan was announcing with her eagerness.

And when that kiss finally broke apart so they could breathe again, panting, Lady Goth's eyes lit up. A fire was inside those dark globes, burning with an intensity that disallowed Lady Morrigan to catch her breath.

"Want can be a dangerous thing, *Morrigan*."

Oh, yes!

They way her delicate voice called her name. Her husky, whispering voice!

Say my name!

Her hands snaked their way to her breasts, no pretense of foreplay remaining. She wanted one thing.

"Kings and queens have killed thousands in the name of want. To have something like *this*..."

With both hands, she roughly grabbed at her breasts and her knees pushed at Lady Morrigan's legs, parting them. The woman still sitting on the bench yelped.

“...requires sacrifice. What must I give to have what I want? What must you?”

“I don’t fucking care!”

Lady Morrigan pleaded with a desperation that she had never displayed before, and she went back into the kiss.

Morrigan kissed her lips, snaked her tongue inside, launched her hands at her, feeling her body, the shape of her face, the small of her back, the shallows of her collarbones and neck. She felt her pulse at her throat as it quickened, her heart at her breasts as her hands and mouth found their way there, and pulled Lady Goth on top of her as the woman staggered, finding the right footing to properly sit on her lap, face to face—so to speak—straddling her.

“I don’t care what I must give, as long as I get to kiss you!”

Almost breathlessly she kissed Lady Goth, as she felt the woman on top move her hips, thrusting in her direction.

Both their mouths left each other, and didn’t wait before they were on each other’s neck in the next instance.

She kissed her neck, ran her tongue along it, and felt the same happen to her. The sensitive skin of her throat was burning, and she felt a similar heat as she bit at her throat, her kisses reaching the blades of Lady Goth’s shoulders.

Lady Goth’s fingers found the laces of Lady Morrigan’s gown, and began to undo them. Lady Morrigan found it difficult to do the same to her as her hands trembled, unable to find the patience to breathe and ground herself, the feeling of the woman still gyrating on her lap too much for her to bear.

“I’ve longed to taste you, Morrigan, and not just these lips.” She kissed her again, pulling her face up with one hand while the other worked at undoing her dress. “And I know that you left without finishing what you started.”

Her dress had come loose, the chemise underneath it already giving way as Lady Goth's head went towards her chest.

"Tonight, that wrong will be made right."

Lady Morrigan tilted her head up as she felt lips and tongue probe at her breasts, leave wet trails along them, before latching onto a nipple without so much as a kiss. She had control, Lady Goth, but she too was losing it quickly.

In present company, altogether impossible not to.

The thought didn't feel like her own. It felt as if it came to her, the words spoken by someone else's inner self, reaching towards her as a warmth filled her body. Lady Goth suckled onto her breasts with fervor as Lady Morrigan released moans of pleasure, her eyes opening wide as her legs opened wider, and she saw a light in the corner of her eye, a bright orange that permeated the sky. The blackness of the night was quickly being replaced, as if the sun was rising, and the bright tang of orange and saffron tore apart the darkness.

Lady Goth then lifted the bottom of her dress, her mouth still latched on as it alternated between her nipples, not letting any one of them be robbed of attention. Her hands snaked in between, separating cloth and silk, reaching the skin of Morrigan's inner thighs and going further beyond.

She had dreamed of moments like this, of a nondescript lover sliding their hands beneath her dress, her skirt, or her trousers. In her dreams, the hands and tongue were almost devoid of a person, floating things that only existed for her pleasure as they found their way around her body, still limited by the physical confines, though the person in control of those hands and tongues hadn't mattered in those dreams.

And those hands would be slow, deliberately slow, bringing her close to the edge with each touch but not letting her through that

line, not finishing what they were here to do. Endlessly those hands teased, and endlessly that tongue kissed, but each kiss was accompanied with a pause that made her unable to think of anything but to pull that tongue back towards her, pull those hands back to where they were.

The hands that belonged to Lady Goth, though, didn't have such patience tonight. Within seconds, they had found their way between her folds, pulling apart the curtain of her lips and finding their way in.

Pleasure.

Absolute pleasure filled her senses. Her body convulsed, and Lady Morrigan felt herself unable to sit on that bench anymore.

Ecstasy.

Warmth engulfed her body, every fiber of her being becoming its own hedonistic entity, demanding more and more and more and more as it received, the hunger and need driving it to greater heights, and the delight of being pleased multiplying with each thrust of her fingers.

Euphoria.

She fell from that bench, her legs giving out, her body loosening and tightening at the whim of the woman she was being puppeteered by, and yet she didn't touch the ground.

Floating?

Her eyes opened, and Lady Morrigan found herself separated from the bench, air beneath and above her, the sound of wind flowing in her hair. Half-naked, her hands grabbed onto Lady Goth's for dear life as the woman kissed and nibbled at her neck, occasionally reaching her head for a kiss, then going down towards her breasts again. One hand grabbed at her hip for support, and two fingers had her gripped in a vice of pure bliss while a thumb was pressed against

her mound. She floated, and the sky lit up like an explosion of fire and flame, the tangerine color of the sky glowing brighter and brighter.

What? Where? Why am I in the air...and oh! I feel so...

So good!

A heat engulfed her entire being as they both panted, the panic of her situation leaving her as she focused entirely on how she felt being loved by this woman. She looked at her, at the Lady Goth, at her black hair that seemed to glow to a white-grey under the light of the morning sky, and her black gown...

The morning sky? Is it dawn already?

It couldn't have been.

You have magic fingers, Lady Goth.

She breathed into Lady Goth's ear as her head neared, resting on the woman's shoulder, her teeth biting into her—though Morrigan could not muster the strength for her bite to be anything but the whimpering squeeze of her lips and tongue on her.

"Surrender to it, *Morrigan!*" the woman cried, and...

And she did.

And world was suddenly alight.

All of Geneva was visible under the flash, under the explosion in the sky. From her vantage point, who-knows-how-many feet floating in the air, she saw the city laid out beneath her like a beautiful painting.

Beautiful, if not for the vision before her, glowing under the light, sweaty from the pleasure she was giving and had not yet received herself.

The world dissolved into a blinding sheet of pearl and ivory. A coiling, white-hot singularity of pleasure took her core, wounding itself tighter and tighter around her as her hips caved to Goth's

relentless fingers. An immense, unbearable force built behind her navel, a beautiful pressure that threatened to tear her apart.

A scream ripped from her throat as that singularity exploded outwards, the scream of pleasure almost indiscernible from one of complete and total pain. A supernova of bliss incinerated her every thought, every memory, every shred of her identity. Every muscle seized, the arches of her feet, the clenched muscles of her jaw—they all locked her in a rigid, convulsing arc of electric ecstasy.

Her thighs clamped around Lady Goth's wrist as if they were the only anchor point that kept her in the air. To let go would mean death.

And what a beautiful death that would be.

Her eyes had closed now and her body had tilted backwards, thighs still closed together. She wanted Lady Goth to keep her fingers there, to feel their warmth inside her, to have that warmth live there and never exit. That was their home now, and they would give her company until her life ended.

But not yet. There is still her that I want to pleasure, still my hands that should return the favor of her love to me...

Morrigan opened her eyes as she lay there, sprawled on the bench, her dress almost torn and halfway unmade. It had been lifted above her thighs, her bare breasts and nipples chafed from the tonguing and sucking Lady Goth had given her.

She felt a hand caress her hair, and she looked above her. There she was, the vision of everything beautiful, the personification of love and sex and all that was right with the world.

"You had passed out for quite a while there, sweetling."

Lady Morrigan smiled. She had so many questions to ask, about whether she was actually flying in the air, about what happened in between her arrival and now, about whether or not Lady Goth received pleasure too...

“What happened?” was all she could ask.

“The people will say the sky was on fire.” She continued stroking her head, pulling an occasional strand of red-streaked hair behind Lady Morrigan’s ear. “I’d have a different theory.”

So it was real. Some of it, at least.

“Which is?”

“That our union changed the world. Your winged beast finally met the sun.”

“Did we doom the world?”

“If that’s what it takes, my sweetling.”

Is she speaking in tongues, or did the sky really light on fire? The question hung in her thoughts, but she couldn’t bear to ask it. It felt wrong, to reduce the pleasure she gave her to a mere coincidence of the natural order.

Even now, in the bliss after only her fingers—*only her fingers*—had sent her careening into the air, her hips bounced, and her pleasure-center drooled.

“The hour is late. It is not my desire to leave you like this, but I’m afraid I must take my leave.”

“Wait...” Lady Morrigan lifted herself up, a hand moving behind Lady Goth’s head. “You haven’t even...”

“I came here to bring you pleasure denied, my lady.” She put her hand over Lady Morrigan’s which was now over the cheek. “There is time for the rest to take place yet, even though every part of me is aching to spend eternity with my tongue buried in your deepest, darkest places.”

She leaned down, pursing her lips, and Lady Morrigan reached up as she kissed her. She did not want to let go.

Lady Goth pulled herself off before Lady Morrigan could have her tongue find its way inside her mouth.

“The heart yearns for it, my lady, but the world—and duty—calls. Do not let your pretty heart fret, though. My tongue will soon be upon it again, and we both will have what we want.”

X

We will both have what we want.

That's what she had said, but did she know what Lady Morrigan wanted? Not just from her, but from...

How could she know? She does not know my head, or my heart, and I've yet to bear my soul to anyone...

The crisp morning air had her feeling lethargic, and the cool, slick caress of the sheets against her naked skin only heightened that feeling.

Or perhaps it was not the morning air at all.

She opened her eyes, expecting the familiar comfort of her bed and bedchamber, yet her vision was only met with the open night sky, the moon full and bright shining down upon her exposed skin, the air flowing through her as if there was nothing between her and the world.

She clutched her velvet sheets tighter around her body, and a breeze rolled across the moon-drenched landscape of the garden. Her hands felt around her, and found the light prick of trimmed garden-grass, and the smell of wildflowers and lilacs grabbing at her senses.

Every time the heavy linen pressed against her body, she shivered. There was no warmth there, yet she did not want to rid herself of

them. There was something comfortable about those silken sheets, even if they were absolutely useless in keeping the cold away.

Her hands went within the sheets, hoping that the warmth of her own skin would supplant her shivering self. The grass had reached her back now, its prickly coolness distracting her from the way they felt against her skin. Like a smooth, liquid touch they were, delicately caressing her body—and then she moved, and like a thousand acupuncture needles she felt the grass on her back.

It did not work. Her hands were too cold. Frustrated, she tore herself off from those silk sheets, and let the moonlight bathe her in her naked form. *I am the moon itself, walking on the earth, a blessing upon the ones I allow their gaze to fall.* She thought.

But as the sheets lifted, a delightful surprise greeted her.

There, between her legs, waited the smiling, eager face of a woman, her hands snaking their way around her thighs.

The woman had hazel eyes and dark hair with streaks of crimson red. They danced in the breeze as the woman locked her eyes with her, and in that, she felt it.

Warmth.

The cool air formed its own blanket around them and this woman kept it from penetrating her skin. Her hands on her thighs lit a furnace to that place in between, and the woman took in a breath, taking in the womanly scent.

Slowly, one of her hands came to her own and interlaced with her fingers. The woman then tilted her head to the side, and placed a gentle kiss on her leg, right beside her knee.

She took one of the woman's hands still around her thigh, and grabbed it by the palm. The woman laid kisses further up, traveling up her leg as it reached her thighs, and she felt the heat radiate from the delta in between them.

Then, with a toothy smile, and without further warning, she dived in between her pale lap. One of the woman's hands left her thigh, the other still being clung to her own, before she felt a tongue invade her, parting her lips, and two fingers pushing in alongside it. Like guests too familiar, they came in and left, occasionally being rubbed around her now-swollen bud, as the tongue lapped and danced and flicked.

The fingers then left, and the hand found its way up, tracing along her core, up to her breasts, kneading one before it formed around her throat. She felt the wet trail of her own juices being left along her body as the fingers found their way to her lips, and like how they parted her below, two fingers pushed in.

She felt the texture of the woman's fingers, tasted the salt-sweet essence of herself on them. She loved the taste, wondering how it would be to find it from the source as the tongue lapped its way to the finish line.

How lovely I would taste, and how much more lovely it would be to taste it on her lips.

Her mouth received the same treatment, those fingers never staying in one place, as she sucked on them. Her moans were muffled with them in her mouth as she pulled her thighs together, trapping the head of the woman in between. The fingers then left, and the hand retreated back to being around her thighs, as the woman redoubled her efforts.

She even felt the ground damp with her sweat and desire as her eyes fell upon the silhouette of the woman, also naked in all her glory, in full display against the moonlight. She lay flat as she licked, her shapely backside inviting her to touch and feel and kiss, though her lips and hands were too far away for such an exquisite experience.

Exquisite scents of the garden's jasmine filled her, along with metallic smells that tasted like wine and cunt on the tip of her tongue,

and her mouth opened as if inviting it there, wishing that this woman would attach her own hips here while servicing her all the same. Her hips moved with the rhythm of her tongue, and her free hand went to the woman's head, going through her hair, pushing her head against her aching bud.

She trembled and writhed in pleasure, feeling herself getting closer and closer, her core clenching in response as the fingers returned their assault. Each wave of pleasure came with a phantom echo of the same, a sensory onslaught of violent sexual spasms that sent her hips up in the air.

She was getting close, ready for it, ready to shatter against this woman's mouth and for her to taste her release in all its glory. She looked towards this woman, her hazel eyes telling her that she was there for her pleasure and hers alone, as she grabbed a handful of her hair and whispered her name.

"Oh, Morrigan."

She felt the woman's hands tremble, and her tongue straighten and stiffen, curved only at the tip, and finding its way deeper inside her.

"Yes! Oh, Morrigan!"

She cried the woman's name, her release closer and closer, eyes locked together as she screamed in total surrender. The moonlight around her was fading, and the grass by her sides becoming a soft sea of silken touches as she wanted that one, final lick, that singular kiss that would send her over the edge and into the beyond, the pleasure-land where all lust was sated and lust was still never-ending.

The world began to narrow to that single point, that single moment of impending, glorious release...

"Morrigan!"

This time, the voice did not come from her. It was different, a different sound, though no less sweet, close to her side.

“Morrigan!”

Her eyes opened, and Lady Morrigan found the sharp features of the spy staring down at her, clutching her bare shoulders.

“Syona!”

The sweat on her body and the dampness of the sheets sent a shiver down her spine, and a chilling breeze took over the air. She shot up, shocked and panting as if waking from a nightmare—*no, from a dream I should not have woken from*—her senses slowly returning, as little by little she took in her surroundings.

Syona sat on the edge of the bed, her body almost reaching atop her rather than next to her, her dark skin glowing against the moonlight with a sheen. One by one her senses returned, and Lady Morrigan saw that the spy was staring at her.

No, she was *staring* at her, a strange non-ogling, unashamed stare that held little in the way of any leering curiosity. She was not the least bit abashed, and it took Lady Morrigan a few seconds of staring back before she realized *why* that would be the case.

Her eyes followed the spy’s gaze, and she saw that she was naked in her entirety, the silk blankets strewn to the side in the throes of passion as the heat still emanating between her legs reminded her of the as-of-yet unfinished business.

It was strangely comforting, that intimate stare. More invasive than any stolen glance could be, each second of it feeling as if Lady Morrigan was shedding another layer of skin for the spy, letting her inside her world, giving her the knowledge of her own self even she lacked. For a second, shame came back with her senses, and she snatched the silk blanket, pulling it up to her chest, letting it cover what may and leave uncovered what she missed. It was a flimsy,

transparent shield against that sudden intrusion, and in the next second all shame was gone. She felt seen under her gaze, seen and ogled, yet it didn't draw her to disgust.

Instead, it only reminded her of her arousal—and of satisfaction denied.

This clinical assessment of her form was profoundly arousing. The heat in her belly was already smoldering from her dream, and it flared into a fresh, wicked fire. She felt her wetness, a sick and almost shameful evidence of her body's betrayal. She was in the presence of, more or less, a friend. A friend she depended on, even though their relationship was more transactional than most.

She loosened her grip on her blanket, letting her bare chest on display as she covered her legs. It was welcoming anyway, as the sweat and scent of her arousal was too strong and too pungent. The air flowing on her breasts was almost its own comfort.

Thankfully, it was Syona who broke the silence. "Apologies. I tried to wake you, Morrigan." Her voice was low, an urgent whisper that carried easily in the quiet of her bedchamber. "You were...quite deep in your slumber...I hadn't realized..."

"I'm not sure if I can forgive you, Syona. I've not had too many dreams I've never wanted to wake from." Lady Morrigan said between breaths.

"That good?"

Lady Morrigan only nodded.

"Well, I'd ask for it, anyway. I'd have waited, but your instructions were explicit."

"Yes, and for the future, dispense with the implicitness on your part as well, Syona. We both know I was neither in dream nor in slumber."

“On the contrary. You looked like you were having a nightmare.” She nodded in her direction, and once again, a pang of shame overtook Lady Morrigan as she looked at herself. Here she was, half-covered and half-naked, talking to a spy in her employ.

Her staring only continued.

“Was a glance enough, or did you have to examine more closely to discern my status?”

It was only then that Syona finally looked at Lady Morrigan, meeting her eyes, before she realized her actions and looked away in shame.

“My apologies!” She almost said out loud, before repeating in a whisper. “Sorry.”

The intimacy of the moment felt even more real at the spy’s own shame. Her looking away had done little to sooth Morrigan’s frayed nerves.

Here they were, alone in the dark, and a sudden reckless impulse sized her. Slowly, Morrigan moved her hands, taking some of the silk blankets with her, revealing more of herself—just enough to show the curve of her hip, the blanket falling below her navel and above the crease between her legs.

Then, feeling bolder, she rose from the bed with a languid, unhurried grace, stretching her arms over her head, arching her back just so, knowing the moonlight would catch the subtle play of muscle beneath her skin.

This spy is most likely no stranger to voyeurism. How would she respond to this?

Was it curiosity that drove Lady Morrigan to do this in front of her friend?

Is it?

The questions lingered in her mind as she got up to the edge, Syona still sitting by the edge of the bed. She walked slowly towards where a silk robe was draped, feeling the cool air touch her. It tugged at her, clutching at her wetness, pulling at the hard tips of her breasts like a delicious caress on her overheated skin.

She felt Syona's eyes looking over at her as she picked up the robe. She almost didn't want to put it on.

With the robe in hand, Lady Morrigan turned around. This time, she saw Syona looked at her with arousal, with want in her eyes as they trailed across Morrigan's entire form. She felt her eyes trace the outline of her breasts, the curves of her legs and hips, the delta between her legs, land and stay at her lips.

Slowly, she put on the robe, a reminder hammering against her head that the spy was here on business, not pleasure, though it was almost disappointing that Syona did not exert that level of control over herself, *and* that she did little to show that her body was any indication of what the spy herself wanted, or if her own arousal in being witness to Morrigan's nakedness was merely circumstantial.

Lady Morrigan felt like a goddess in that moment, naked in the moonlight of her bedchamber, robe in hand, being ogled by this admittedly beautiful woman with a strange reverence rather than a glare.

And for the first time, Lady Morrigan too looked at Syona with a different eye, and she truly was beautiful.

Dark, stormy hair. Eyes like lavender or nightshade, and a figure I would not mind inviting in my bed, firm and muscled while still being lithe and petite—

No! She's your friend, Morrigan!

Before her thoughts could continue their fight, once again, Syona broke the silence.

“I will look away.” Her voice was tight, strained in a way it hadn’t been before. “Forgive me.”

Once again, arousal overtook shame, and Syona’s nervousness only made her want her stare even more.

She slipped into her robe, tying the sash with a sharp, decisive tug.

“Once again, Syona. I find it difficult to forgive you. I’m searching and searching, and yet there is nothing you have done that warrants forgiveness.”

A chuckle escaped the spy, and Lady Morrigan then continued.

“As much as I’ve enjoyed this, my sweetness, I do believe I called you here for business. You have news, I presume?”

A single blink broke the spy out of whatever trance of arousal she had been in.

“Yes. I found something interesting at Junia’s home.”

“When we split up?”

“Aye.” Though she had come to her senses, in a manner of speaking, Syona’s voice was still tightly controlled.

XI

Cold, damp stone surrounded her as she moved through the tunnels, the bioluminescent glow from her Ocular-eyes guiding each step.

The doctor clutched a little lantern in her hand; it's faint bobbing light almost imperceptible to the silver-white glow that Junia appeared in through the contraption that Syona wore.

Junia's pace was agitated, that much was unmistakable.

Syona followed her through the tunnels to her bedchamber, each room and corridor having a conveniently located spy-hole from which to discern all movements and activity. The doctor's own lack of concern towards potential spies was remarkable.

Syona removed the goggles when she reached Junia's bedchamber. A large four-poster bed and a thick, worn rug was in its center, and soft candlelight illuminated the corners.

A half-empty wardrobe served as both a convenient secret-entrance towards the tunnels, and a place for Syona to safely gaze upon the doctor's activity this night. Junia set the lantern on the nightstand, and began to pace back and forth along the room. Her movements were quick, frantic, almost like a caged animal. She

removed a small mechanical device from the hidden sash of her pouches, and attached it to her ear to amplify the sound.

“Time, more time,” Junia muttered. Her voice was low in whisper to herself, as she moved towards a closed window, and opened it. She let the air in, and the moonlight flooded her bedchamber. Syona noticed a small, leather-bound journal on an ornate table by the far end of the room, nearer to where she was, with Junia’s back to it.

“He touched her,” Junia said, to nobody in particular. Her gaze was far away outside, staring into the night sky. She started working at the fastenings of her gown, and Syona saw the silver light flooding her flustered expression. “I know she did. I saw her face afterwards.”

The gown slid from her shoulders, pooling at her feet and she immediately stepped out of it, letting it stay there on the ground. She stood only in a chemise, but that also changed as her hands slid beneath them, pushing it up to reveal the rest of her. She pulled the garment over her head, and threw it to the side onto a lone chair that lay by a dresser.

Syona witnessed the moonlight fall upon her bare arms, eyed the hollow of her throat, the upper swell of her breasts. Her body was perfect—too perfectly pert and youthful. The flush of vitality was apparent on her skin, her waist narrow, the hips taut and curved. Every feature had a mathematically perfect symmetry to it. Her navel was sculpted and toned, her thighs white and pale, her calves muscled, her arms toned yet delicate, and her breasts unnaturally globed and firm.

Junia stood like a marble statue, naked and perfect, but then Syona saw what made her body feel so strange. The face—the face shared nothing of what lay beneath. It was smooth and preserved, yet those storm-grey eyes betrayed everything. There was no youth in those eyes.

Syona saw a desperate approximation of what should be a woman's blooming, but her cheeks were placed atop flesh that remembered being older. She looked to be staring outside the window in a mask of youngness.

Junia then brought her hands up to feel her hips, her waist, and put both hands on her breasts, pressing them together. "And I'm not her, am I?"

Junia crossed the room to her ornate desk and opened the journal. The light hit the cover as she flipped it open—it was embossed with a caduceus entwined with a double helix. Junia picked up a pen and began to scribble furiously, the scratching pen and her labored breathing the only sounds in the room. Then she stopped, and her hand trembled.

Junia slammed the notebook shut, and her breathing quickened. "*Her!*" she spat. "That beautiful, perfect *bitch!*"

Naked, Junia paced and Syona felt her own breath hitch. A heat pooled low in her abdomen and she pressed her thighs together in that wardrobe. She felt silk dresses graze her skin as she moved and willed herself to focus, though the sight before her was...distracting.

Junia had moved to the bed in her bare splendor, and her hand had slid between her legs already.

Syona saw her fingers moving with practiced urgency, her body arching, her breasts heaving as the light and the candles bathed Junia in a mix of tangerine and silver-blue.

"What have you done, Morrigan!" she whispered, twisting and turning on the bed. "Why are you so...*ooh!*" She turned and buried her face in the sheets, laying on her stomach as her fingers worked away at her center. Syona laid eyes on the curve of her hips and rump, spotless and enchanting under the light.

“What did he do to her to make her feel so?” Her fingers moved faster, circling and pressing on her sex as she turned back onto her back. “Did he *touch* you, Morrigan? “Were you gentle or were you not, my darling animal—*ah!*”

Junia grabbed and kneaded at her breast, and Syona’s own body twisted.

“I want her,” Junia moaned, bringing her other hand to her mouth and wetting her fingers. The ones between her legs quickened in their pace. “I want to know what he felt, what you felt, what you saw in each other!”

“I want to be her when he touched her, *oh*, for me to be so beautiful!”

Syona saw her opportunity. Junia was entirely distracted, and if Syona did not occupy her mind with something else—perhaps the reason she was here; information—she would not be able to keep herself from doing exactly what Junia was getting up to at the moment.

“Why do make me want you, Morrigan?! Why do you give in to me so readily?”

Silently she moved, her footsteps not uttering a sound, though it would not have mattered. She was lost in her own pleasure of amalgamated sexual rage and jealous imagination. Her eyes were closed, her body was swaying, and her magnificent breasts pushed outward as her body arched.

“Why did you not stay behind like I told you to?”

As she went across the room to the ornate table, for a fleeting second, Syona envisioned something she had not imagined before. An image of Lady Morrigan and her sharp, golden-eyed beauty right here in this room, as bare as Junia on the bed. She saw Junia’s naked body as close as she could as she went towards the table, and in her mind’s

eye, Morrigan was there, and Junia was above her instead, insider, *taking* her as if she had the appendage to do so.

Then her vision changed, and her knees got weak, and Syona paused. Morrigan was on top of Junia, their legs tangled together, and one of Junia's rested on Morrigan's shoulder. She moved her hips, and Junia writhed under her, before Morrigan lowered herself and their lips met for a kiss. Wet, sloppy sounds filled the room as Syona made her way to the desk and picked up the leather-bound journal.

At first, she thought of tearing the pages up before putting it back and retreating, but no. She could not risk it, for Junia would know.

Instead, she stayed there, and witnessed the naked woman on the bed pleasure herself to confused feelings of lust and envy.

She opened the journal, and scanned the pages as Junia's oblivious body moved with increased urgency.

Post-animation cycle 114.

No sign of vital instability, no sign of artificial life. Cortical activity exhibits patterns inconsistent with initial projections. Strong, irrefutable evidence of emergent consciousness is now been confirmed since cycle 32.

I hypothesize that the synaptic bridge was not given the safeguards it needs. The body-vessel does not seem to work with the intended modularity for greater control. Instead, it acts as a single unit, as unified animated tissue like a singular mind from disparate parts. In essence; person.

Junia's voice rose as Syona turned a few more pages. Breathless and broken she seemed as her fingers plunged in deep, her hips bucking at her touch. "I will take you, Morrigan. I will pin you down to this bed, and take you! I will fuck you until you scream my name and forget any other in existence! Then...*ah!*"

Syona's own arousal was a throbbing pulse she could not ignore, but ignore she had to. Her hand trembled on the journal, reading uninteresting text—relative to the moment—for a piece of information that would shed light on what was ensuing before her.

Post-animation cycle 148.

Preferences seem to be prevalent and unique, relative to the original cadaver. There are more than occasional parallels to the choices. Music preferences demand for higher sophistication, as an example.

“I hate you!” Junia screamed, and her body arched. Syona's gaze traveled to her, and to the journal, then back again. She could not help but stare at the sight before her, at Junia's curling fingers, her other hand pulling at her nipples, joining the hand working away at her sex, touching her face and throat, feeling her inner thighs. “You make me forget my work, my purpose! I hate how I want your hands on me, your mouth on me, your cunt against mine, wet and mine! Mine! My cunt!”

Post-animation cycle 209.

Observance of dilating pupils and quickening breath with touches. I have used my self as a subject for stimuli, and reactions seem genuine. All readings indicate a state of arousal, including the blood flowing to the erect genitalia. Using hands to elicit further stimulation produces thick, viscous liquid consistent with all properties of sperm. Further testing is required for determining the full extent of the production capabilities...

Syona did not read the rest, and hurriedly went forward a few pages. Then Junia spoke, and Syona's mind supplied every image that was painted with her words.

“I cannot breathe near you without wanting you, Morrigan!”

Syona saw a recent entry, unlike the ones she saw before, and it had a name that spiked her interest.

Project Rej., Entry 93

Facial symmetry is achieved, yet the results are inconsistent with the readings and measurements. All de-aging properties have been successfully applied, yet the process has resulted in worsening the effect. Further testing on live subjects has revealed the necessity of using a full transplant. Basic scientific means might be limited. Transplant donor body requires using correctly proportioned facial structure. Testing has suggested sharp, bony features...

And further down the page, scribbled hastily with new ink, the words.

Subject found. (M)

“I want you, Morrigan! I want to be you, that beautiful body of yours, that perfect face, those tasty lips!”

Syona’s breaths were shallow, no thought of concealing herself or her own sounds of breathing, her hands quickly flipping pages.

“I will be beautiful like you, I will be you, Morrigan! I will take you and fuck you and be you! And then, I will have him!”

Entry 117

She is so perfect. I cannot stop thinking about her. I see her in my mind, in my thoughts, in my dreams. I can no longer focus on what I need. I just want her. I need her. I wish I could feel her inside me. At times I even imagine them both together, and sometimes I am her as he erupts in me—

“I hate you, Morrigan, for ruining everything, you beautiful, bombshell *bitch!* *Aaaaaahhhhooh! Morrigan!*”

Junia’s hips jerked, her back fully arched in a rigid bow. She screamed Morrigan’s name, the word tearing from her throat like a curse. Her climax was hard and violent, and her fingers worked on, milking every spasm.

Junia had started sobbing through it, tears streaming down her face with her eyes still closed, her body twisting in agony of that desperate release.

Syona carefully put the journal back to where she found it, a shaking hand doing its best to keep quiet. Quickly and quietly, she slipped back to the wardrobe, pushed at the false panel, and retreated from the room and the estate.

Junia, meanwhile, still lay there. Panting, crying, her body limp and glistening in the moonlight, her hand still between her legs, tired and in bliss.

“Rexas,” she whispered, the name spoken with a reverence reserved for the most special of peoples. “Wait for me. Soon I will become what you truly want.”

XII

The moon had risen high enough to cast silver beams through the tall windows of Lady Morrigan's bedchamber, illuminating the scattered silks and velvets laid across her settee. She stood before a looking glass in a state of partial undress, her cream and gold brocade gown still clinging to her with the corset halfway unlaced.

The anticipation of the morrow sent a thrill through her core. The last time they had met, Lady Goth had sent her flying—though whether it was literal was still up for discussion. Though she was curious, Lady Morrigan had decided against asking her about it. The unreality of it all, the possibility that Lady Goth sent her senses spiraling so much that she hallucinated; it was a memory she wanted to keep, the idea that the world turned on its head with her touch and her lips.

She wanted to look her best for her, and in the looking glass she saw a woman ready to be adorned with royal apparel. Lady Morrigan first held up one gown, then another, and another, discarding each with a critical eye. Too prim. Too provincial. Too much like the woman she had been before the gala, before the woman in black had shown her what her body was capable of craving.

She needed something that would make Lady Goth's eyes darken the moment she saw her. Something that spoke of invitation without desperation.

Or I could just appear before her as I came to this world, naked and pure. In truth, she would not care for my desperation.

"Pauli," she called out, "come here."

The door opened moments later, and Paulette stepped inside, her simple cotton dress clinging to her curves in a way that suggested she had recently bathed.

Morrigan held Paulette's gaze in the mirror, watching the young woman's eyes widen as they traveled over Morrigan's form, watching her lips part slightly. She enjoyed Paulette's lingering looks at her, more so now than ever.

"You called, milady?" with a soft voice and blue eyes darkening, Paulette took in the sight of Lady Morrigan standing half-dressed.

"I need your help with these laces," Morrigan said, turning her back but keeping her eyes on Paulette through the mirror. She raised her arms slightly, presenting the long line of her back. "I cannot sleep until I've decided on something suitable. Help me out of it."

Paulette approached with halting steps. "Of course, milady." She worked at the corset ties carefully, slowly, shivering as each lace was tugged and loosened. The fabric gave way and revealed the spine of Morrigan's back. "What exactly should the dress be suitable for, milady?"

Lady Morrigan turned around, facing Paulette. "Something functional, easy on the eyes yet uncomplicated in removing it."

Paulette unlaced the rest, her hands more often wandering unconsciously to trace the lines of her ribs and brushed aside her chest, as if on accident.

Lady Morrigan smiled. *If it was some other, sterner mistress in my stead, she would definitely punish her for such familiarity. Poor girl, so close, yet her station demands distance.*

“You’re trembling, Pauli,” Lady Morrigan observed, her smile turning to a smirk. She could see the tips of the young woman’s breasts stiffen. “Is the room cold?”

The blue of the moonlight could not have masked the red of Paulette’s cheeks. “No! No, milady!” She spoke aloud, before coughing and speaking in a whisper. “It’s quite...*warm!*”

As she spoke that last word, the corset fell away, and Lady Morrigan remained only in a chemise and her stockings. The firelight from the hearth made the fabric translucent, and Paulette breathed in. Lady Morrigan could see the nervousness in her eyes, her gaze shifting away from Morrigan, stealing glances at her form as the light revealed more of her.

Lady Morrigan decided it was torture enough. “Fetch me the box in the upper dresser.”

Paulette nodded with a light bow, and with quick steps reached the drawer, pulling out a wooden box with a velvet exterior. She carried it towards Lady Morrigan, who opened it. It had several necklaces, each with a pendant of a different color. There was emerald, jade, sapphire, and even a few obsidian locket. Lady Morrigan picked one up, holding it up against Paulette’s neck.

“The color of midnight would suit the company.” She said, and moved aside to let Paulette look at herself in the mirror, while still holding the necklace up to her.

“It is a beautiful piece, milady.” Paulette said. “May I ask who is the company it should suit?”

“Lady Goth, it’s supposed to be for. I want her to...” Lady Morrigan decided against elaborating further. It would just make her more unable to prevent torturing this poor girl further.

But she saw Paulette’s demeanor shift, and she looked right at Lady Morrigan through the mirror, into her eyes.

“I want her gaze to fall *here*,” Lady Morrigan said, taking Paulette’s hand and putting it to her neck. “As much as I’d love to have her look at me like you do at present, Pauli.”

“Ahem, yes, milady,” she stammered. “Do you have something in gold, then, to match your eyes?”

“All of these are adorned with gemstones, I’m afraid, and stones sit on gold, not the other way.”

“Then, if I may, milady,” Paulette shifted in front of Lady Morrigan, turning to look into her eyes. “I have something. I’m afraid it’s not to someone of your stature and station but...it does match your eyes, tawny like yours.”

“I don’t think it’s in my wardrobe, is it?”

“No, milady. Shall I fetch it for you?”

“Please, do.”

As Paulette left, Lady Morrigan took off her chemise, and put on a robe, lacing it loosely at the front.

The lady-in-waiting returned shortly after, and in her hand held a necklace—the pendant seemed to look like bone, either naturally in the shape of a tooth or carved like one. There also looked to be strange runes carved on the bony surface. The pendant was held up by a string, clearly not a piece of valuable jewelry, but something of a charm, or a heirloom.

“Is this yours, Pauli?” Morrigan asked, taking it, feeling the weight of it against her palm.

“I brought it from a traveling merchant, milady. When you left with the Syona woman for the estate, I worried for your safety. He said this is a good luck charm. I hope it brings you safety, milady.”

Morrigan turned the pendant over in her fingers, then looked up at Paulette, and pressed it in her hands. “I cannot have this, Pauli. You paid for it, and you should keep it. I have been spoilt with the selection of dresses and jewelry I have. Luck and fortune I have aplenty.”

Paulette pushed it back towards Lady Morrigan. “I brought it as a gift for you, milady. I just...didn’t know how to give it to you.”

“If you insist, then. Help me put it on.”

Paulette took it from her hand, her fingers brushing against Morrigan’s, who—for her part—loosened the silk robe. It gaped open, revealing the long, pale line of her back, the graceful curve of her spine, and the soft swell of her hips.

She felt Paulette’s sharp breath, a little gasp of surprise that was quickly stifled. The young woman’s hands trembled slightly as she brought the necklace around her front, and Lady Morrigan felt her trembling fingers at the nape of her neck.

Every touch was charged, electric, lingering for a moment too long against her as Paulette’s thumbs brushed her sensitive skin. Every touch sent a shiver down Morrigan’s spine, and she closed her eyes, imperceptibly leaning into her lady-in-waiting’s brushes.

She could feel the heat radiating from Paulette’s body, could smell the clean, innocent scent of her soap. She had freshly bathed before retiring for the night. As the clasp fastened, her hands went to her shoulders, resting there for a heartbeat with a light, questioning pressure.

Lady Morrigan then opened her eyes, seeing the girl’s reflection in the mirror. Paulette’s face seemed to hold plenty—worry,

confusion, a something else; a new, dawning awareness that felt positively thrilling.

She stared at her lady-in-waiting through the mirror, the structure of her face, her full lips, sharp jaw—everything was strikingly similar to her own.

Her cheeks were flushed a deep, pretty pink, and her eyes were wide—fixed on Morrigan’s exposed skin. She was flustered, utterly undone by her lady’s display of flesh.

Slowly, Lady Morrigan turned, facing Paulette, standing straight as if presenting herself to her. The silk robe was almost forgotten, loosely pooling around her arms, and the light of the moon shone both on Lady Morrigan and on her lady-in-waiting.

It illuminated the pale, smooth slopes of her breasts, the soft curve of her belly, and the faint, shadowed line that led downwards. Yet she saw Paulette’s eyes locked at the whalebone necklace that had settled perfectly in the valley between her breasts.

“What do you think, Pauli?” she asked in a low, husky murmur, breaking the wanting woman from her trance.

Paulette’s breath hitched audibly, and as if her hand had a will of its own, it rose slowly, trembling, and her fingers slowly clasped the cold bony pendant, her knuckles grazing the soft flesh that it lay on.

The touch made Lady Morrigan’s legs ache and grow weak, sending waves of want and desire through them both.

“You’re so beautiful,” Paulette whispered, before her eyes looked up at Lady Morrigan’s down at her chest, then back again, and she stammered. “I mean—it looks beautiful, milady.”

Then her eyes went back to her own hand, fixed to where they lay, close to Morrigan’s heart, almost as if shocked and unable to comprehend the boldness of her own actions.

“Your heart, my lady.” Her fingers left the necklace, and her hand lay flush against the top of her breasts, where the thumping came from. “It’s beating so fast.”

Lady Morrigan smiled. “And why do you presume it would be so, Pauli?”

Lady Morrigan only looked at that hungry, helpless look in Paulette’s eyes, the way her breath hitched, the way her own chest heaved with each breath.

The world—her world—was becoming full of dangerous, beautiful things, and it seemed that Lady Morrigan had discovered the latter much closer to home than she had ever deemed possible.

XIII

“Milady, your guest has arrived.”

Paulette tilted her head down, her hands clasped together as she bowed, but Lady Morrigan’s attention was elsewhere. She already knew of her arrival. She was watching it happen through the window, with rapt attention.

The carriage was drawn by two horses, one of burnt umber and the other black as midnight. The sheen of their coats glinted against the morning sun, their long manes flowing as the stallions came to a halt.

As the carriage door opened, she saw her, and already, Lady Morrigan was drooling.

Her legs were covered in silk stockings and tied with ribbon garters, ending with black, heeled ankle-boots. Her dress was a careful architecture of fabric, each layer both concealing and defining her. She had a black, tightly laced corset of stiffened cotton pulling her torso into an upright, constrained line, lifting the bust and narrowing the waist in ways that made Lady Morrigan whimper. The gown itself was heavy, the bodice cut close and structured, fashioned from velvet and fastened with small buttons. It was further trimmed with

restrained lace at the throat and cuffs. The neckline itself was higher than Lady Morrigan would have liked, yet her breasts still stood prominent, accentuated by the corset.

She walked as if the earth beneath her was parting for her, the weight of each step something for the ground to savor. Morrigan had longed to see Lady Goth again, wished so heavily since their time together that she would get to pleasure her again. By now, though, their times and pleasures together had been numerous and long, each ending in a long bout of conversation that they held unclothed, never a single inch of the body left dry as they told each other tales that regaled the mind and wet the senses with further longing to begin their dance once again.

She took a deep breath, and saw Lady Goth do the same, just before her lady-in-waiting welcomed her in.

“Tea and biscuits, milady? Or perhaps some other warm refreshments?”

“Some wine would be exquisite. I’m in the mood to be serenaded by a Chateau vintage.”

Paulette bowed and left to fetch the beverage as Lady Morrigan descended the stairs of the main hall and welcomed her guest to her domain.

“It’s a pleasure to have you here with me, my lady,” Morrigan said. The distance between them closed as the visiting woman reached the foot of the staircase, Lady Morrigan standing just a step higher. It made Lady Goth look at her, tilting her face up, a position she hoped would frequent them more often.

“And what shall we get to, now that you do, my lady Morrigan?”

“Indulge in unladylike behavior, of course.” Lady Morrigan answered, a wide, toothy smile gracing her lips.

“Lets. And do tell that lovely girl who greeted me to fetch the wine quicker. These parched lips have been left wanting for far too long.” She said, as she slid a hand across Lady Morrigan’s arm, and the both of them started walking up the stairs.

“In that case, let me.”

Lady Morrigan took her hand, bringing it to her lips. She placed her thumb just before them and opened it just enough to let her tongue out and wet her finger, before bringing it to Lady Goth. She lightly traced her lips, first the bottom, then the top, as the both of them stood frozen on the staircase, looking into each other’s eyes.

When Morrigan’s hand returned back to her side, Lady Goth licked her lips, and closed her eyes, before a smile formed, and they both erupted in laughter.

“Come. We have much to discuss.”

“Discuss we will, in great detail. But not without the wine. Speaking of..”

Paulette was just outside their bedchamber door as they both went in, and the tray was put down at the dresser. The wine was poured in, and she left the pair of them alone.



It was torture enough, trying to breathe in that corset, but he didn’t make it any easier. He breathed in a way that made it look like

a show, and he was the centerpiece on the stage. His chest heaved, his muscular abdomen almost looked to convulse, as he picked up another sheet of metal with his bare hands.

Other men could only manage two at a time, yet he did it on his own. His shoulders did most of the work, as she noted so meticulously. She was studying his movements, wanting to be educated by each and every one of them.

Thoroughly.

She watched him work the forge. Bright, tangy firelight making him shine, the sweat on his brow dropping down like tears across his face. She watched his back, the muscles on it, and the pale skin around cringe and tighten as his arm went up, and back down again for a swing.

Clang! The hammer went, and he worked away, passing newly heated and hammered sheet through the rolling mills, operating the mechanism and mechanical levers by his lonesome. She watched him as he lifted stacks of metal bars, and placed them in the forge for melting, soot and sweat covering the rest of his body before he'd wipe it off and she'd see the smooth, waxen paleness return.

If not for this tight corset and the ever-so-restrictive dress, she'd have worked her magic. She yearned for the spell that would take away those wants of hers. She could touch through her dress, yet skin she couldn't reach, and that only made her feel for him ever more.

And then, he paused, wiped his brow, and his face—for the first time in quite a few minutes—came to her view. She'd been so focused at the rest of him that seeing framed in such a manner made it feel like she was laying eyes on him for the first time.

The green-blue-alabaster skin almost had a glow of its own against the lights of the furnace, hues of marigold and marmalade mixed in with the ethereal-like sheen. The scars only made it better. It showed

her that he was not perfect, that he could be hurt, or could be torn apart. It made him more precious to her, something of value, to be protected and cherished like a delicate piece of glass.

His mouth was slightly gaping, evocative as it was already, but she quickly realized he was staring at her, in ways that made her feel like commanding him to rip apart the corset from her. It was the quickest way to reach the destinations they both wanted, after all.

But she would not want the quickest way with him. That would be tragically short, under any circumstance. Over too soon and without a formal introduction to every part of him, and every part of her. She wanted each to meet, to shake proverbial hand and fall into embrace. She wanted close, unrelinquishable contact.

For now, the sight of him sated her need, though it only increased her want. This was the object of her desire, the hulking creature of more bone than flesh, more a skeletal visage than a person-ed one, eyes with more depth than the shallow reaches of the men that so frequently wanted her company—claiming innocence in their insistence. He was more a man than a man could ever be, and he was so close to her, yet so far.

She wanted to be closer. To smell his hair, however covered in soot and grime it would be. She wanted to see him as he was, his naked self in all manners of speaking. It made him seem real, feel real.

Clang! His hammering continued. She saw him grip the handle and hold the metal firm with his other gloved hand. Even from her position above him, perched on the metal walkways, she could see the muscles contract on his arms as they strained against the weight of the steel.

It was torture enough. To try to breathe in that corset.



“That’s where she put him to work?”

“At the foundry, yes, where he melts metal and flattens them. She thinks he’s to be kept away from prying eyes or else the world turns on her creation.”

Lady Goth recounted just what she did most of the hours in her day, as she sipped on wine with Lady Morrigan as they both lay on the bed. The gala-woman was resting her head on her dear friend’s lap.

“Cruelty, to be trapped like so.”

“I see him working at it almost every day now.”

“Do you ever talk to him?”

“In a way, a few weeks ago.”

Lady Morrigan was stroking her head with one hand, occasionally playing with a strand of hair. The other was caught between Lady Goth’s own, as she explored her host’s palms and fingers almost absent-mindedly, though Lady Morrigan herself was very attentive at every sensation she felt.

“What did you talk about?”

“There wasn’t a lot of conversing that we did.”

Lady Morrigan’s lips broke into a wide smile. “Oh? Do tell.”

“A cold, lonely morning it was. The only heat I could feel was between my legs at the thought of him, and I desired to feel warm on that cold day.”

She stopped fidgeting with Lady Morrigan's fingers, took hold of her wrist, and brought it to her chest, just above her breasts. Morrigan could feel the heat in her, the quick beating of her heart.

"The furnace would have sufficed, so with that poor excuse I went down to the floor where he works."

She brought Lady Morrigan's hand up to her collarbone, touching her neckline, before bringing it up to her cheeks. She nestled her cheek in Morrigan's palm, who then used her thumb to caress that cheek, feeling her smooth, warm skin.

"He was occupied, and unaware of my approach. If he had been, his demeanor lacked indication for it."

She brought her hand lower again and set it back against her neck this time. Lady Morrigan felt it heating up, almost as if sporting a fever. *A fever it is, cured only by delicate, loving hands and lips.*

She stopped stroking Lady Goth's head for a second and took a sip of wine to calm her nerves, before resuming her favorite activity again.

"I could've called out, yet I wanted to see if he'd feel my presence first." She looked into Lady Morrigan's eyes. "I wanted to see if the warmth from him could compete with the fire."

"And did it?" Lady Morrigan asked, looking back into her eyes, locked together, hands starting to wander, going where nobody else had permission to.

"Maybe he had seen me, for in the next instance he had me pinned against the wall and at his mercy."

"And then what?"

Lady Morrigan was breathing heavily now, and so was the woman in her lap. Her own breasts were heaving with each breath, the heat in her own core dangerously close to being felt by the woman whose head was resting so close to where she wanted it to be.

“Then I raised my arm and slapped him without saying a word.”

“Oh!” Lady Morrigan exclaimed, a look of playful shock on her face. She knew this woman too well, and she knew this would not be the end of that encounter.

“Such innocence in his expression, such fear at having slighted against me. His hunched form so innocent and broken as my hand dove across his cheek and he lightly caressed it to ease his pain. I could never have physically harmed him with that slap. He only dreaded the possibility of disappointing me.”

Her hand was still grasping at Lady Morrigan’s and was now back to where it had started, right over her chest this time. Lady M’s hand raised and lowered with each breath, and her heart was beating so fast Lady M could not help but make a loud, audible gulp.

“*My Lady, have I wronged you?*” he said.” She attempted to mimic his voice, loud and gruff, but with a pained innocence that made even Lady Morrigan’s mouth wet and watery. “I exchanged no words. Only took hold of that innocent face, and brought it to mine own to kiss him.”

Her face was writhing now, turning left and right, and the movements made Lady Morrigan’s own heat more apparent with every shift.

“Oh, such bliss! How could I describe it?”

Lady Goth’s eyes were closed now, her face buried in Lady Morrigan’s dress, trapping the hand stroking her hair in between. Lady M’s other hand had left her chest already as Lady Goth pulled it lower, using her own hand to raise her dress to facilitate what came next.

“His strength lifted me with ease and I was up against the wall, his own body used to prop me in the air. His hands were free to do what they wished, and so was his mouth. *Oh...*”

Lady Morrigan's hand, guided Goth's, which had disappeared beneath the dress, the other hand now free to grasp and knead at her breasts.

"Then, he buried his face in my neck, and he didn't waste any time doing this."

She took the hand stroking her face, and brought it to her chest, beneath the fabric and the corset, and Lady Morrigan could feel the skin in all its glory.

It was smooth, as expected, and so was the place at the other end, same as her own.

"I could feel him, feel the thing I wanted most from him, as he thrust against me. I was still wearing...everything, otherwise our skin would have slipped against each other. His own was covered in sweat and soot from the furnace, but I could not even feel that heat anymore."

A moan escaped Goth's lips as Lady M explored the areas in between her legs and lightly traced around her mounds. If Lady M's palm was on one breast, she grabbed the other.

"I don't think he had the capability of thinking enough to be able to take off his clothes...*abhh*. How could I describe it, Morrigan, but show it to you?!"

Her hand on her breasts immediately left them, and shot up to grab behind Lady Morrigan's neck, before pulling her head down to her own, locking her lips with her host.

She trailed off. Lady Morrigan could feel the sweetness of the wine, the scent of grapes and juniper berries, of sunflower oil and lilac perfumes. Their kiss didn't stop, continuing on as Lady Morrigan put her fingers to use, doing what *he* had been unable to, and reached inside of the woman's folds.

"HMMMMMph?"

It was all she could say, all the noise either of them could muster. In that moment, Lady Goth brought Lady Morrigan's hands up to her lips.

"Taste me," she said in a commanding tone.

Not losing her sense of urgency, Lady Morrigan obliged as she cleaned off her own fingers, savoring every iota of her flavor.

A few quick releases of their mouths had them struggling to draw breath, before she hungrily reached for Lady Morrigan's lips again with her own. Their kisses became quicker and quicker, more and more frantic as the seconds, minutes, or perhaps hours went on. They massaged each other's tongues, kissed some more, touched and grabbed and kneaded where they could.

Epochs could have passed and ended, but it wouldn't have mattered. The only thing left burning was the fire in between Lady Morrigan's legs, as she brought her thighs together, clashing skin against waxed skin, in yearning to be cared for like she was caring for the woman in her lap.

To Lady Morrigan, Lady Goth looked positively delicious. Her hair was slightly wet, with all the sweat and heat that had accumulated, and each breath only made her other features more apparent. If not for the fire in her, she would have lapped at her again, but Lady Goth was not in the place to give her what she needed. And she needed *him*.

XIV

The ache had been persistent throughout the day, a low hum beneath her skin that was refusing to fade. Like the ghost of the fire left behind by Lady Goth, the flames were still lit, a candle if not a bonfire—though at times it did become such an inferno.

Lady Goth had departed and left her in quiet desperation, and Lady Morrigan wondered if she had done the same to her.

No wonder she was so eager to come here...and so eager to come.

She still felt her every time that fire burned even a little bit brighter, phantom touches of the woman that had been allowed in her deepest places and had made full use of her decadence. Now all that residual energy demanded an outlet, and Lady Morrigan knew of only one such that could possibly fulfill that desire...

She remembered what she had seen back at Junia's estate, how Lady Goth's body had writhed in pleasure staring into her eyes, how she had wished it was her tongue pleasuring her so, how it was her being pleased to no end by the yet unseen rod that he no doubt had between his legs...

The way she had surrendered to his brutal form was nothing short of magical. The vantage point of seeing her in that position, being pleased to her utmost satisfaction—and not feeling that twinge of

envy she had expected to feel when someone she wanted was not in her own arms—that was new. Lady Morrigan had expected to feel jealous towards the creature, to feel possessive of Lady Goth, or perhaps to feel those things towards them both. Yet all she felt was that heat between her legs, that heat that once again threatened to engulf her, the flames of sexual wrath being her most welcome doom.

The sounds of her moans played on a relentless loop, even the ones that had just been hummed into her mouth as her fingers brought Lady Goth to pleasure. They were all unforgettable, and she wished she could preserve them in some imaginary biomechanical device that René and Syona fashioned from naught but thought and sexual turbulence. That way, she could *actually* listen to her scream her name in erotic ecstasy day in and day out, her hands never leaving her thighs as she spent days, weeks, and months caged and trapped in a prison of ecstasy, turning her hands like keys in a lock as they would twist and turn to work away at her sex, attempting to open that dam and turn to sweet release.

Tonight, though, that otherwise persistent ache had reached a breaking point, and Lady Morrigan had always been one to treat the disease, rather than the symptom—though in this case treating the symptom had been no less fun.

She called upon her lady-in-waiting, who approached her bedchamber with an expression she wore quite often around her—an earnest mixture of devotion and concern.

“Pauli. Come here.” Lady Morrigan said to the girl, who approached with quick, eager steps and stood beside her. She reached into her wardrobe, picking out an outfit reserved for her escapades out into the world where she was no Lady. A studded leather jerkin and trousers, all black, and a similar one to match.

“Are you going somewhere, milady?” Paulette asked her.

“We are, Pauli.”

“Is it not late? Our trips are seldom in the dead of night.”

Should I tell her what I intend to do? “Late it is, but this is hardly ever done with the sun out and about, Pauli.”

“What is, milady?” She instinctively reached out to her, grazing Lady Morrigan’s arm in concern.

Lady Morrigan smiled. She was touched every time her lady-in-waiting showed her such affection and was wrought with such concern. “Come with me and find out.”



They rode in silence, a single torch guiding them through the streets of Geneva as Lady Morrigan led her to a place lords or ladies seldom frequented. They went past the outskirts, took a winding road through a canopy of trees and past forest brush where the crickets chirped.

The smell gradually changed along their path, wildflower scents giving way to an acrid tang of coal smoke and hot metal.

There it was, exactly where and how Syona had described.

It was small, almost strangely inconspicuous how it stood by its lonesome. A singular workshop well past the edge of town, a low sprawling building of brick and iron, squatting against a small open

yard and smoke rising from the chimneys. A single, flickering lantern cast a sickly yellow glow.

“Aren’t these the lady-doctor Junia’s estate grounds?” Paulette asked as they approached.

“Aye.” Lady Morrigan’s head was far too busy trying not to think to make any other answer.

Here she was, doing what, exactly?

What do you plan on doing once you see him? Do you simply intend to work your hands, or perhaps it is his touch you desire?

She dismounted from the horse, but Paulette remained seated on hers.

“Milady?”

Morrigan continued towards the unguarded iron-wood door.

“Morrigan!”

Lady Morrigan stopped as Paulette hurriedly disembarked from her horse, jogging towards her. “Milady, it’s not safe for you to go in there.”

“Stay in the office adjoining the main floor. I won’t be long.”

Paulette’s hand shot out, gripping her arm with a desperate strength. “No, Morrigan, please. Don’t go. It’s dangerous.”

Morrigan turned towards her, and saw the genuine terror in her eyes, her crystal-blue pupils dark in the night, the light from the window reflecting on them.

But her desire burned too fiercely, and Paulette was not equipped to supplement her wants. She reached up and gently cupped Paulette’s cheek.

“I’ll be safe, my sweet. I promise.” She leaned in and pressed her lips to the woman’s cheek, trying to be chaste as she could, though she knew that it was her own fire trying desperately to reach out to

whatever—or whoever—was near. “Wait for me by the office, Pauli. Please.”

Why did I even bring her here? Would I not be able to think better if I was alone?

Without waiting for another protest, either from her lady-in-waiting or from her own heart and mind, Lady Morrigan turned and slipped towards the heavy, iron-studded door of the workshop, her heart pounding a frantic, exhilarating rhythm against her ribs.



The air was hot and thick, heavy with the smell of coal and heated metal. It felt like a primal, masculine scent that settled deep in her lungs, and the distant *clang* of hammer striking steel like a percussive heartbeat.

The sound came from below, well underground.

Good. Pauli should be safe up in the office, and not surrounded by darkness.

And it was dark. The rooms did not have anything else but a candlelight, if they had one at all. Lady Morrigan followed the sound until she reached some stairs, and followed them down.

You're not exactly hidden well here, you know.

The brilliant orange sparks were the ones that first welcomed her, cascading into the gloom as the only source of light. And situated as

a silhouette against it was *him*—a tall mountain of a man with a hellish, ethereal glow. His movements were powerful and economical as he worked a sheet of glowing red metal on an anvil.

She was transfixed on that sight, the only thing to look at in the darkness, but as she crept along the periphery, she tripped on a hammer, or *something*, that clattered loudly on the floor.

She *had* intended to spy, just like last time, but had forgotten about the catwalks. They would have given her the same vantage point as Lady Goth.

Too late now.

He turned with a quickness that betrayed his stature. His eyes glowed luminous against the firelight, and with ultimate speed found her instantly. There was no surprise in his face, strangely enough, only a chilling, unnerving recognition.

“You should not be here.” He spoke in a low, gravelly rumble.

He says?! He SAYS!?

It had almost not occurred to her, the repeated mentions of sentience that Syona had found in the doctor’s journal, that this thing would talk. Not even Lady Goth’s recounting her encounter made her realize it.

Morrigan’s heart began to hammer even faster, though if she felt any fear, it was a thin, sharp veneer over a much deeper and potent emotion.

She was exhilarated.

He stopped before her, his sheer, overwhelming size blocking out the light from the forge. He was even more imposing up close as Lady Morrigan looked at him, silhouetted against the light. Scarred flesh and corded muscle covered him.

“I remember you, and your scent.” He said, his gaze pinning her in place as he drew closer. “You were watching me and the lady, were you not?”

Lady Morrigan stood there, frozen and quiet, unable to articulate a single word as the fire in the forge paled in comparison to the one between her thighs. Like melting steel, she dripped onto the stone floor, the fire and the smell of hot iron masking her womanly scents.

In a flash he balled his hand into a fist, and sent it crashing towards the wall right beside Lady Morrigan, and she felt the air shift as his hand went flying past her.

“WERE YOU NOT?!” He roared.

And even now, she could not answer.

Yet instead of intensifying his anger, his next question was spoken in a much softer tone, though it still held a quiet fury. “Why were you spying on us?”

He is being...possessive?

“I...I was curious.” Morrigan managed. Her words were spoken in a breathless whisper.

“Curious creatures tend to want to speak about their findings.” He said as his eyes narrowed, and he drew even closer. “Will you speak of what you’ve seen?”

She could smell the clean scent of his sweat, feel the heat radiating from his skin. But most of all, the articulation of his speech gave her joy.

He talks, really talks.

Almost in ignorance of his question, a reckless, overwhelming need to bridge the gap between them took over Lady Morrigan, and she reached out to him. Her fingers trembled as she placed a hand on his chest, letting the palm lay flat as she felt his beating heart.

Oh, fuck.

Her knees grew weak at the electric static that contact made her feel. His skin was hot. Not just from furnace, but *hot*. Like the warmth of a gentle lover, intensified under the fires of carnal need. Her hands roamed around, feeling the texture of scars and sinew beneath her palms, as well as the immense, solid power of muscle. She gave him a tug, heavy as she could in her half-frozen state, yet he did not flinch or pull away. His brutal strength was enough to allow her anything, because he knew she was no danger.

He knew that, right?

The danger was electrifying. He could snap her in two at any moment, yet here she was, objectifying his form, and he let her. It was the most erotic thing she had ever felt.

Losing all control, all semblance of safety, and acting on impulse more powerful than any she had ever known, she rose on her toes and closed the distance that remained between them, pressing her lips to his.

The light of the forge would pale next to the violent conflagration of the way their lips locked together. A current shot straight through her spine and coiled deep in her core. His mouth was firm as opposed to her pliancy, the scent of sweat mixed in with his manly, masculine musk as the aroma made her head swim and her thighs clench.

It was a clumsy, desperate kiss. He was still for a moment before he, too, joined in. He parted his lips, tasting her tongue on his. It was a gentle, curious exploration, almost unbecoming of his intimidating demeanor. *Almost*.

Then he pulled back, though only slightly, his eyes searching hers, and like their first meeting, lifted her effortlessly into the air, bringing her closer to the light before he pinned her against the hot stone walls.

“You scent,” he rumbled. There was profound confusion and wonder in his voice. “I sense her on you.”

His gaze then fell to her neck, as his hands reached up to her, finding the chord that ran around her neck. He brought it up, and his eyes laid on the small bone-carving pendant.

The tension in his massive frame seemed to ease, and he gently let her down.

“A kindred spirit, I see.” The rumble in his voice was gone, and instead it had been replaced with a gentleness that Lady Morrigan had not expected of someone like him. “You should go, my lady.” There was a weary resignation in his voice.

No, no. Please, please put your hand back where it belongs! Let me have you if only for a few more moments!

He stepped aside, creating a path back up the stairs and out of that workshop.

“I—”

“My lady,” His voice had turned to a plea, the innocence reminding her of Paulette, of the woman who had been left waiting in the office upstairs. “Please.”

The fire in her had turned into an inferno long ago, and it was enough to burn away the world. Yet she knew it was no use prying a few moments of love from someone who didn’t want them.

I cannot make him do anything. He is his own person, isn’t he? Even if he is...

She gave him a final, lingering look, and then turned and fled. It reminded her of the way she had run away from him before, and just like last time, her body was thrumming with a desperate, aching need that was now more potent and dangerous than ever before.

And she ran, up the stairs however her weak legs could carry her, and made her way to the door, and as soon as she exited the workshop, she ran into Paulette waiting by the entrance.

“Milady, I heard loud noises, I—” And then she noticed Lady Morrigan’s disheveled, sweaty, breathless state. “Are you alright, Morrigan?” She grabbed her face with both hands, looking over her, examining every part of her. “Did that thing hurt you?”

Morrigan couldn’t find the words, and only shook her head. There was only one, singular sensation in her mind now. The forcefulness, the gentleness, the raw, untamed power that personified him—she had witnessed and felt only a glimpse of it, and Lady Goth had experienced it whole. Even this glimpse had been everything she had fantasized about, and more.

“You must stay away from him,” Paulette pleaded. Morrigan’s hands reached out to grasp Paulette’s arms as hers remained clutching her face. “I’m scared for you, Morrigan. I don’t want you to get hurt.”

Again, Morrigan only shook her head.

“You don’t understand, Pauli.” A frenzy of heated anger and frustrated yearning took over her, her cunt aching and painful in spite of everything. “You don’t know what this lust is like, to need something more so than anything else.”

“Milady, but I do!”

Lady Morrigan had done much with Paulette these past few weeks, much in the way of seduction. She had never been encouraging to her, but also, she never dissuaded Morrigan from her advances, if one could call them that. She felt drawn towards Paulette, wanted her in a way that she had never wanted anyone else. There was an innocence in her, a naiveté that neither Lady Goth nor *he* possessed. The way she drew Morrigan to herself was entirely different from any lust, and that draw was something she had been struggling to understand ever since she had taken Paulette in her employ.

Then perhaps, it should not have been too unexpected, for the woman to pull Lady Morrigan's head towards her own, and lock their lips together in a kiss.

That was it, the final, earth-shattering trigger that sent Lady Morrigan over the edge of her lucidity. A sharp, ragged gasp tore from her throat into Paulette's mouth as her entire body seized at sanity's eclipse, and a violent, convulsive crash took over her body. White-hot, blinding pleasure, so intense that it was painful as it travelled from cunt to core, radiating outwards in a searing rush that stole her breath and her vision.

Her knees buckled, and Lady Morrigan dug her fingers into Paulette's shoulders, clutching her tightly as the woman's hands found their way into Lady Morrigan's neck and locks.

She held on to her lady-in-waiting for dear life as a loud, uninhibited moan escaped her as their lips broke contact. It was the sound of pure, unadulterated release.

Lady Morrigan moaned and screamed again as another pleasure-wave came. Drowning in the storm of her orgasm, her body trembled uncontrollably against the smaller woman's frame, who had now put her arms around Lady Morrigan in an embrace.

XV

The bedchamber was cold tonight, so much so that the covers did not provide the warmth needed. The curtains were half-drawn, the windows slightly ajar, letting the moonlight flood the room in a pale, silvery glow that turned everything to ivory-white and dark shadows, and illuminating another vision before her.

The glass was frosted just enough to transform the light into patterns—stars and diamonds dancing across the walls, as though the heavens themselves had come to witness what would unfold in this wanting night.

Lady Morrigan lay on her side, her nightgown thin and sheer, the linen doing little to conceal the curves beneath. Beside her, she lay; a vision of beauty complete, her raven hair spread across the pillow, her own gown cut from midnight silk that clung to her every crevice. They had drawn close for warmth, knees touching, shoulders bumping, releasing shivering sensations with every contact.

Lady Goth had invited her to her abode, the both of them feeling frigid in their longing for him, and having experienced his touch, Lady Morrigan felt that frigidness herself. They both understood what it meant, why they needed to be close together tonight.

They would have made their trek down to him, at his workshop, or perhaps even sneaked their way to Junia's home, if they knew he was there. He often disappeared from their knowledge, even from Syona's own watchful eye. The doctor was keeping him away, perhaps, out of jealousy and spite newly discovered within her arsenal.

In their proximity Lady Morrigan could also breathe in her scent, and what an aroma it was. She had put on a scent of lilacs and darkshades tonight, and Lady Morrigan felt like she was standing in a field of flowers, sun-kissed green under the midday haze, surrounded by purple and violet lavender bushels, and small shrubs of berries she would pluck and bring to her lips, before another pair would engulf her own, looking for the taste of the fruit, exchanging it with a clash of tongues.

They were both in their nightgowns, having lounged on the bed for quite a while, sipping on wine on occasion, and the enticement of eventually getting to peel off the layers the only reason that they had any clothes on to begin with. It was quite cold, too, and Lady Morrigan felt so every time she would get up from the bed to fetch some wine. The marble-stone would surround her feet with a chill, and then she would retreat back to the bed, where Lady Goth would touch and caress them, surrounding them with sweet kisses until she felt warm again.

They both had their bodices on still, laced up, their hands occasionally finding a string until the urge to remove them got too strong. At times, a string was unlaced, yet there were many more to go yet. They did not want to begin too quickly. A sudden hint of bare flesh, and all pretense of their slow foreplay would have vanished. Tonight was a night to take it slow.

"Miss him already, don't you, my sweet?" Lady Goth said, her low and sultry voice purring as it vibrated through Morrigan's bones.

“Some parts of him more than others,” Morrigan admitted, her breath misting in the cold air, and their hands playing with each other’s.

“Inspected closely, then?” she asked Morrigan with a slight thrill in her voice.

“Not closely enough.” She answered. Lady Morrigan licked her lips and gulped. “He stands taller even than the Potsdam Giants. A mountain of might wearing his innocence on his sleeve.”

“Which, of course, you love about him.” Lady Goth smiled, using her other hand to touch Morrigan’s arm.

“That, and more.” Morrigan smiled back, grazing Goth’s hand on her shoulder, and as she did, Lady Goth moved to place a gentle, wet kiss on the back of her it. They looked at each other, then, with hungry eyes. The heavens could have torn open then, ripped apart the roof from their heads, sent quakes and thunder-hurricanes—nothing would have averted Morrigan from staring back into her, breathing her in, feeling every tingle and jolt in her body that her lingering stare created.

“And what more do you love about him?” Lady Goth asked, her sultry voice echoing in her mind as her hand continued to caress her arm, their shared desire for him becoming a yearning for each other.

“What ‘more’ would you like to know?” Morrigan exhaled through bared teeth, unable to conceal her giddiness from her confidant.

“There can be so much. Do his slights avoid reprimand, for example? Do you excuse them as mere evidence of his purity?”

She rested her chin on Lady Morrigan’s shoulders.

“All I want is to offer him guidance.”

“Towards?” Lady Goth asked softly, the sultriness in her tone becoming a phonetic wave of pleasure through Lady Morrigan’s core.

“Towards what I want, admittedly.” Morrigan’s eyes dropped from Lady Goth, settling on her own lap. “What I need.”

“And what do you need?” Lady Goth asked, her breath close to Morrigan’s ear now.

“Closeness, for one.” She breathed.

“Closeness like this?”

“Closer still.”

Then Lady Goth edged closer, draping one leg over her, brushing their thighs together, her lips brushing Morrigan’s ear now. “And do you feel the need now?”

Morrigan turned her head, their mouths inches apart. “I couldn’t feel anything else in this moment.”

“Is it the same need as with me?”

Lady Morrigan paused. “I—it’s—”

“You need not fret, my sweetness. I know nothing compares to him.” Lady Goth continued, her voice dropping lower. She shifted, rising onto her elbow, and Morrigan felt the bed move as Lady Goth moved over her, straddling her thigh through the thin fabric. “Though I can give you an idea, a taste of things to come, if you will.”

Morrigan nodded, her throat too tight for words.

Lady Goth’s hand slid down, beneath the covers, finding the hem of Morrigan’s nightgown and pushing it upward until cool air touched her heated skin. “Open for me,” she commanded, and Morrigan obeyed, her legs parting, her body arching with anticipation.

Lady Goth placed her hand between Morrigan’s legs, her fingers finding the wetness there, coating themselves in it. Then, with a deliberate slowness, she pushed three fingers inside—all at once, filling her completely.

Morrigan cried out, her back arching off the bed, her hands fisting in the sheets.

“Feel the pain, Morrigan. There is no pleasure without pain,” Lady Goth whispered, her fingers curling inside her. She thrust harder, her palm grinding against Morrigan’s most sensitive place. “Do you feel it? The way he would stretch you?”

“Yes,” Morrigan gasped, her hips rocking into Lady Goth’s hand, seeking more, seeking deeper. “Oh, you and him both—”

Lady Goth leaned down, her mouth finding Morrigan’s breast through the sheer fabric of her gown, sucking hard, her teeth grazing the nipple. “You may have me for years on end,” she breathed against wet silk, her fingers still working. “You may touch and taste me a thousand times. Ten of me could appear and make love to you all at once, drown you in our sapphic serenity.”

Morrigan moaned, the image blazing behind her eyes—Lady Goth everywhere, surrounding her, filling her, a dozen mouths and hands and wet, sliding heat. She imagined them tangled together, Lady Goth between her legs, Lady Goth at her breasts, Lady Goth kissing her throat, Lady Goth everywhere, every tongue a new sensation, every hand on her most erogenous zones—

“And yet nothing,” Lady Goth continued to whisper, her fingers withdrawing suddenly, making Morrigan whimper, “nothing would compare to the way he would *fuck* you.”

She shifted again, rising fully now, and in one fluid motion, she removed her own nightgown, then Morrigan’s, tossing both garments to the floor. Now both were naked and bare, skin to skin, and Lady Goth positioned herself between Morrigan’s legs, her own thighs parting, her own wetness pressing against Morrigan’s.

“You would want for nothing but him,” Lady Goth began to move, her hips rolling, their sexes sliding together in friction. “You would

forget slumber, for it robs you of the chance to be with him for a few hours, taking all of him inside you.”

“Aaaahh—oh!”

“You’d forget to eat, save only for the sustenance needed to feel on all of the pleasure he gives you.”

Morrigan wrapped her legs around Lady Goth’s waist, pulling her closer, deeper, their bodies moving in rhythm now, simulating the act they both craved. “Show me,” Morrigan begged, her voice broken, her hands gripping Lady Goth’s hips. “Show me how he would take me—”

Lady Goth thrust harder, faster, their wetness mingling as sounds of clashing sexes filled the room in wet, rhythmic slaps of flesh against flesh.

“Like this,” she gasped. “He would take you like this, Morrigan.”

She leaned down, capturing Morrigan’s mouth in a kiss, and Morrigan felt herself spiraling, falling, drowning in the imagined sensations of being filled, even as she knew it was only a shadow of what awaited her.

Lady Goth broke the kiss with a gasp, her hips never ceasing their rhythm. “You cannot imagine,” she panted, her voice ragged with pleasure, “You cannot imagine the completeness of him inside you, my sweet, how he shapes you to him, bringing searing, amazing pain until the pain becomes pleasure, and pleasure becomes utter madness.”

Lady Morrigan’s nails dug into the other woman’s back, the consideration for pain against her hands leaving as Lady Goth winced and smiled.

Her hips snapped forward suddenly, hard and fast, and Morrigan screamed. “You may wet his appetite with your own wetness, as I have, but he will never be sated, Morrigan.”

Morrigan's vision blurred, the bedchamber seeming to melt before her eyes as her arousal consumed her. She wrapped her legs tighter, her heels digging into Lady Goth's rump, urging her deeper, harder.

Morrigan felt herself cresting, the wave building and building, when Lady Goth paused. Lady Morrigan looked up at her with pain in her eyes, a desperate plea she presented with them for her to continue.

Then, Lady Goth separated from her, drawing out a whimper from Morrigan, just as her lips were covered with Lady Goth's own. Morrigan pushed her hips upward in an effort to meet them with hers, but Lady Goth pulled back.

"He won't deny you like so, Morrigan, but in this instance, I will." She said, and then descended, her mouth trailing fire down Morrigan's form. She kissed her neck, bit at her stiffened peaks, ran her tongue down her trembling stomach, dipped into the hollow of her navel, and kept on going lower, lower, until she was there—her lips brushing the wet, swollen flesh that ached for her.

"And this," Lady Goth breathed, her breath hot against sensitive skin, "this taste, my sweet. I deny your release, so I can taste it at the edge, when it's at its sweetest and most exquisite."

Her tongue swept upward, a long, deliberate stroke that made Morrigan's hips buck off the bed. Lady Goth gripped her thighs, holding her still, and began to feast—lapping, sucking, her tongue circling the swollen bud of Morrigan's pleasure. Morrigan's hands found Lady Goth's hair, gripping tight as her body arched, her voice breaking on ecstatic moans and guttural groans of pleasure.

Then, she screamed. Her climax crashed through her as her body convulsed, her essence flooding Lady Goth's lapping mouth. Lady Goth kept her mouth at Morrigan's lips, savoring every drop, her

tongue working her through the aftershocks until Morrigan was limp, gasping, her vision white at the edges.

Lady Goth smiled from between her legs, then moved up to her, kissing her way up her body and kissed Lady Morrigan.

There was only one thing left now, at least for tonight, that Lady Morrigan still wanted to do.

As soon as the kiss broke, she let out a desperate voice. "Let my lips find yours as well, my lady." She placed her hand on Lady Goth's cheek, her thumb grazing her mouth, and the woman smiled once more.

Lady Morrigan had expected her to move aside, laying on her back, and she would have to muster all the strength in her spirit to switch places with the Lady Goth of a minute ago.

It would not have mattered if her body had shattered then. She'd find the strength, the willpower, and energy. The woman needed a tongue lashing, and Lady Morrigan had yet to taste her proper.

But Lady Goth moved further upward instead. She rose, her chin glistening, her eyes dark with hunger, and brought her breasts to her lips. Obliging her, Morrigan suckled, but that sensation lasted but for a few moments. The woman had another goal in mind.

Lady Goth rose further until her thighs reached Morrigan's cheeks, her sex positioned right above Morrigan's face.

"I'd rather that my lips need no finding."

Morrigan reached her head up, her hands gripping Lady Goth's hips, pulling her down, and latched on. She felt the woman's inner walls part against her tongue, and her hand reached up to cup her breasts.

Morrigan lost herself in the act, her tongue exploring, tasting the salt and musk and sweet tang. It was unlike anything she had ever

tasted. Even her own flavor at the kisses Lady Goth had just given her were nothing compared to this.

It did not taste like static as she had expected. Instead, her lips sucked on lemon-sour flavors, sweetened milk, and honeyed cocoa.

Morrigan's hands held Lady Goth's trembling thighs apart as she ground against her mouth.

"Yes," Lady Goth gasped, throwing her head back. "Memorize that taste, my sweetness. He knows it, too. He has known it, and I wish him to taste it on you! *Aaah! Oooohhh!*"

Lady Goth's climax came with a scream that shattered the air, making Morrigan shiver underneath her. Her body convulsed as she collapsed forward, her hands finding the headboard, and she rode Morrigan's tongue through the aftershocks with hips still jerking and her voice breaking on sobs of pleasure.

They lay entwined, their breathing slowly steadying, the cold of the room creeping back in now that their bodies were still. Lady Goth drew Morrigan close, throwing her leg over Morrigan's hip, and rested her hand possessively on her breast.

"I do not know what this is, Morrigan, between us." She spoke in between heavy breaths. "All I know is that without him it's not complete."

XVI

The moon was at its zenith when Lady Morrigan woke. Every night, her mind regaled her with dreams of being taught new things by Lady Goth, and every time they engaged in something new while being awake, it would only give ammunition for her dreams to charge her with newfound sexual fervor.

Tonight, her body was thrumming with the aftershocks of another dream where she had been chased through a forest, and Lady Goth had been a huntress. The prize to claim was her—and she ran through the ferns and bushes, the thrill of the chase and what might happen at getting caught leaving a trail of wetness and womanly scents that had made huntress-Goth's mission far too easy.

In the end, she had been caught, and then she had been treated to hours of endless lovemaking, a wild, animalistic fury in every which way Lady Goth took her.

But now that she was awake though, she lay in her bed alone, the sheets cool against her heated skin. The whalebone pendant still rested between the valley of her breasts, the hard texture tingling the edges of her nubs.

She rose, moving towards the window to ask for the night air to cool her down. Her nightgown clung to her sweat-dampened skin as

she gazed outward, setting her sights across the vastness of her estate. It was all hers, and while the more affluent would have scoffed at her measly demesne, it was more than enough. She longed for nothing but a place of her own—even the staff was kept at a minimal. At times, there would be nobody living in the estate except for her and Paulette, the cooks and cleaners having their own hamlet a little ways down to ensure privacy within the estate.

So perhaps, the figure she saw in the gardens was not at all supposed to be there. In her half-slumbered, and more-than-half aroused state, her vision did not let her realize that this figure did not look to be the size of a regular man or woman, nor did it move like one.

The gait was unmistakable in its movements, and clearly a man, and when her eyes adjusted and she saw that it stood far too tall compared to the garden-bushes and hedgerows, she froze.

It was *him*. He stood in her grounds, and his form was silhouetted against the moonlight.

Her hand went to the window latch, and with trembling fingers, she *almost* made the move to shut it.

Should I call for help?

She should have done anything than what she was about to do—as the more prudent ones would have commented. Or perhaps there was no world in which Lady Morrigan would have done anything except for what she did.

Flashes of being chased filled her mind again, and this time it wasn't Lady Goth who was the predator on her trail, but him.

And just like her dream, he caught her, and their frantic, wild, animalistic fuck-making lasted for days and weeks in the short seconds that her imagination worked its way through her inner eye.

Without a second thought, her wetness pushed her and his hardness pulled, and her legs made their way down. She descended the stairs barefoot, stopping only to put a coat around her skin, the necklace alight with a slight hum as it clashed against her breasts. The front door was opened, and the night air kissed her flushed cheeks as she stepped onto the gravel path.



The moonlight struck his porcelain skin, illuminated against the darkness of the night. Lady Morrigan could not help but be drawn to his almost ethereal glow as she approached him in the gardens, surrounded by peonies and forget-me-nots, as he tended to a planter of edelweiss from the Alps. He had chosen to wear a thick black overcoat and trousers, and nothing else. On bare feet he waded through the gardens, his bare chest catching the moonlight, as she slowly walked towards him.

He noticed her and quickly averted his gaze. She wondered what had brought on this sudden change in demeanor, him wanting to chase her instead of the other way around. Her dream returned in flashes, and it was both Lady Goth and this man-thing that were now squeezing her between their naked selves.

“The hour is late, my lady. You should be long into your slumber.”
A smile formed across Lady Morrigan’s lips.

“I decide when sleep overcomes me in my own house, and if I allow such behemoths to trample my garden-grass” she said, as she approached one of the wild rose hedges on the edge of the gardens.

She had to be careful not to go too near them. She was in her linen nightgown, sleeves falling just below the elbows, which would have been bare if not for the tailcoat she had adorned to keep herself warm at this time of night.

Like him, she was barefoot as well, the blades of grass against her skin making her feel more grounded, more in the present.

More in control.

“Tell me....” She paused, as if to speak his name, but realized that he did not have one. “How exactly is it that someone of your size can follow me home unseen?”

“This form is built for much, my lady, and discretion was always one among them.”

“And does that give you leave to spy on me if the opportunity strikes?”

“As long as I am returning a favor you’ve already taken several times over.”

She smiled. *I have, in fact, spied on him, ogled him, have I not? I cannot expect him not to do the same.*

There was a gentle breeze in the garden, and the nightgown felt smooth, soft against her skin, even as she wrapped her coat tighter. There was a slight hum as the wind picked up, and his hair flowed with it as he examined the roses.

Lady Morrigan hadn’t realized he had come up beside her, at the hedges.

“You see these roses.” She began, walking slowly along the length of the hedgerows, as he followed. “Many expect them to be grand and delicate. But these things...”

She plucked one single flower from the hedge.

“These are stubborn, hardy. They can survive the cold, even the frost. Don’t let their appearance fool you.”

She handed him the rose, and he admired it, examining each petal.

“This one has five petals. A dog rose. You’ll find them in poor soil, besides lakes and all manner of places ill-fitting for something so...”

“Enchanting.” He added, to which Lady Morrigan smiled.

He held up the dog rose in the moonlight, white inside the petals and pink along the edges, and smiled along with her.

“The ones people like to cultivate are fuller, more symmetrical and heavier. Yet they wear their delicacy on their sleeve.”

She glided her hands across a bushel growing along the hedgerow, reaching the stem and letting the thorns prick against her fingers. They stung, but she let it happen.

“The wild ones can endure, lasting when nothing else will. They have the thorns to hurt those who would do the same to them, though they are but roses still.”

He had a look of complete admiration about him, his face absent of thought beyond the vision before him. His eyes pierced into hers without shame, and his gaze lingered where others would have received considerable slack for doing the same.

She felt the innocence in how he looked at her, examined her. Yet he kept a respectable distance, one that Lady Morrigan wanted to close down, and never let go.

“You were created, were you not? Cultivated? Which one are you?” She stopped walking, turning fully towards him.

His mouth was slightly agape, as if caught like a rabbit in a trap, as he began to stammer his way through his words.

“My lady...I...”

“I have seen you at the factory, working away with iron and steel.” She interrupted him. “Do you have that power over yourself as you do over the rock you melt in that furnace?”

“A rock I am not. Nor a flower to be plucked.”

He seemed almost defensive in his words. *Good.*

“You could lift any measure of a man with your strength, toss him around like I would a broolly.”

“I would much rather work with the rock, my lady, lest it land fatal blow, otherwise unintended.”

He gulped, his jaw contracted, and he started breathing through his nose.

“Then how does she take charge of you? What power does she have that you don’t?”

Almost with uncontrollable force, he grabbed her arm, and Lady Morrigan felt it.

It *hurt*, but this was part of the game. Their game. It was the tango she loved to play.

“My lady, I am my own...ma—”

He paused, eyes wide, breathing heavily.

“You are what?”

He took a deep breath and calmed down.

“I am my own man.”

“Then show me.”

He closed his eyes but for a moment, in quiet frustration. “My lady, I cannot do such a thing.”

“Am I so wretched then?”

In an instant, his anger vanished, replaced with a longing. A kind of desperation. He got closer, much closer, and gently placed his palm on Lady Morrigan’s cheek, caressing it lightly.

“My lady, I would never imply. You are...”

She grabbed both his shoulders. “Tell me what I am. Tell me what you see.”

“I see a thorn, Morrigan...”

Gulp. Her breath caught in her throat. It was the first time he had ever spoken her name. She wanted him to scream it from the heavens, again and again, with tones of ecstasy until the night turned away.

“...a thorn placed upon a delicate rose. It survives the harsh frost and turns away those who might see it as anything less. I see a flower strong, that melts into my hands as they hold it so.”

She felt his arm around her waist, pulling her closer, and the one on her face gently roam elsewhere.

“Keep going.” She breathed.

“A rose plucked from the gardens of Eden,” he said as his hand found her neck and ever-so-gently found themselves around it. She looked up to him and gave a slight, almost imperceptible nod.

“I see a flower...dying. It’s beauty fading...”

His hands continued their journey, finding her shoulders, as he gently shifted the coat and the linen nightgown aside. As soon as the cool air touched her bare shoulders, she shivered, but his hands quickly replaced the air, filling her with warmth.

“...wanting to be gorged and consumed before time takes it away.”

The hands around her waist didn’t stay still. They had their own plans, as they made their way to places that only he had permission to reach. She pressed herself against him, feeling him, the warmth that threatened to escape from his breeches, as the hands on her shoulders made their way to her half-exposed chest.

“This rose, my lady...is...not deserved by...a monster.”

The hands around her stopped, and he turned, walking away from her, as Lady Morrigan almost lost her balance.

His hands were balled up in fists, and he was breathing, heavy and hard.

“You are not—” she began but was quickly interrupted.

“You deserve a saint, Lady Morrigan. A man, true and real, unlike me.”

There it was again. Somehow, her own name spoken from his lips made the sound the sweetest thing she had ever heard. She grabbed his shoulder and pulled, turning him around so he faced her. He didn’t have the strength, the will, to resist her touch.

“You...are no saint.” She said, as she grabbed him by the hem of his trousers and pulled him in, closing what little distance remained. The kiss she planted on his lips put her out of breath, and she breathed through her nose, desperate for air, yet even more desperate to keep feeling him against her.

“I don’t need a saint.” She said in between kisses, as he began to return them, his resistance slowly fading.

“And this...” She snaked her hands inside his trousers, finding him ready. “This...” her hands traced his shaft. “shouldn’t belong to a saint.”

Their kiss got hungrier, and he shivered as Lady Morrigan draped one of her legs around him.

“My lady, I would never...dare...” he said, almost in protest.

“You have plucked me already, ser. Now gorge, lest this rose fade away.”

His hand found her waist, spanning it easily, his fingers tracing the curve of her hip through the thin silk. Then, slowly, his hand slid lower, beneath the hem of her nightgown, his cool fingers brushing against the heated skin of her thigh.

Morrigan gasped, her head falling back, her hands gripping his shoulders for support.

“Here?” he asked. His finger circled the entrance to her body with a teasing slowness. “Now?”

“Yes,” Morrigan whimpered, her hips rocking into his touch, seeking more.

“The cold or warmth, their feeling I do not remember,” he breathed, his forehead resting against hers. “Yet I feel your heat, my lady. I feel you...it’s a sensation around me I cannot seem to find escape from.”

“Why run from it?” Morrigan gasped, her hips rocking. “Why seek escape from what is so...*fucking wonderful!*”

His thumb found the sensitive peak of her pleasure, and yet to enter his fingers stayed. She wanted to push herself onto them, but even in her state, she wanted to wait. She wanted him to push them in, for this to be his decision.

Tonight, though, it seemed he was hesitant, far too hesitant for Lady Morrigan to allow her own heated ambitions to continue. Perhaps another day, or another night. Despite his words, he did not seem like his own man yet. He belonged to someone still, she felt.

XVII

The morning light spilled in its soft haze across the rumpled silk sheets and warming skin on Lady Morrigan's shoulder. She had slept through the dawn until it was nearing noon, and the memory of the midnight stroll through the garden was still fresh in her mind: the scent of damp earth and roses, and the overwhelming presence of it—of *him*.

Everywhere her senses went, he went with them. She felt him everywhere—his taste on her lips, the pressure of what lay between his legs against her aching mound, that delicious tongue of his that she hoped would snake its way down there sooner rather than later, and perhaps, afterward, bring along what she desired most of all.

She had felt powerful in that moment, desirable and desired, wild and untamable, yet being able to bring to heel a monster so vast in its strength that even ten men would not match it in sheer power.

But then why do I feel like I should regret what I did? What I plan to do? Hope and ache and desire to do?

She did not regret it, in fact, and that's what worried her.

Am I losing touch with reality? Am I going crazy? Am I blinded by the lust towards a dead thing?

Her darkening thoughts were interrupted by the soft click of the door, and Paulette entered, carrying a small tray.

She wore simple peasants' clothing this morning, and even in them she looked radiant against the approaching sunlight. She approached with quiet, soft movements, and there was a tension in her shoulders that Lady Morrigan, in her state of blissful confidence and anxious unease clashing together, barely registered. As she approached, she noticed the way Paulette glided through the room, and it made Lady Morrigan's thoughts shift, landing squarely on the gentle, subtle sway of the lady-in-waiting's hips.

"Morning, Pauli." Lady Morrigan purred, sitting up against the pillows as the sheets pooled around her waist, stretching. "What delicacies have you brought me?" she inquired lazily. She still wore her nightgown this morning, and a flash of disappointment crept through her.

Lady Morrigan wished that Paulette would see her this morning—all *of her*.

As if to scold herself, she put the thought aside. The past few weeks had already been chaotic, and she had wanted Paulette to be separated from this side of the world.

Yet she couldn't help but pull her into it, without thinking, letting her strange desire she didn't understand take control of her actions in such moments.

"Some poached eggs, cheese bread, and chocolate tart, my lady." Her voice was formal and distant as she placed it on the bedside table, her gaze fixed firmly on the silver plate.

Paulette then turned around to leave, and Lady Morrigan reached over, grabbing her by the wrist.

"Where are you going, Pauli?" she asked.

She didn't turn around; her gaze fixed on the exit door as she answered. "I must see to my other duties, milady."

"I am your duty and refer to me by my name when we are alone." Lady Morrigan said with a firm tone. She pulled Paulette towards her until she reluctantly gave in and almost fell onto the edge of the bed.

"What is wrong, Pauli?" Morrigan asked, putting an arm around her waist, placing her chin on the woman's shoulder as she still avoided her gaze.

"Morrigan..." her voice trembled.

"There now," Lady Morrigan murmured. With a gentle but insistent tug, she pulled Paulette fully onto the bed, guiding her to lie beside her amidst the silk sheets. Paulette hesitated, but then gave in.

She lay on her back, and Lady Morrigan draped her arm back around her waist, and a leg on hers, letting her toes play with Paulette's.

"Tell me what's on your mind."

"A great many things, Morrigan."

"Am I among those things?"

"You are all of them."

Lady Morrigan chuckled. "All of them?"

"How could they not be, Morrigan?" Paulette began to idly play with Morrigan's hand on her waist, her hand roaming across Lady Morrigan's bare arm. "There is not a sight in the world that would match your beauty, my lady, no being that could match your radiance."

Morrigan nuzzled her face into Paulette's neck. "I have no equal, truly, but only for the reason that a certain young woman has stolen the beauty of this world and taken it for herself." She laid a kiss on Paulette's neck. "For when I look upon her, the beauty of the world fades, and only she remains."

“Is Lady Goth just that beautiful to you?” A desperate tremble lay in Paulette’s voice.

“Pauli!” Lady Morrigan tugged at the woman’s face, using her hands to tilt it her to look upon her directly. “It is you I speak of.”

“Me? But...my lady Morrigan...”

“Pauli, do you not understand that I want you here, in my bed like so, perhaps with even less clothing than you have on—though you do even this simple dress more than a few favors.”

“My lady...” She blushed, her cheeks reddening, a smile erupting across her lips. “I presumed it to be for all the ladies and lords of the courts and the royals to want their servants to do their bidding—”

“*Staff*.” Morrigan firmly corrected her. “And strike such line of thought from your mind. I bid you at this moment, permission to leave from the bed should you not want this, and I promise neither harm nor retribution will come to you. Your station, your remuneration shall remain intact.”

Lady Morrigan pulled, if only slightly, from the woman, giving her space.

“No! Morrigan!” Paulette grabbed at her hand. “My dreams and desires are brought to fulfillment every time you...touch me.”

“Every time?” Lady Morrigan asked with a smile.

“Yes.”

“Every single time?” She asked again, her eyebrows raised in intrigue.

Paulette nodded. “When you hold on to me, I want to pull you in only tighter and never let go, Morrigan.”

“What else do you dream and desire, Pauli?”

“Every stray kiss on the cheek, every little tug at me as you ask me to listen, to follow, to fetch something for you.”

Lady Morrigan's hands roamed around Paulette's body, careful not to delve into the lines of intimacy. Not yet.

"Yet when you are...with *them*..." Paulette started breathing heavily. "You look so much more alive, so dangerously alive and insistent. I always presumed you wouldn't want to...take a lover. Ever?"

Morrigan went back to nuzzling into her neck, laying kisses there.

"It irked me, quite so, to see you so taken with not one, but the two of them."

"Is that envy I detect in your tone, Pauli?"

"I...I believe you do, Morrigan."

"Why is it so, Pauli?" She said in between kisses.

"Because I feel like what you become with them...it's a force of nature that will consume you, and I might end up losing you, milady. I fear for you."

"Do not fear for me, Pauli. I'm as safe with them as I am with you. And self-discovery often requires a bit of risk, don't you think?"

"But why more than one, my lady? Is it not..."

"Paulette, do not finish that sentence." Once again, she pulled away from her neck.

"I did not mean it that way, Morrigan."

"You did not."

"Still, may I not ask? Is it not a question you have asked yourself?"

"I ask myself a great deal, and each question frightens me, Pauli, though I know you do not need to fear for me."

"But I'm yet afeared when you go after I—him. And especially so that night, when you...when I..."

"When you kissed me." Lady Morrigan finished for her as her lips found Paulette's cheek. "And I held onto you," Lady Morrigan pulled Paulette by the waist into her. "Shuddering absent of control, surrendering myself to the pleasure I felt, as I climaxed." She used her

leg to slightly part Paulette's and pressed it between the woman's thighs.

A gasp escaped the woman.

"It frightened me, my lady. I did not know what was happening to you."

Lady Morrigan was quite surprised. She looked at the woman with a sideways glance. "You did not?"

"The concept I'm familiar with, my lady, but I've...I've never..."

"Oh, you poor thing."

The crystal-blue eyes darted away, almost in shame. "Pauli...are you...?"

Lady Morrigan took her face in her hand, the blue of her eyes hazy against the sunlight, before they looked down again, a slight nod of the head the only movement she could muster.

"Was that your first kiss?"

Again, only a nod came from her.

"In that case, would it please you to have another?" Lady Morrigan asked, shifting her body—slowly—atop the other woman, until they were breast to breast.

"If it pleases my lady." She answered with bated breath, her lips slightly parting at the prospect.

"Yes." Lady Morrigan breathed, blowing hot air onto Paulette's face as the sunlight bathed her skin in gold. The light of the morning sun covered her eyes in shadow, and for a brief few moments, Paulette looked like a mirror image of herself, her coppery hair glowing in the sun in contrast to Lady Morrigan's dark-crimson. "Yes, you do."

Morrigan felt Paulette's hips involuntarily press into hers as their lips locked, and her arms caress her waist in light yet still cautious curiosity. Lady Morrigan's hands found their way to one of Paulette's

legs, and draped them up and around her hips, and her other hand caressed at her hair.

She had to press her tongue to her lips, like an impatient visitor frantically banging at the door while the host remained oblivious to what was needed. “Open up your lips, and let my tongue in, Pauli.” she breathed as she broke off the kiss, not waiting for Paulette to answer or even register her demand, before she went in again.

This time, Paulette listened, and Lady Morrigan almost forced her tongue in with the frantic desperation she felt at that moment. Realizing her own lust clouding her judgement, she eased in her frenzied assault.

I need to make this moment special, and lovely. I want to gorge, and she is but peckish and oblivious to her own hunger.

Then Lady Morrigan pulled back, and found Paulette to be very reluctant as her leg around her forced her to remain where she was, and her hands found their way around her head.

This time, it was Paulette’s tongue that invaded her, and a yelp escaped Lady Morrigan. The woman’s tongue explored every corner of her mouth, leaving her lips wet as if Lady Morrigan’s cravings had passed on to Paulette.

Breathlessly they both pulled away from each other, catching their breaths, and Lady Morrigan saw Paulette beaming, her face a bright red that rivaled even her own hair. Even the sunlight was unable to disguise her blush.

“I’m sorry, Morrigan, I—”

Another kiss quieted the woman down, a quick peck on the lips.

“Do not dare apologize for or with a tongue like such. If a kiss was like that, I’d wager that the rest of you will be like tasting heaven.”

Paulette smiled, closing her eyes as she shied away, her chest heaving with each breath.

“And I intend to put that theory to the test, Pauli.”

Her eyes shot towards Lady Morrigan, large and hopeful, a toothy grin erupting across her lips.

“But first, I’m famished, and so might you be.” Lady Morrigan reached towards the bedside table where the confections lay forgotten.

“Wait, my lady, this food is for you. Let me serve...”

But Lady Morrigan had picked up one of the chocolate tarts already, bringing it up to her lips. As she did, a dollop of that rich, dark dessert melted and spilled out, falling right on the edge of Paulette’s collarbone.

“Oh.” She said in a dainty tone as she looked upon the dessert flowing like a tear down towards her chest, curving towards the center at the valley of her breasts.

“I supposed you’re serving after all.” Lady Morrigan stated coyly, before her lips were on Paulette’s collarbone, licking off the chocolate and tasting both its sweetness and some of Paulette’s salty sweat. She was on the verge of perspiring under the sun and the heat of their encounter.

“Oh, my lady,” Paulette breathed, grabbing Morrigan’s head with both hands, playing with her hair, as Lady Morrigan pulled down Paulette’s dress from one of her shoulders, letting her bosom free.

The lady-in-waiting moaned as her lips traveled downward, following the chocolate trail, and kissed along with it. Lady Morrigan scooped up some more on her finger and brought it towards Paulette’s lips, letting her taste that confection as well. Her onslaught continued until she reached the edge of her breasts, her eyes looking towards Paulette.

“You look like me, you know that Pauli, except for your eyes.” She murmured, and a sharp intake of breath later, her lips latched onto her nipple.

“*Aaahh-oo*,” she moaned and cooed at Lady Morrigan’s assault on her, Paulette’s tongue beginning its own onslaught on Lady Morrigan’s fingers.

Morrigan tasted sweetness and saw Paulette struggle to keep her mouth closed around her fingers. Her legs wrapped themselves around Lady Morrigan’s pulling them towards her hips, and her hands bunched up at her hair.

“My lady,” she managed as Morrigan released her fingers from Paulette’s eager mouth. “What are you doing to me, Morrigan?” she breathed.

Morrigan released her from her mouth with a wet smack, and uttered, “My duty.” Then her mouth shifted towards her other breast, releasing it from the cloth that still clung to it, and latched on once again.

She sucked until she felt Paulette’s nipples peak, alternating between them, licking around them. Every time she did, the woman writhed in pleasure, and it gave Morrigan the motivation to suck harder, to lick with greater fervor, to push her own hips against Paulette’s burning sex, her own aching with desire.

Then she would find her hungry mouth searching for the woman’s tongue, and she would lift herself up to kiss her once again.

“Morrigan.” Paulette breathed as Lady Morrigan’s teeth lightly bit onto the lady-in-waiting’s neck, a gasp of pleasure releasing from her lips. “Let me give it a try.”

She was eager in the way she pulled Lady Morrigan up, who straddled Paulette above her waist. Paulette hastily pulled Lady Morrigan’s own nightgown, almost tearing it off in her desperation.

Lady Morrigan almost expected an apology before she would have to chide her and pull her head towards her chest, but Paulette didn't have a care for such things anymore.

With no preamble or foreplay, she went straight for her prize. Her mouth was on Lady Morrigan's tips as soon as she set sight on them, her half-torn nightgown bunching around her hips, and a moan of ecstasy coming from the lady as she tilted her head up.

Paulette's tongue flicked along as her lips suckled, sounds of pops and smacks and moans filling the room.

The air was hot and thick with their arousal as their hands explored and Paulette's tongue worked its magic. Yet there was another taste far sweeter than any savory pastry or tart that Lady Morrigan wanted to taste, and it currently lay burning-hot between the thighs of the blue-eyed woman.

Paulette made a whimpering sound as Lady Morrigan pulled away, but she eagerly lifted her hips to let her mistress remove the dress the rest of the way. Morrigan threw it to the side and left it crumpled on the floor, before finally laying eyes on the full, sun-lit form of the woman who was in sexual agony, aching to be pleased.

But Morrigan's eyes sighted only the burning heat of the woman, and she began her next assault.

It started with a simple kiss, both of their tongues dancing around, and it continued with trails of suckling love-bites along her body, shifting lower and lower until she reached the delta in the middle, that crevice that held a treasure she desired most at that moment.

She placed a kiss on her thigh before she felt Paulette's touch on her hair, a desperation in her eyes as she breathed in anticipation. "What will you do now, my lady Morrigan?"

"As I said, Pauli." Another kiss landed on her thigh, closer this time. "I'm famished, and you are going to serve me my favorite meal."

She bit at her inner thigh, and a gasp escaped Paulette. “And I...” She placed one hand around her right leg. “...will eat...” Another on her left. “...my fill.”

And she dove in.

Paulette’s back arched and her mouth went agape, a soft cry filling the room. In an instant, she was trembling, writhing, her body tensing and tightening, her chest heaving in her frantic movements, her hands flailing as her legs squeezed Lady Morrigan. She felt the skin of her thighs on her cheeks tighten around her as she lapped at Paulette, taking every inch of her sex.

To see her like this, at the pinnacle of her pleasure, it brought Lady Morrigan to the edge as well. She removed a hand from around Paulette’s thigh, and through her nightgown pressed into her own sex, hoping to let the friction of her hands be enough for the deed.

But no matter what she did, no pleasure was as arousing as the thought of being in between Paulette’s legs, breaking in this virgin-woman as her very first lover.

Lady Morrigan realized that if she touched Paulette’s lips with her own, she was the only soul to do such. If she pressed her mouth on her chest, nursed and suckled on her, placed a hand on her aching heat, or pleased her with her tongue—no matter where her hands or lips or mouth went, she was the first to do so.

“My lady!” she squealed.

She continued her onslaught, and Paulette continued her moans.

“Morrigan! Morrigan!”

Morrigan parted her folds with her fingers and continued to suckle and kiss and much more.

“I love you, Morrigan! *I love you!*”

With a scream, Paulette unleashed a torrent of her arousal as she reached the pinnacle of pleasure, and Lady Morrigan gorged on,

before Paulette pulled at her with a look of horror, her tired body unable to muster the strength to do much except tug at her mistress.

“My lady, I apologize...I...”

Lady Morrigan gulped, and breathed, looking into the eyes of her lady-in-waiting, and smiled. She felt her hair and face slick and wet, and in a light, playful tone, laughed.

“If I knew this about you, Paulette, I would break my fast like so between your legs every day”

“Whatever do you mean, my lady? Did I not...”

“Oh, Paulette!” Lady Morrigan pushed herself towards Paulette and kissed her, sending her tongue her way, and having the woman taste her own self on her.

Paulette wore a shocked expression as Lady Morrigan pulled away, a lone finger reaching up to her lips to lightly graze them as she contemplated on her own taste.

“I thought—”

“Shhh. Do not think, Pauli. Bask in this sensation. Breathe in the scent of our love-making, taste it on your lips, feel it in you.” Lady Morrigan sent her hand lightly over Paulette’s sex, which made her breathe in sharply. “You taste the air no longer as a maiden, but a woman reborn.”

A flurry of expressions and sensations overtook Paulette. At first it was happiness, pure happiness, before it was quickly replaced with worry.

“My lady, I should have been the one to please you.”

“And you have, Pauli.” She kissed as her body once again straddled the woman. “And the day has just begun. You and I are not leaving this room until you have broken your fast as well, ten times over.”

XVIII

The smoke-void of its form pressed against the plaster ceiling, distributed across the rafters like spilled ink in water. From here, it watched them through the miasma of its many eyes, black and unblinking. The scent of them rose in thick, honeyed waves, the salt-sweet woman-musk masking all others.

It seeped down the wall, leaving trails of fluid across the stone, colored like the rainbow of oil-paints mixing with water, each slick sound of its movement drowned by their panting breaths.

They did not see it. Tonight it was the shadow in the corner, the distortion in the mirror's edge, the breath of green-blue sterility that mingled with their heat.

Lady Morrigan lay sprawled across the silk, her dark-crimson hair strewn across the pillows. Her legs had parted to the night air, her entire body bare and glistening. Beside her, a young woman with coppery hair pressed kisses down her throat, her mouth trailing fire toward the swell of Morrigan's breasts.

Something twisted in the center of its chaos. Its form shuddered, tendril-teeth sticking together like wet vines as it screeched silently into the space between the walls.

Paulette's mouth found Morrigan's breast, her tongue circling the nipple until it hardened. She suckled, her cheeks hollowing, and Morrigan arched her back, her hands tangling in the younger woman's hair, holding her close.

"Pauli," it heard Morrigan breathe.

Their heat drew it closer, it's bipedal shifting to merge with the shadow, and becoming a formless void that crawled on shapeless limbs across the floor in slick sounds, leaving its prismatic trail. It wanted to be the one she opened for, spread for, begged for.

Paulette settled between Morrigan's legs, her face hovering inches above the sensitive flesh.

The creature rose up, its form coalescing into something resembling shape, and moved toward the standing mirror in the corner of the bedchamber. As Paulette lowered her mouth and licked—a long, slow, deliberate stroke from bottom to top—it looked at what it had become.

It was delightfully similar to the woman splayed out on the bed, being serviced by the younger one. It had the same dark red hair, almost the same golden-brown eyes blackening along the edges, and the same full, dark lips.

But it was all wrong, the rest of it. The limbs were too long, the nails too crooked. It opened its mouth to screech, and it saw tendril-teeth reflecting in the glass, and two lone appendages produced from its behind like tails, mouths and tongues strewn about its end emerged and retracted in hungry pulses as if it was God's discarded experiment.

It turned from the mirror, looking at the real thing, the woman it had attempted to imitate. Her head was thrown back, her mouth open in a silent scream as Paulette's tongue worked her. The young woman's fingers pushed inside, curling to find that spot that made

stars burst behind Morrigan's eyes, and the creature watched her body betray her—hips bucking, seeking more, pleasure building in waves it could taste in the air.

It longed to be in that position. To be given pleasure so delightful, yet the feeling of wanting feet foreign to it, unbelonging to its own nature. It was borne of another, of something else, of another skin it wore, like the one it wore now.

From one of its mouth-appendages came a mist, as dark as it was, and like a breath it flew towards them.

Lady Morrigan's eyes opened. She turned her head, and she saw it standing there in her twisted reflection, its golden-black eyes fixed on her with a hunger that was terrifying in its intensity. Her breath caught and her body froze even as Paulette continued her assault, oblivious, lost in her task.

"Please," Morrigan gasped, but the young woman only doubled her efforts, her tongue flicking faster, her fingers thrusting deeper, her other hand reaching up to pinch Morrigan's nipple, and Morrigan shattered despite her fear.

She came with a scream that tore from her throat, her body convulsing, and her flooding Paulette's mouth in thick, hot waves. Paulette drank her, her tongue still lapping, milking every spasm, every tremor, until Morrigan was limp and gasping, her eyes still fixed on the creature in horror, tears streaming down her face from the intensity of her pleasure and her fear.

Paulette kissed her way up Morrigan's body, and when her lips found Morrigan's, she did not feel her tongue, couldn't feel her kiss back. Paulette pulled back from the kiss, her crystal-blue eyes confused, focusing on Morrigan's face.

“That good, milady?” she whispered with a slurring, the air thick with the mist she had breathed in while drinking in Morrigan’s pleasure.

Morrigan could not answer. Her eyes rolled back, her body going limp, and Paulette collapsed atop her, both women falling into unconsciousness together.

It moved to the bed, its limbs clicking, its form shifting and blending as it gathered them up.

Then, it stepped back into the shadows, carrying them with it, leaving its oily trail along the path, but not before it took a torch-light from one of the hallways and dropped it on fluids it leaked.

The fire burned bright and violent, a darker tang in its color, swallowing stone and wood and everything else in between.

XIX

Rain clattered down on the stone pavements, and thunder rumbled and thumped in the air. Sleet cascaded across the ground as he moved through it on bare feet. The wind's cold bite crashed against him and retreated in defeat, unable to pierce through into his skin. It formed itself across him, gripping his gargantuan stature, and yet he continued at pace. He never felt the cold, even though his skin dried and tightened all the same.

He passed a small patio of trimmed garden-grass, and silently hopped above a hedgerow, and then paused. Along the garden-path in front of him were a regiment of armed soldiers marching in route step.

He slipped behind a tall bush and waited, the pitter patter of heavy raindrops striking the foliage against the rhythmic sound of the soldier's march. They were clad in heavy armor, clearly in his search, the glint of their freshly sharpened weapons unmistakable as it reflected against the torch-lights.

The estate gardens were lit up, every sconce filled with a fire-torch, and every regiment carrying additional light. The beast needed none to see, but they weren't beasts. They were but men, fragile and frail as

the weakest bone that could crush and splinter at a mere gesture of his strength.

Then the sky lit up with thunder and lightning, and the flash of light gave him the chance. He saw a gap, a momentary lull in their patrol as the regiment passed, their attention up in the sky.

Silently, he launched into a burst of speed, the rustle of the bushes being masked underneath the rumble and the rain, before retreating towards the next bushel. Despite his titanic stature, he was only flesh and shadow and made himself smaller as he melded in with the darkness.

He felt her near, the other thing that he hunted, the only other beast-among-men that could match him in dark-sight, the vicious form of it yet a stranger to him.

He found a stone pathway yet unpatrolled, and with silent steps reached a small metal doorway, reinforced with steel, and lined with iron hinges. It was made to keep out the likes of him, with only the tension of a metal key to release the multi-inch-thick rods that held the door strong, opening at the whim of something so miniscule in comparison. Yet he found the door open wide, its steel frame twisted and its iron hinges halfway to falling apart.

Something had been here, something that matched his strength, or perhaps even surpassed it.

He went inside, past the entryway and through a corridor. He followed the smell of burning sausages and spice-powder, went past the kitchens where a fire-pit lay with a burning pot atop it, abandoned in haste, and found the larder. The trap-door that was beneath a set of false crates that hid a small alcove was already wide open, but lacking the steel and strength of the entry-door, it was torn apart, one half still attached to the hinges and the other splintered across the cheese wheels on the shelving across the room.

He dove in, and the smells of the kitchens vanished. Instead, he found a scent familiar, a scent he had been used to for a very long time.

Smoke ushered its way through a small grate, green-blue with the sterility and stench of death. Further along the alcove, a hidden stone wall door that he knew the mechanism of, a secret latch below a false stone, a latch he had seen operated a thousand times before. Finding and opening it was as easy as taking a breath now—and impossibility it would have been, if not for her.

And then he saw it, the shape of something from his nightmares. Black miasmatic eyes stared back at him, one or many, he could not tell. Limbs and flesh blended to become one, and that bipedal entity lost all physical shapes before returning to its horrific form. From appendages it produces a tongue, and another, and another, and from more it produces a mouth, tongueless. When it moved it moved on its hand, on its head, across the stone walls in slick sounds, leaving trails of prismatic fluid across the stone like rainbows in puddles in the aftermaths of stormy rain.

From one of its appendages, it attempted a voice, yet it came as a screech rather than speech, and tendril-like teeth revealed themselves, stuck together like wet vines.

From the tongueless appendage came a mist, blood-red, void-black, dark forest-green then sea-blue. Then it glowed yellow like the sun, and he breathed it in, involuntarily, as it mixed in with the green-blue hue of the atmosphere.

In an instant, he retreated, his nose scrunching as if smelling something strong, back through the trap door and the kitchens and out into the stormy estate grounds.

And then he heard a shout.

“*REXAS! COME BACK!*” Junia’s voice bellowed against the thunderstorm, and he saw her faint silhouette in a flash of lightning, and a black void took his senses.

He burst from the bushes, and the first of those foot soldiers could not even muster a scream before a backhand sent him flying into a stone wall with a sickening crunch.

The others flinched and screamed as their shouts were lost in the thunder, their torches sputtering in the deluge. He sped like a wolverine, spun like a whirlwind of brutal efficiency.

A heavy-set foot soldier thrust a pike towards him, and he caught it by the rod, wrenching it from the soldier’s grasp and using it to sweep his legs out from under two more.

Thunder and lightning rumbled and flashed as he moved through them like white-shadow, his eyes silent and colored faded ivory as if he was blind.

A mace attempted to strike him, and the blow found its mark, yet he did not flinch—though pain did sear through him. In his state, though, pain was constant and blinding, and excess of it only further fueled his frenzy.

He found the mace and gripped it, the hand that held it frozen in shock. His own fist balled around it, and with quaking force, he squeezed.

Bone splintered and skin broke, and blood showered in a red mist as the foot soldier screamed like a wailing witch. The soldier’s eyes stared into the blind greys of *him*, and he let go. The mace fell along with the rest of the body onto the dirt and stone, a heavy thud and the clang of metal sounding against the rain. The hand still gripped onto the mace, entirely divorced from the body—or rather, the remnants of what would have been a hand. It was crushed and

disfigured to a point that it lacked any sort of recognition as an appendage; such was the intensity of his wrath.

“HELP!”

One of them screamed. Or all of them did. The storm drowned out their voices, and the rest of the patrols around the estate grounds only assumed it was the whistling wind that sent strange voices through to them. It was said that the wind carried ill portents during the thunderstorms, and to hear them meant equal misfortune. Understanding this, this closed off their helmets, and tightened their skullcaps and coifs, and continued their patrols in search of the abomination that had escaped from the clutches of Doctor Junia.



He sped through jungle and forest brush, past empty dirt paths and stone roads, dodging carts and carriages as they drove past him. He would have wanted to tear into the horses drawing them, to have the doors of the carts torn from their hinges, splintering into his hands as he would have pulled the passengers and torn them to shreds as well.

But his bloodlust had been surpassed by a greater force, a greater lust, one that drove him to a scent that was a mile away yet. He smelt her still, her touch and her taste as if she was right next to him, as if he had touched and tasted her that morning.

His feet splashed against the puddling water along the paths. The downpour had slowed to drizzle, and his cloak and clothes were damp and cold as he sped through.

He leaped over bushes, vaulted over stone walls, and jumped to unfathomable heights as he leaped above the passing carriages and continued, the drivers and the passengers oblivious to the hulking entity that had been in their proximity mere moments ago.

And then he reached it, the place where the scent was strongest. *She was here.*

The door itself was rusting and rotten, clearly not a place that someone like her resided. A secret meeting place, then, though she must have known he would find her there. In his arousal, he could find her anywhere. He could find anyone he wanted through taste, though there was one he had yet to taste, yet to claim and take make his own.

He burst through the door, his frame splintering it under the force of his rage. There was a deep thrum in his chest, a vibration that he felt in his bones. It demanded an outlet, his eyes reddening and his skin tightening.

A yelp and a scream came from the other side, but the recovery was just as swift as the shock when she saw him approach. She was a vision of dark, patient elegance, a long black dress and tall boots adorning her, and her hair loose and flowing freely. In the days he found her in his arms, she was beauty and debauchery incarnate, but tonight she was only the latter, only a tool for him to sate his hunger and lust. His lust; his greatest need and greatest want, all flowing into one place as he felt himself engorge at her sight.

“Are you hurt? Is that your blood?” Lady Goth asked him with a twinge of concern, though her tone spoke more of her arousal than anything else. She glanced at his eyes, burning with a feverish light as

he took quaking strides towards her, and she stood in place, ready for what happened next.

His massive hands seized the front of her dress. There was no resistance that the fine silk and lace could offer him as they ripped away with a sound like tearing flesh, exposing her pale, perfect skin to the cold, damp air. There was only once glance that he could afford in his frenzy, a glance that travelled from her full, pouting lips, her hair flowing, her eyes glazed, down to her now uncovered chest and her heaving breasts under quick breaths, to her legs—and the place her desired most at that moment.

A guttural growl tore from his chest, a sound of pure need, and he picked her up with ease. He anchored himself to her as his own blood-soaked clothes found their way away from him, either torn or quickly taken off in the haze. He pushed her against a cold wall and brought his mouth to hers in a sloppy, needy kiss, letting go of her lips in seconds, as she breathed.

“Your flesh hungers for mine after battle, my sweetling. I surrender myself to your sexual wrath.” There was no judgement in her tone—only dark, curious amusement, coupled with her deep arousal.

In the next instant her legs had wrapped around him, and he dove into her in a single, brutal thrust. With a roar, he buried himself inside her to the hilt of his shaft, and they both cried in a blend of pleasure and pain and relief. A sharp, ecstatic cry escaped her lips, and her head fell back against the wall.

Her body arched to meet his fury, and with great fury he continued to thrust inside. This was the glorious violence she craved, the raw, untamed power that no man could give her.

He set a punishing, relentless rhythm to his plunges, the sound of skin on skin against wall and itself filling the room with percussive

beats, a primal drumming of flesh against stone. Her folds engulfed his member with searing heat, and her legs pulled him tighter against her with each thrust, matching his rhythm. His hands gripped her hips like a vice, and the feel of her tight warmth around him only make his own need feel greater and greater and greater still.

She put her arms around his neck, gripping him for support, even though his hands had locked her in place. He was not going easy tonight, not that she had expected any less.

From the shadows near the door, a soft, deliberate cough cut through the air, though he did not look, or glance at the source. His only focus was to fulfil his need, and to ram home his engorged member inside her, and do it again and again and again and again. He was deft to the world, lost in the blinding, roaring sounds of the sex-tempest.

“Apologies, *Syona!*” Lady Goth’s every other word was a yelp of pleasure. “*He cannot hear you!*”

He continued to thrust inside her, and her mouth opened in pure, intense joy.

“*You can go, or stay and watch! I care not! Aaahah, ooh, oooooh!*” She shrieked and squealed. “*But do not interrupt—aaah! I crave...crave this!*”

Syona remained silent like a motionless silhouette in the room. She did not move, witnessing their brutal, beautiful storm.

A smile tore through Lady Goth’s pleasure-haze as she saw the spy had opted to remain, and she brought his face to hers for a kiss.

“We have an *audience*, my *sweet-ooh!*” He rammed inside her with greater speed. “*Let’s—give!—her!—a—shooooow-aaah!*”

His thrusts became erratic, more forceful, and his grip on her tightened almost bruisingly. With a final, deafening thrust, he roared and she shrieked, gripping his hips with her legs and pulling him into

her, while his final thrust put him to the hilt inside. A hot, violent flood erupted inside Lady Goth, and it seemed to drain him from every ounce of strength and fury.

For a few good, long moments, he simply held her as they both caught their breath, his forehead resting against her shoulder, both their bodies trembling and convulsing in the aftershocks of their fuck-making. The rage was gone, replaced by a profound, hollowed-out exhaustion. Slowly, he slinked to the ground, his hands gentle now, as he lowered her to the ground.

Her legs gave out entirely, and she fell, and Syona ran towards her to catch her in her arms.

“Worry not, Syona. I am quite elated at the moment. I’m afraid no part of me will function for a while yet in this bliss.”

The spy held her, brushing away several sweat-clad strands of hair from her face. “I do apologize for staying, my lady, but the matter is urgent.”

“I called you here knowing this would happen, Syona.”

Lady Goth’s eyes traveled towards him and Syona’s followed her gaze, and back at lady.

They both had sated smiles on their faces, heavy breaths and sweat and sexual heat-scent covering the room and their naked forms.

It was only then that his gaze fell upon the spy, and concern overtook his expression, a look that Lady Goth responded to.

“She’s here by my request, my sweetling. Fret not. Our secrets, however dark and debaucherous, are safe with her.” She said, though his expression remained. “Unless it is disappointment I see in you.” She looked over at the spy, and back at him. “Did you want her too?”

With a nervous look, he shook his head, albeit with great hesitation.

“It might surprise you, my lady,” Syona stated. “But this is the first time I have witnessed your union with him. I was too mesmerized to leave.”

Lady Goth looked up to the spy cradling her in her arms. “Mesmerized by the both of us, I hope.”

Syona only smiled shyly, and Lady Goth reached a hand up to her cheek, and caressed it.

“Then I must arrange for you to take part in our union, not just lay witness to it.”

“That won’t be necessary, my lady. Besides, we have work to do, matters to discuss.”

“Discuss them now, Syona, before blissful slumber overtakes me.”

Syona then looked over them both, raising her eyebrows.

“Oh, no matter our naked selves. This will be the last time you will have me undressed in your arms and remain unsatisfied, I promise you. But for now...” She inhaled and exhaled slowly. “To business.”

“What business? What are you two planning?” He asked.

“We have a lady to rescue, of course.”

XX

A deep, penetrating cold gripped Morrigan's head, giving it an ache that pierced on one side and stayed there, pulsing as she struggled to keep her head up. The cold seeped through the thin layers of her nightgown and settled in her bones, making her blood run cold. She stirred, head foggy and limbs heavy, as she discovered that her lack of movement was not because of her lethargy against the cold.

Lady Morrigan was bound by her wrists above her head, chained to some fixture on a board. Her ankles were similarly secured, spread apart, leaving her exposed and vulnerable to what felt like a padded table. The surface beneath her was warm and smooth, like soft leather that trapped a bit of heat and fought off the cold air.

Lady Morrigan's eyes looked at the rest of the place—glass walls lined the roofs, a ceiling of panes that had been wrought filthy with dust and dirt, and age most of all. Weak sunlight filtered through the glass panes, and the air smelt of earth and rot, and hushed flowers whose beautiful scents had died long ago, a shadow of them lingering now in acrid sweetness.

The conservatory was nowhere Lady Morrigan was familiar with.
Is this even Geneva?

“Paulette?” she called out, with a disused roughness in her voice, looking around the conservatory, her vision half hidden by old plants and dried leaves, and Morrigan’s eyes fell on a familiar figure.

She sat upon a bench, with a rigid and worrisome posture, her hands twisting a small, embroidered handkerchief into a ruined knot. Water fell from the roof somewhere, landing near her bench as she stared at the puddling pool of water next to garden planters of skullcaps and agaricus pots. Junia was staring at her own reflection in that puddle of water as it cascaded downward, falling to the floor below them.

They weren’t at ground level, then.

She had dressed for a ball, not too different from what she wore at the gala when they had first met, though this ensemble was hardly fit for occasion.

Speaking of, what occasion was this exactly? For a second, Morrigan wondered at her current predicament, at Junia’s presence here, trying to remember what happened between the last time she saw her, the last moment she remembered her own consciousness.

“Junia!” she called out, but the doctor remained still. “Junia, come help me out of these!” she called out again, moving her hands and feet through her restraints.

Then Junia looked at her, slowly getting up from the bench. The woman’s gaze, the way her eyes looked at her, it did not feel like they were eyes of youth. Her eyes betrayed her body, and her youth sat strangely on her perfectly angled shoulders, little dark spots below her eyelids as they drooped above a perfectly pert bust.

“I had the most terrible dream, Junia.” Morrigan said, temporary relief flooding her veins. “Will you release me, June?”

She tugged at her bonds, the rattling chains the only sound against the stagnancy of the conservatory. The plants were too dead for flies and moths to disturb them here.

But there was something in the doctor's gaze that gave her pause. A glint in the eyes, yet Morrigan could not place it. It felt too dissimilar from any other time she had gazed at those storm-grey eyes.

"If you wanted me bound, June, you only had to ask." Morrigan spoke, unsure if they were the right words in the moment. Confusion wrapped around her head and in Junia's gaze. It was altogether unclear if Junia was responding with any of the sexual interest the situation would have otherwise demanded. Lady Morrigan had never found herself in such a situation before, though the thought was not something she had failed to entertain.

"Will you release me, June? Or...?"

Junia moved, suddenly and close, her hips swaying as a hand reached out to trace Morrigan's jaw. Her touch was colder than Morrigan had remembered it to be, though Morrigan still half-responded to it. There was a fear that prickled at the edge of her awareness, a fear that this was all wrong, yet she did not hate what was happening. Quite the contrary.

Then her mind went again to why she was in this situation to begin with, and her last bout of consciousness before she woke up here. She had not seen Junia for a while, since at the estate when she had gone through the tunnels with Syona. The spy had then recounted certain events, hadn't she?

Junia was silent as her hand traced further down, feeling around Morrigan's throat, her pulse, and the small at the back of her neck.

Syona had found her in quite a state that night, dreaming of herself as Lady Goth—presumably—being loved to completion by herself, through her eyes. The spy had seen to it that boundaries

between them had thinned, and Morrigan had made sure that the boundaries between herself and her lady-in-waiting had disappeared entirely as she handed her that pendant on the necklace.

She felt it around her neck as Junia's hands grazed the string that held it fast. She saw Junia's eyes rest on her chest where the bone-tooth pendant lay between her breasts, and this time her arousal was unmistakable. Still, Morrigan could not shake the feeling that something was wrong.

And then she remembered, her last conscious memory, of Paulette in her arms as she slept soundly, her hand holding her naked breast as if etched on it, and her leg draped over the young woman possessively, as she nuzzled her face into her neck.

"Paulette." Lady Morrigan exclaimed, looking right at the doctor. "Where is Paulette, June?"

"There was no image I could make him in other than the one I loved the most."

Junia's words brought Morrigan pause, her breath stopping and her heartbeat rising. The fear took over, and the memories of the young woman in her arms faded temporarily.

"D...do you mean...?"

"He has so much of others in him, but all of what matters, all of what I thought matters, is all him."

Junia's hands took hold of the tooth-shaped pendant, the back of her palm resting against Morrigan's chest.

"He has his face." Junia let go of the pendant, and brought her hand up to Morrigan, cupping her cheek. "It is perfect and symmetrical, a beautiful man with a beautiful face, like yours."

Her hand went further down, to her neck, and then her breast, cupping them both with her hands as Morrigan breathed in, her own arousal spiking instantly. "His body is his, too, though I needed to

graft it considerably for it to be complete. The decomposition had not set in, but the damage to the body was substantial...unlike to the one in my hands.”

Her hands found her waist, feeling them, before they went back up and to the shoulders.

“He was quite the specimen, with strength in his arms that matched his sharp wit. He could cut with his words as much as he could crush with his fist.”

Junis reached up to her shoulders and took Morrigan’s hands in her own. “His hands had touched me a million times before they found you, though the new ones were not his own. Some parts of him were all replacements.”

Her face was an inch from Morrigan’s as Junia brought her hands back down, passing her thumbs over Morrigan’s lips, her palms over her breasts, and reached the curve of her hips.

“All these were precious to me, but to you there was only one thing that mattered, did it not?”

Then Junia’s hands pulled Morrigan’s gown up, and cupped her sex, and Morrigan let out a wincing, moaning sound. “The cock is all his, Morrigan, just like this cunt dripping at my touch is all yours, as it was going to be all mine!”

There was venom in her voice, one that Morrigan had only glimpsed back at the estate through the tapestry.

“Junia, please, what is this? What are you saying?”

“He was mine, Morrigan! I made him to be mine! And yet he chose you!”

She had started whispering, her face getting closer to Morrigan’s who pushed her hips outward to meet Junia’s touch. It felt peculiar to do so, a pinch of shame grazing Morrigan as arousal quickly clouded everything else.

“Are you talking about...?”

“Rexas! My love!”

Junia pulled away, and Morrigan breathed heavily, the cold of the conservatory forgotten.

“You mean—” Morrigan attempted to speak through bated breaths. “Is that it’s—his name?”

“There was so much left to do.” Junia spoke with her back to Morrigan. “So much to do, but I was this close.”

She turned, and got close, this time cupping Morrigan’s cheeks with both hands, her thumbs on her lips.

“So close, and you mucked it up with your beautiful, perfect lips, those lovely golden eyes and that *fucking hair!*”

Junia reached near her, cheek to cheek, and breathed in through her nose. “I had made plans when I met you, Morrigan. I already had the perfect man, but I was far from the perfect woman!”

Junia reached into her breasts, and from her bust produced a small key. She inserted it into one of Morrigan’s restraints, and unlatched her hand, before grabbing it and bringing it to her breast.

“Feel this, Morrigan. Feel the perfect symmetry of its shape, feel how perfect I am in every sense!” She pulled Morrigan’s hand where it could reach with that restraint.

“But that is not enough. I have tried much, slaved away for love, but you waltz in effortlessly and beautiful, and find it in an instant!”

Junia’s head landed on Morrigan’s shoulder, and she felt tears streaming down the doctor’s cheeks onto her nightgown. “He was supposed to be mine.”

At first, Morrigan’s mind went towards where the key had gone, but her hand went to Junia’s back, holding her close, making soothing noises as she calmed her.

“Junia, if I have wronged you...”

“I had considered delaying it, you know. For your sake. For our sake.” Junia spoke into Morrigan’s shoulders.

“Delaying what, June?”

“I wanted you for myself, even if just for a few weeks or months. To feel you as you are before I would carry out the final stages.”

“Junia, unbind me, and we can talk—”

Junia’s hand took hold of Morrigan’s, and the other snaked around her waist.

“It’s too late. As much as it pains me to say, it’s too late, Morrigan.”

“What’s too late, Junia?”

“Kiss me.”

“Junia, you are grieving. We can talk—”

“I felt your wetness, Morrigan. I know you want to, but I cannot force you to do anything.”

“June...”

“Just this once, Morrigan, and then you will never have to listen to me again, I promise.”

Tears streamed down Junia’s face, and far more than her arousal, Morrigan felt pity. Without any further bidding, she pushed her head forward, and her lips met Junia’s wet and salt-teared ones in a kiss.

Part of her felt strange, as if she was indulging in someone’s worse habits, and part of her simply wanted to sate her own desire.

Despite the saltiness, she felt herself enjoying the kiss, wanting to pull her thighs together as the kiss made her knees weak. She felt Junia’s hands stroking her cheek, one hand holding hers, and their tongues clashed together.

Despite her uncanny appearance, Junia was strangely appealing. Unlike Goth’s irresistible draw, unlike the creature’s—Rexas’—obvious appeal, and unlike Paulette’s innocent allure, the kiss was from a woman she wanted in all the ways a woman could. Syona’s

warning had not been lost on her, yet her desire was greater. Part of her wanted to see if she could go through with this and find pleasure in her bound state.

The heat between her legs wasn't helping.

They breathed into each other as the kiss broke off, heavy breaths mingling together.

"That was everything I dreamed of, Morrigan." Junia finally spoke. "Though it makes the next bit all the more difficult."

"Junia, what...I don't understand."

"Then you are truly lost in your lusty haze, Morrigan." The doctor answered, the venom returning to her voice. "I told you. You took something from me, Morrigan, and now I will take something of yours."

XXI

Junia moved to the far side of the conservatory, where leaves and bushels in dead grass and golden-brown blocked off Morrigan from seeing what lay beyond. Junia took hold of a small lever that had laid hidden beneath and overgrowth of wildflowers and pulled it down.

It was a small screen-wall that held the plants aloft, and as it moved, the leaves moved with it, revealing a shall bench, and on it, the slumped and slumbered form of her lady-in-waiting, Paulette.

Morrigan gulped. The young woman was in a simple shift, her hair loose and tangled, and her eyes closed. Her chest rose and fell with each steady breath. She looked unharmed, thankfully. Unharmed and beautiful in her vulnerability.

“Paulette!” Morrigan screamed at her before addressing Junia. “Why is she here?! She has nothing to do with anything, Junia! Let her go at once!”

Junia walked towards her sleeping form, extending her hand to her.

“Do not fucking touch her!”

Junia took hold of Paulette’s chin and tilted her head up. The young woman stirred and her eyes fluttered open. She was confused

at first, but then her eyes widened as she took in her surroundings, and the woman who held her head up.

Then Morrigan saw Paulette's eyes fall at her. It took Paulette a second to examine Morrigan, her expression, the way her breathless state spoke less of what Paulette was getting increasingly accustomed to, and more of a fear she had not seen too often.

In the next second, she was on her feet, running across the conservatory floor with a cry of alarm.

"Milady!" She gasped, reaching Morrigan's side, her hands finding the chains at her wrist, tugging and pulling at them. "Morrigan! Oh!"

"Paulette!" Lady Morrigan panted, holding on to Paulette with her free hand.

"Miss Junia, please help me unbind her!"

"I watched you, you know." Junia said, walking towards them as they both paused their frantic movements to try and free Morrigan from her binds. "When you coupled with her, held her, kissed her, nursed at her and feasted on her."

As Junia got closer, Paulette put her back to Lady Morrigan, covering her with her own body as if for protection.

"It made me feel such envy, to see such love expressed when it should have been me expressing it, and seeing the gestures returned."

Lady Morrigan tried to push Paulette away, but the young woman had grabbed her free hand and held on to it as she covered her.

"Paulette, please, you need to leave."

Junia continued her slow stride towards them. "I have done much to myself, to try and be something you become so effortlessly, Morrigan. Yet in my pursuit I saw that I was in a vessel unworthy of such love, undeserving of it."

"Miss Junia, please." Paulette pleaded.

"Pauli, leave!" Morrigan was shouting now.

“And when he became infatuated with you, Morrigan, it took a long time for me to realize, I need not change myself.”

She was close and reached out. Paulette winced, and Junia extended the back of her hand to stroke at her cheek. Paulette took hold of it to shake it away, but then Junia caught it, and pulled Paulette to her, putting her hand around her waist.

“And then she found you in her arms, you beautiful thing. And she had you as well.”

Junia interlocked her fingers with Paulette’s and brought her forehead to the young woman, who stood frozen and terrified.

“Such love I would witness once again.”

Paulette looked below at her hand as Junia let go, and Morrigan saw that in the young woman’s palm was a key.

Instantly, Paulette turned around and placed the key in the lock around the chains and released Lady Morrigan from her binds. Morrigan fell to her knees as she was released from the board, and Paulette grabbed her arms.

Morrigan looked up at her, staring into her crystal-blue eyes, as Paulette smiled, and in an instant, they embraced, their eyes closing and their lips locked in a kiss.

Their tongues clashed, wet and obscene, passing breath between them. The kisses deepened, becoming more frantic by the second, as Paulette’s hands found Morrigan’s hair, and Morrigan pulled at young woman’s waist.

“Such love, I had once.” Junia spoke from behind them, and they both smiled, their lips never leaving the other’s. Paulette’s hand tugged at Morrigan’s necklace, pulling her with it as if Morrigan had any intention to let go from their kisses.

“Mmmnnppphhhh!” Paulette moaned into Morrigan’s mouth as her tongue danced with hers.

“Such love, I could feel again, but it was taken away, selfishly, from someone who could find it in another.”

Morrigan’s brow furrowed.

“Now I will find it in you, Morrigan, and take away yours.”

“Mmmm—phuuuh!”

Paulette took in a heavy, wheezing breath, but it felt like it came from a punctured bag, and Morrigan opened her eyes, and saw Paulette’s wide open, as her mouth loosed around her, and Morrigan could taste copper.

Paulette looked down, and Morrigan followed her gaze.

Blood-red filled the white colors of Paulette’s shift, and she fell into Morrigan’s arms, her hand grabbing her hair painfully, before it loosened as she lay on the ground.

Morrigan looked at Paulette, and then at Junia, and found the blood cascading down the doctor’s hands. Anger took her, but Paulette’s touch forced Morrigan to look at her lady-in-waiting.

Her coppery hair was splayed across the floor of the conservatory, her crystal-blue eyes wet with tears, and her lips parted. Morrigan felt the pulse hammering in her as she held her, the way her breath came short and fast.

“Morrigan, milady. I’m...”

“Shhh, don’t speak, Pauli.” Morrigan held her in her arms, stroking her hair and holding the knife protruding from her back. “I’m so sorry, Pauli, please forgive me.”

“I need no apology, milady,” she breathed. “Only a kiss, to ensure these lips taste yours one last time.”

With surprising strength, Paulette pulled her down in a desperate kiss.

Then, with their lips still embracing, Paulette stiffened, her mouth breaking from Morrigan’s, and her eyes looking hazy as if staring at

something out in the distance, blood blooming across her shift like a flower.

“Oh,” Paulette whispered, her hands reaching up to touch Morrigan’s face with trembling fingers. “Oh, Morrigan—”

Then the hands fell and Paulette collapsed.

Tears fell onto the young woman’s face as Lady Morrigan’s eyes welled up. She brought her forehead to hers, touching them together, then bringing Paulette’s still body up in an embrace.

Morrigan felt numb, the strength in her body leaving as she fell holding Paulette, unable to keep herself up. Her knees felt weak, arms heavy, and her head thumped as if it had split open in two.

Then she felt a set of hands around her, picking her up, and she saw Junia bring Morrigan’s teary face up. She held her close, pulling her into her bosom, letting Morrigan’s tears fall onto her chest.

She felt a warmth across her own chest, between her breasts where the necklace lay, though the thought did not hold for long as she sobbed into Junia’s chest, her body shaking, her hands clutching the woman.

“Shhhh, Morrigan. The pain will go away soon. You won’t have to feel it for long.”

She wanted to grab Junia by the hair and drag her and hang her. She wanted to kick and scream into her face, but she was powerless. Her legs had given out completely. No part of her body obeyed her, not even the shameful arousal of her lips so close to Junia’s bust.

“I tried so much, Morrigan, to find comfort in who I am. For him, for his sake, and for him to love me. I gave him life, gave him everything that he was, and more. Yet he wasn’t my Rexas, he wasn’t the man I married and loved. He had his brain, but not his memory.”

Junia stroked Morrigan’s hair, holding her close.

“Then he grew to love you, Morrigan, and I found my answer. I simply had to become you, my love. For his sake. I had to take away something beautiful from this world to restore it to mine.”

Morrigan’s sobs did not stop. Her hands lay loose by the woman’s side.

“I had never wanted such things, Morrigan. But I saw you succumb to the worse parts of yourself and find happiness there. Should I be denied the same? Morrigan, what—”

Morrigan’s strength had waned, her tears in a freefall, and something tugged at her chest, the warmth growing stronger and stronger. Junia felt it, too, as she pulled Morrigan’s teary face away, looking at her chest, and the necklace between her breasts.

It burned with a sharp, insistent sensation.

XXII

“I’m sorry, Morrigan.” Junia whispered into her ear, keeping her close. “It was the only way.”

Morrigan’s thoughts were empty, devoid of anything—even the memory of what had transpired was absent from her mind. Like a dormant cadaver she lay in Junia’s arms, eyes closed as if asleep.

Junia put her hand around the necklace, picking it up by the pendant, examining it. It slightly seared at her skin, making her wince, though the heat was bearable. With curiosity, Junia looked at the bone-tooth, examining the peculiar carvings strewn across it, embossed into the cartilage.

Slowly, the searing sensation heightened, then dimmed down again, simmering in the heat as the wind outside howled and the sun prepared to retire for the evening. The observatory had turned the color of tangerine, amalgamated with the dried brown leaves and the glass panes reflecting light throughout the conservatory.

It bathed Morrigan’s face in that light, and her hair glowed bright, red and copper, like Paulette’s. Junia couldn’t help but notice the resemblance.

She held on to the woman, knowing it was the last time she would hold her like this, for Morrigan would never permit it so in the future.

She had taken something from her, never to be returned. Junia pressed the pendant back into Morrigan's chest, feeling her heat beat as the bone became dust under Junia's hand, and all that was left were tiny grains.

"No ordinary pendant, then, Morrigan?" Junia stroked her hair, but Morrigan remained silent. "A pity. It made you look so beautiful, so irresistible, with that thing where I had wanted myself to be."

Junia laid Morrigan down on the floor, and got up. The moon was out in full force tonight, and Junia breathed in the night air. She looked up towards the sky, and felt the air change.

The scent was changing in the conservatory, and the leaves started to move, swirling around Junia faster and faster. She turned, looking behind her where Morrigan lay, and her lips turned upward in a smile.

A dark, sputtering form descended from one of the open panels on the roof of the conservatory, landing before the splayed-out form of Lady Morrigan as she opened her eyes.

"I would welcome you to lay witness unto me, my lady. Soon I will become the splendor you've often indulged in."

Lady Goth knelt before Lady Morrigan, taking her hand and bringing it to her lips, laying a kiss on her knuckles. "Your flesh lies weak, Morrigan, along with your spirit. Take some of mine, and find succor in it."

Lady Goth put her hand around Lady Morrigan's neck, pulling her up. She then grabbed the back of her head, and parted her lips, descending them onto Lady Morrigan's in a kiss.

Lady Morrigan breathed into it, feeling the shape of Lady Goth's tongue, and her hands found the strength to reach up to her. She felt around for her shoulders, and the warmth carried itself across Morrigan's own body, as she deepened the kiss, moaning into Lady Goth's mouth.

Lady Morrigan breathed hard as they parted, and found the other woman doing the same. She looked into her dark eyes, the two voids revealing nothing even as new light shone upon her, showing Lady Morrigan that this delectable morsel was far more than she has dreamed of, far more than she dreaded—and not unlike Junia either in that regard.

“Can you stand, my sweet?” Lady Goth asked.

“With the promise of your lips on mine again, I will fly.”

“Fly we will, sweetling, but first we must deal with what chains you to the earth.”

Junia stood there, and Morrigan saw that she had been busy. Her dress was half-undone, and she was working on unlacing herself.

“Yet another lover, Lady Morrigan. Must you be so greedy?”

“Careful with your words, Junia, and who they address.” Lady Goth spoke up. “This lover of hers is quite possessive.”

“Possess her, then. All the better to snatch her from you, colluding with that cur to undo my work! You claim for me to violate some natural order by creating un-life, yet you parade around with immortality, you and that oaf!”

Lady Goth’s hands balled into fists, and a mist surrounded her. More leaves started to swirl around Junia, and the plants started to move, cascading around the doctor.

“Then you should know better than to put either of us to the challenge, Junia.”

“I could say the same for you.” Junia let her dress fall to the floor, and stood before them in her naked glory, a perfect form of beauty adorned by an imperfect frame, a crookedness to the cheeks that had not been there before, and eyes that were wide as saucers, as if bursting from their sockets. Contrasted against her body, the age-ness of her face was even more apparent.

A green-blue mist emerged from around the plants, and Morrigan saw Junia become something else. Her eyes were the first to go, becoming a miasma of nothing—strangely similar to Lady Goth’s but with greater intensity. Her hands and limbs stretched, becoming large tendrils as more sprouted from her body, and appendages the length of an arm popped out. An appendage-mouth opened, and a screech left its tongueless void.

“Oh, what the...?!” Morrigan exclaimed.

“Morrigan!” Lady Goth turned, picking up Lady Morrigan with a strength that seemed impossible. She took hold of her back, and put a hand behind her knees, and lifted effortlessly. “Come fly with me.”

And Lady Goth leapt with Morrigan in her arms. Lady Morrigan put her arms around Goth’s neck, gripping tightly as she could, though even in that situation she felt safe and unmoving in Goth’s arms.

Lady Goth landed on a higher ledge, overlooking where Junia was transforming into...something. Morrigan kept her arms around her as Lady Goth tried to let go.

“Darling, I’ll be near. Let go, and you will feel my touch again soon.”

“We should run away, my lady. We do not know what this thing is!”

“Junia is sapping the strength from you through this place, Morrigan. She kissed you, did she not? Soon she will take over your body, and you will cease to be. I cannot let that happen, and I cannot let my lovely little creature be harmed any more than she already has been.”

Lady Goth stroked Morrigan’s cheek with urgency, and Morrigan put her hand over Lady Goth’s, her other reaching up to her neck. She brought her face up and kissed her once more.

“The next time you find my lips on yours, my Lady Goth, they better immediately fall to taste my other pair.”

“They will, my sweetling. I promise, but tonight we have more pressing matters.”

“I don’t presume to know your strength, my lady, but I doubt you can win this fight.” Morrigan pleaded, holding both of Lady Goth’s hands.

“My aim is to delay, Morrigan, for help is coming. You should just stay here, and—”

A tendril burst from a pore in its body, lashing and launching itself towards the stone ledge where they stood. The entire platform shuddered, and Lady Goth staggered, her grip on Morrigan loosening for a heartbeat. That thing screeched again, the sound vibrating through the glass panes of the conservatory.

Lady Goth held her, and Morrigan floated with her downwards to a lower balcony. As she descended, she almost dropped Morrigan as a vine wrapped around her ankle, and another tendril whipper through the air. Lady Goth launched herself in place to shield Morrigan, twisting her body. The tendril sent her tumbling towards a stone wall.

Morrigan saw Lady Goth fly this time. She was light as a feather in her movements, and landed gracefully in front of Junia.

But Morrigan didn’t witness their battle. She felt a touch on her shoulders, distracting her, and her head twisted backwards, her arms up, ready to strike at a lone tendril sneaking up on her.

“Come with me, Morrigan.” Syona said, pulling her towards the opposite direction. They went through a door and down a stairway, away from the fight, though crashing and thundering sounds could be heard from the wall beside them.

“Syona!” Morrigan choked. “Pauli...she’s...”

“We need to get you out, Morrigan. I’ll make sure Paulette’s body is safely removed!”

Syona ducked, and pulled Morrigan down with her, as a tendril burst through the wall and crashed right in front of them, hitting the wall and she heard its pained noises.

The creature bellowed and screeched. Its own movements were slow, the skin bark-like and a visage that looked more like a writhing mass of feelers and tentacles, vines and tendrils protruding from every orifice.

“You...will...lose...this fight...!” It screamed, as a single tendril burst from a pore in its body, launching itself towards Lady Goth. With superhuman speed, she dodged the projectile, before another tentacle-shaped appendage swung towards her, using its body mass as a hammer. Another plant-vine emerged from one of the planters, surrounded by mushrooms like armor.

Morrigan could not even discern the hazy shape of Lady Goth through the wall-hole. She was quick as a shadow, but the tendrils were too many, emerging from every direction, and one collided against her, and she fell to the ground.

Before Lady Morrigan could scream for her, though, the glass ceiling above them shattered.

A massive form crashed through the conservatory roof, sending shards of glass raining down upon the writhing creature-mass. Morrigan screamed, ducking against Syona as the spy pulled her into her arms to protect her.

“Rexas!” she heard Lady Goth shout, and the man bearing the name launched himself to that thing. Morrigan saw him, the thing that had held her heart, and Junia’s. He breathed in the green-blue mist protruding from Junia’s shapeless form.

She wanted to be down there, to be in the heat of battle, fighting for Paulette and fighting her killer.

She heard a scream, a roar, and a screech as the sound of blood and splintering bone filled the conservatory. Syona pulled her away before Lady Morrigan could see whose bone had splintered, crushing against stone.

“Syona, I should help them.”

“No!” The spy exclaimed as they reached the conservatory entrance, large double-doors towering over her, at least ten-feet in height. “It’s not safe for you to stay here. I’ll get Paulette, and you run, Morrigan.”

“She’s dead, Syona!” Morrigan held at the spy’s shoulders, resting her head atop one as well as tears streamed down her face. “She’s dead because of me!”

“If the doctor took her life, that’s who I’ll blame, Morrigan. Do well to remember that.”

Tears swelled in Morrigan’s eyes. She felt selfish in that moment, to worry only about herself, and not be concerned for the two that were fighting this great beast for her sake.

Syona put a hand on the back of Morrigan’s neck, and pulled it up so that Morrigan was face to face with her.

“And if you feel like we’re endangering our lives for you, make sure the risk we take is worth it. Run. Junia gets stronger the longer you stay here.”

Morrigan stared into those violet eyes. “What even is she, Syona? What is this world I’ve stumbled into?”

Syona took Morrigan’s hands and brought them to her cheeks, moving them backwards until they were on the back of her neck. Morrigan felt a strange feeling there, as if something was protruding from both sides of her neck.

She felt a series of soft ridges that fanned outward from the curve of the spy's neck. It did not feel like flesh, but like supple skin as the folds shifted faintly at her touch, opening a fraction as Syona drew a breath, then settling closed again as she exhaled.

"The world has much that's beautiful and horrific, Morrigan, and more of each hiding in plain sight." Syona said as she rubbed her thumbs against Morrigan's hands. She traced her hands up to Morrigan's arms, and then her shoulders, before having them land back over Morrigan's. "For now, you should conceal yourself from them all."

She guided Morrigan's hands upward, pressing her fingers further up into the slits at her neck, and the ridges parted further.

Lady Morrigan gasped as microscopic barbs pricked at her tips, and she felt warmth around her fingers—and then inside her hands. She felt something well up to meet her touch, seeping into tiny wounds made by the barbs.

"It'll cool your blood, Morrigan, among a number of other things we do not have the luxury to discuss. It'll conceal you from the likes of us, beautiful or otherwise."

She held Morrigan's gaze, her hands moving to Morrigan's face as she trailed a finger down her cheek, letting her thumb brush away the tears.

"Syona—"

The spy took Morrigan's hand and opened the door, bringing her outside at the steps of the conservatory.

"Go, Morrigan. You're not safe here. Do not look back."

With that Syona closed the door behind Morrigan.

And then, she ran. Her knees felt weak at first, each step heavy. Her feet were difficult to lift. Every part of her body ached, and her head pulsed with a piercing ache.

She found her strength returning as she put more and more distance between her and the conservatory, yet her body and soul were spent. Still, she ran, and Lady Morrigan did not wait to see the outcome of the battle taking place behind her.

XXIII

He sped through cobblestone and wild grass, feeling the cold hard stones against his limbs and the wet, damp smoothness of the forest brush. Wet and green and damp and dank. Mud caked around him as he plowed forward, accompanied by water dropping down from the canopies above him. It fell from the tall trees as he waded through the brushes.

Like a hunter, he stopped to smell the leaves, searching for that unmistakably regal aroma that used to be around her.

He came across a bed of wildflowers, flaxen and peach-colored, growing next to deep green shrubbery before his path got muddy again.

There was a violence in him, an urge that needed satiation beyond any need or any lust that men or women had ever felt. The desire for release wasn't as prominent as the need for it, his eyes graying as his vision blurred with time and he relied more and more on his nose.

He had tried the scent of bright oranges, brought in as fresh as can be from Sicily. It burst out, the tang attacking his nostrils.

He had examined the lavender, the lilacs and the elderberry Sambucus, in the hopes that maybe a whiff would remind him of her.

He had even tried to find the aroma of his lady on her, the taste that they had both become familiar with, yet it escaped him.

With a grunt, he went on, faster and faster and faster, wading on all fours if he had to. Half of his clothes were torn already, occasionally catching on a stray branch, as he was distracted by a patch of anemone and rushed to smell them. He wouldn't stop to inspect the damage.

A new smell came with a gentle breeze, hitting his nose just as he reached a grove of beech trees. It smelt of the earth, of the resin of the beeches, of the mushrooms beneath his alabaster feet, uncovered and bare, scratched from all the rocks he ran over. His body relaxed in the air, opening up his airways as he breathed it in, the smell of the fresh open country, of alpine land and deep forest.

He had never been here before, so far away from people, from their wrath and judgement.

For a brief, fleeting moment, he forgot why he was here, and simply stood still, as a wave of warmth touched his half-bare skin. He hadn't even realized that he'd closed his eyes.

He opened them to see the sun rising, the sky bathed in a deep tangerine, brighter than any orange from Sicily, and far more enthralling.

The sunlight and the warmth...it was familiar. He had felt it before, back in Geneva.

And back again, came the memory that reminded him of his purpose, of why he had been speeding through all this dense, dank green as he searched for a scent of the woman he had lost.

Along with that earthy breeze came another scent. A familiar one. Wild roses.

In a flash, he was back in that garden, feeling her, breathing her in, touching her.

And he took off in a sprint, with renewed purpose and vigor, and a virile strength guiding him to wherever the scent led him.

Day turned to night and the forest turned wetter, a storm brewing and unleashing as the canopies opened up and the rain splattered down to wash all the muck off him. Mud caked his breeches as he plowed forward, a spirit of reckless abandon in how he followed that smell that had seemed to last for so long, and for such a long distance. Was he chasing her, or was this something else he had caught in his nose?

Thunder and lightning burst from the clouds, his own anger at himself reflecting in the skies as bright flashes revealed a small clearing, and across it, a sturdy, smokey lodge.



The lodge was simple—one room, a hearth, rough-hewn furniture. But his eyes went immediately to the bed. It was large, covered in thick furs and blankets, and upon planters and vases around it were dozens of wild roses, strewn about like offerings. Their presence felt deliberate, their scent intoxicating, and he felt all the more ready and willing to find *her* underneath him. Blood rushed to his groin, thickening him against his breeches with the same intensity that had carried him through shattered glass and battle-madness. He was rage-hard, violence redirected into singular, sexual purpose.

Candles stood on the bedside table and along the mantelpiece—dozens of them as well, their flames dancing in the draft, casting amber shadows across the room. The scent of beeswax mingled with jasmine and the unmistakable musk of a woman—no, *the* woman.

“The roses are there to invite you here,” A voice came from behind him, and he spun around, and saw her, the woman he was seeking. “The candles, though, are for me to look at you in all your glory, for I’ll be witnessing it unclothed soon.”

His lust began to unspool, his wild, translucent eyes reddening as the rage broke away, and those eyes upon him tore away at the threads of his need.

Lady Morrigan’s hair was wild and loose, her golden-brown eyes burning in the candlelight, and her linen shift halfway to being torn and damp. She looked like she had been running since the conservatory yet had the time to bring the roses to the vase and set the candles alight.

There was command in her voice, authority, and he was driven to obey. He would have caved at a simple request, but her domineering tone over him made his lust focused, yet he remained firm, the sight of her only engorging him further.

Her hand reached his half-bare chest, and with a flick, his torso was entirely naked, his heavy muscles and the hard planes of his chest rising and falling with his quick breaths. She pushed him lightly, yet he found no capacity to resist her, and soon he was on the bed, and Lady Morrigan settled herself atop him. She settled on his thighs, the press of her knees against his hips, and then her mouth came down to his, closing around his lips in a kiss.

It was not gentle, that kiss. Once their lips met, the rest of Lady Morrigan collided against him, and he fell on his back, taking Lady Morrigan with him. He felt tears on her cheeks, tasting their saltiness

as they mingled with their kisses, though her skin was no less wet from the splatter outside.

Lady Morrigan broke the kiss, casting her gaze on him, and seeing his form in the firelight. Still atop him, she reached for his breeches, tugging at them, and beginning to unlace them, before a glint appeared in her eyes.

She stood up atop him, and moved one foot atop his chest, feeling his warmth. She saw the hunger in his eyes, and knew that there was something in him that he was holding back because of her, a frenzied flame that made her want to unleash it. The anticipation of such passion and fervor rose a fire between her thighs, and she moved her foot, dragging it up until it reached his chin. She saw him stare at her, waiting for the next instructions, his mouth watering, eager to be put to use.

For so long, Lady Morrigan herself had felt control leave her, her own command at the world wane, and she wanted—needed—to be in charge of herself, of something, of *someone*. She wanted to feel in control, and nothing felt better than having the beast's violence harnessed beneath her, all that destructive potential waiting for her signal to become virile. She rose her foot to his nose, and he took in her scent, before she placed it directly above his lips.

His lips parted, and his tongue darted out, and he laid a kiss onto her toes, before she pushed them in and he suckled. Lady Morrigan reached her hand out to try and grab onto something, but the ceiling was too tall, even standing on the bed and atop him.

But then, his hand found hers, and from it, she found balance.

Something shifted in the air. There was newfound hunger in her eyes now, a passion that burned bright that wanted to use her own hands to rip away everything...but this was...better. More sensual. She wanted him to feel less like a beast, at least for now. Contradicting

thoughts came to her, of unleashing his potential, of providing him with warmth and reassurance, of goading him into a burst of angry, erotic ecstasy...

She pulled away her foot, and he made a whimpering sound. Lady Morrigan then moved her foot to his breeches, and felt his hardness, her foot tracing its length. She moved from atop him then to the foot of the bed, and descended, standing on the floor next to him. Then she reached for her linen shift and pulled it up.

She was naked underneath it. Completely and entirely naked. She saw him eye her breasts first, before reaching up to her face, looking into her eyes. They seemed to be asking for permission even now, and Lady Morrigan smiled.

His eyes traveled down, down to her neck with an intensity that made it seem as if he could feel her pulse. Then they lingered on her breasts, and he licked his lips. Further down they went, tracing along her hips, eying the lips below, and gazing at her thighs.

Then he, too, reached quickly for his breeches, only for her to put a stop to it immediately.

“Tsk, tsk, tsk. Slowly.” She spoke with a quiet, breathless urgency as he paused, her eyes now following the slow, deliberate movement of his hands.

He unlaced them, and as he did, more of him was revealed. As the trousers started to slide down, the lower part of his abdomen was revealed. She could see the outline of where it all started, and as that piece of cloth fell to the floor, her breath caught.

Lady Morrigan gazed at him, eyes wide with rapt attention to what mattered most to her in that situation, as she laid eyes on the prize.

It was thick. glowing against the light, veins protruding from it as it twitched with the desperation of his arousal.

She couldn't help but look at the rest of him, too, in combination with his hot, throbbing shaft between his legs. She could feel the heat from where she was, and it was all she could do not to pounce on him immediately.

"Come here." She said, extending one of her hands to him. He took it and pulled her in onto the bed. She straddled him and smiled as his hardness pressed against her heat. The warmth of each other's sex was like a warm blanket on a cold night. Laying her hands on his chest, Lady Morrigan moved her hips and moaned.

He sat up until his face was closer to her, holding her tight.

"Are you certain, my lady?" He asked, voice laced with concern, yet also with the raspiness that told her he wanted nothing else.

"I'd tell you to stop talking, but I think this will also suffice for an answer." She said, as she lightly put her hands around his neck, and closed the remaining distance between their faces.

When she brought her lips to him, she didn't waste a second invading it with her tongue, making sure that he knew what she wanted from him in that instant.

His response was clumsy. At first, anyway. Her tongue smashed awkwardly against his own, before both found the right steps to take in this dance and were kissing in earnest.

Almost involuntarily, both of them began to move their hips, gyrating against each other, desperate to feel the friction and the heat against each other's sex.

Still with locked lips, Lady Morrigan moved her hands, squeezing it between each other's bodies, and felt his shaft for the first time that night.

It was warm in her hands, throbbing and pulsing, aching for release. The message was clear; there was no time to waste.

Still kissing, she lifted herself up, positioning it just below her opening, and slowly set herself down.

“Ooohhhh—aaaahh.” Wordless noises tore from her throat as she sank down, inch by inch, feeling the stretch and burn give way to perfect, overwhelming fullness. She moaned into his mouth, her sounds muffled by his lips

Gradually, she kept going, taking more and more of him inside her, as the kiss inevitably stopped and they both took deep breaths.

Seeing her face in pain, he inquired with more concern. “My lady, should I st—”

“No!”

Her response was instant, as the rest of his length entered her, impaling her on top of him.

“Hunnnnghhh!”

Nothing was comparable to this.

It was total and complete, how she felt with him. She could have traced his heat and drawn it by feel, how perfectly it situated itself inside her.

But when it twitched, the movement made her shiver, despite the fact that both their bodies were now burning with heat and need and desire and the want to desperately, longingly needing to fuck the cold away.

“Take me, you sweet thing.” She said, breathlessly. “And do not stop, ever, until my heart and my heat are both sated, which they shall never be.”

Slowly, she grabbed one of his hands, intertwining her fingers as he followed suit, and brought her lips to his ear, as she whispered to him. “Now, fuck me.”

For so long, he had been wanting to be wanted, to be a part of something, to be with someone that understood him. For his life,

however short that it had been till now, he had been shunned, judged for being what he is rather than who, and thrown away where eyes rarely ever could see—except of course, for the not-so-subtle voyeuristic treks that she and Lady Goth would partake in, spying on him from the catwalks.

There had been a wall all his life that he hid behind. A wall he used to hide rather than seeking protection behind. This was him opening the doorway, letting her into his own world. There was no need for the wall to come down. He might need it again, but tonight, it was just him and woman on top of him, secured atop him sex to sex.

As for Lady Morrigan, it was closure. She had seen much of the world already, had already been jaded by it, letting herself live only in a fantasy. There was no hope for her that the world would ever contain a man that would make her have faith in it again, no hope to ever let her own true self be revealed.

For too long, she had sought to feel safe, to feel loved without obligation, without the need to be anyone but herself. She had lived among people who lied with every breath, schemed with every act, and betrayed with every promise. She made no promises with him, no act she felt obligated to do, and every breath came as easily as the next.

And now, he was giving himself to her. This hulking being made of muscle and titanic brilliance, and the flesh impaling her as a signature of his greatness. He belonged to her now, and she felt like she could trust herself with him, to feel safe in being her true self.

And it wasn't the world that gave her all this. It was this being from another world, and she was invited into his, free to come and go as she pleased. He had been borne from evil desire, of not letting go, and he was now giving her release through the same stubbornness, refusing to let go of her pleasure, her satisfaction. This world had

monsters that brought a painful feeling in her gut, but this was filling her completely, pressing against every secret place, rearranging her interior to make room for his intention, and all she felt was bliss.

She brought her other hand to his and intertwined it with her own. Both hands in hand, she moved her hips and he followed her, gradually settling in a rhythm.

There was nothing else between them but the feeling of being loved, of making love.

Their hands remained intertwined, their mouths agape in pleasure. There was no exploration beyond that—there would be time for that later.

Or maybe there would not be. The world could end tomorrow, and she would still be grateful that she spent the time she had wrapped around him, around his heat, and she felt herself spasm again and again as the minutes or hours rolled by.

The furs and blankets were getting wet by their sweat, and she felt the dampness of the blanket irritated her skin. But it didn't bother her enough to throw it away. How could it, when it would mean she would have to let go from him, and bring an end to the fullness inside of her.

She was too busy watching the sweat on his brow, on his chest, his muscular and chiseled form glistening against the glow of the candlelight as they slowly moved.

She watched the veins in his arms tighten, his face almost glowing as the scars darkened against the candle's light, feeling his legs stiffen as her own did the same, and their hands left each other's to wrap around them.

They finished in unison—her climax triggering his, or perhaps his triggering hers, the boundary dissolving as he finally let go of the last thread of restraint and poured into her with the thoroughness of a

promise kept, filling her with heat that met her coolness and turned to steam between her thighs. She spasmed around him, milking him, her body knowing what to do with his offering, and he groaned like a man being unmade and remade simultaneously.

The world could end tomorrow, of course. But she'd gladly trade the world if it meant it would end like this.



“I would give my life to see yours lived, my lady. Wade through fire and brimstone to see the spark within you light back up again.”

“Would it burn you like so?” Lady Morrigan questioned, tilting the candle towards him, letting the wax drip and land on his bare chest.

He neither winced nor grimaced, no sound nor expression at the pain she felt *for* him. It made a low, burning noise as it dropped. It certainly seemed painful, though she knew it was temporary. The soothing effect after was almost ecstatic in comparison.

“Burn, it doesn’t. Yet I do feel it across my skin.”

“How does it feel?” She asked, tracing a finger across the now-hardening material, feeling its texture getting smoother and smoother as it cooled down.

“There is a warmth to it, even now.” He paused, looking into her eyes. “I feel you against it far more, and it’s quite the welcoming sensation.”

A smile enveloped Lady Morrigan, as she draped one leg over his shaft. “I do too, and would you know, I concur.” She said, moving her leg back and forth, feeling it hardening against her.

“I have talked to you plenty now,” Lady Morrigan began, moving her hands around his chest. “I have had you take me, kiss me, and love me.” She moved to kiss his chest. “Yet I must admit, your name had escaped me.”

“Names matter little, Morrigan.” He said, but then Lady Morrigan chuckled.

“What would I scream then, as you take me? What would I say to call you if our arms ever parted?” Lady Morrigan moved her head up to his neck. “I did hear one particular name, though I do not know if you wish to keep it.”

“For a long time, my lady, I’ve had only one name.” He said, his hands on hers as they traced his chest. “She gave it to me when she was yet my wife, and I her husband.”

“Would it hurt to be called that again?”

“Uttered from your lips, even insults would feel like music I could listen to four days on end, my lady.”

Lady Morrigan smiled. “Shall I call you Rexas, then?”

“If it pleases you, my lady.”

“Yes.” Lady Morrigan moved her head up towards him for a kiss, and both closed their eyes as their lips met. “Yes, you do.”

Rexas’ hands explored, taking hold of her, pulling her up on top of him, and she gasped, breathless, already arching into his touch.

“Careful, the candle. Let me put it down.” She said, moving to put it back on the candlestick by the bedside, before Rexas held her wrist.

She looked towards him, and wordlessly, she eased her grip on the candle, as he took hold of it.

“Here,” he said, motioning her to move beside him. “Lie down.”

She did so, and he took his place beside her, lying on his side, holding the candle up above her, tilting it towards her ever so slowly.

The anticipation alone made her rub her thighs together, right before one single drop of hot wax landed on her naked breast.

The pain seared through her body, eliciting a whimper from her through pursed lips as she stifled a scream, and Rexas eyed her with a pained look.

“Let me soothe the pain, my lady.” He said, as he laid kisses around where the wax had dropped. It distracted Lady Morrigan from the pain, but the sensation when he latched on to one of her nipples was something else entirely. She lost herself in the wet heat of his mouth, the wax forgotten, everything forgotten except the pull of his lips.

His tongue alone worked wonders on her as another drop landed on her navel, where his mouth soon followed. He kissed around the pain, the searing sensation being quickly taken over by his wet kisses, his hands roaming on her arms making her want him to tend to the heat that was rising between her thighs now.

Lady Morrigan had her eyes closed and didn’t notice him moving his hand right above where the heat came from. And then...

A drop of wax landed right between her legs, and pleasure shot through her as she moaned, uncontrollably. She arched off the bed, moaning, as the pain transmuted instantly into throbbing heat.

“Ohhhh.”

Then another, and another, before Rexas tilted the candle back.

“Oh, Rexas, my sweet...”

The hot wax made her tremble, legs shivering and writhing in ecstasy as some of it slid further down, just as it cooled and hardened.

She could feel the smooth texture. It felt good against her, tight as a second skin that pulled slightly when she moved, before his hot breath was added to those feelings, making her moan again.

She gasped, eyes still closed. “Mischievous, aren’t we?”

“I like how you look, in pain. Gives me reason to soothe it and do *this*.” Lady Morrigan felt his hand reach up, until one of his fingers were moving across her lips.

He likes how I look. She thought to herself. The excitement of it alone was...

She took one of his fingers in, and suckled, right before another joined in.

“Because what you feel after, is nothing but pleasure, my lady,” he murmured, and his fingers—still wet from her mouth—found her folds, parting them. The hardened wax pulled against her skin as she opened for him, a strange tightness that made every touch more intense.

He found her center with his thumb, circling it slowly, the pressure perfectly relentless. She moaned around his fingers in her mouth, the dual sensation making her hips buck. When he lowered his head and replaced his thumb with his tongue, she nearly screamed. The heat of him, wet and soft against the hardened wax; it was overwhelming. He worked her with lips and tongue and just the edge of teeth, making her see stars behind her eyelids.

His tongue dipped lower, finding her entrance and the sensitive flesh around it, lapping at her until she was trembling, until her thighs were shaking around his head, until she was so close to the edge she could taste it. Then he pulled back, just enough to blow cool air across her overheated flesh, making her whimper at the sudden contrast, before diving back in with renewed fervor.

He rose above her, his shaft heavy against her thigh, but he didn't enter her yet. Instead, he dragged his heat through her folds, coating himself in her wetness, teasing her entrance until she was begging.

Each time the wax cooled down, she didn't stop feeling it. It still felt smooth on her breast, where it had dropped first, on her neck and navel, even between her legs. Between kisses, she moaned and tried to get the words out as quickly as she could.

"Do not...tarry...I want those fingers to be...replaced...with something...better."

Her eyes were open now, and so was his, as he looked back at her.

"As you wish." He said, removing his fingers, the sound of another moan coming from her open mouth as he repositioned himself, eyes never leaving her. He placed his palms over her breasts, feeling her beating heart, as he thrust forward.

"Oohhhhhh"

Yet again, like before, it was magnificent. He felt smooth, and searingly, painfully magnificent. It engulfed every part of her, every atom of her inner being, nary a space left for anything else. She experienced every pulse of his heartbeat through his shaft as he seated himself fully inside her. He withdrew slowly, almost completely, before driving back in, the force of it moving her up the bed. Again and again, he found that rhythm of slow withdrawal and hard impact, the sound of their bodies meeting filling the room alongside her moans.

With another movement, she felt him deeper, wrapping around him perfectly, made for her.

She felt each thrust deep within her core, a feeling in her gut that made her want to wrap herself around him, even though she felt like her legs were giving out with each muscle that she felt move inside her.

Clinging onto him, latching herself around him as if not doing so would bring that aching want back again, she met his rhythm.

He shifted his angle slightly, and suddenly he was rubbing against her pearl with every stroke, the dual sensation of being filled and frictioned sending her over the edge. She came with his name breaking across her lips.

“Rexas, Rexas, Rexas!” she screamed, and he swallowed the sound, fucking her through it, not stopping, not slowing, until she was trembling beneath him, until her nails had left marks on his back.

Only then did he let himself follow, with a final, deep thrust that seated him fully inside her, his forehead dropping to her shoulder as he groaned his release, pulsing hot and wet within her.

They stayed locked together, breathing hard. She could feel him inside her still, and she tightened around him. She smiled against his shoulder when he groaned, and she whispered.

“Again.”

She felt him move inside her, twitch at new command, and she prepared herself. The night was young, and she was going to have her fill.



It was difficult to let herself free of his weight and strength. Even in the docile state of sleep, his limbs had mountainous strength. She

looked at him, in his peaceful sleep, his naked form magnificent as it lay on the bed, each breath flowing like a heavy tremor across the bed.

She still felt him between her legs, a sated, satisfied soreness to her still-wet sex. A laugh escaped her with surprise as how hungry she still felt, in spite of having it all. She had tasted and taken Lady Goth, been taken by her. She had held Paulette in her arms after they had coupled, and in spite of everything, she was happy they made love before she left this world. And now, she had been taken by him, and she was complete.

But still, there was a longing there. It could have been so perfect, herself perched atop him, with Lady Goth and Paulette on either side of her, caressing and nursing her.

But her aching need was exactly what killed the young woman, and she was not going to let it happen again.

My sweet Rexas,

How wonderful it is to finally put a name to you, even though it is the one you used to adorn. I felt complete screaming it into your ears as you emptied into me, and I want for nothing but more of the same.

Yet I fear I cannot hold myself back when I am around you, or around the most beautiful Lady Goth. My desire brings death to those around me, and in knowing your own affliction, your own wrath in wanting to protect me, I fear I must not put you through that again. The aftermath of your bloodlust ended in the most beautiful of endings, yet I fear of what might happen if I'm not there to bring your need to heel.

It pains me greatly, but now must be the last time we join our beautiful bodies together. I will dream of every part of you, and despite what I will desperately crave, I implore you—and myself—to keep a distance between us. I remember the night Junia captured me and Paulette. I remember my home burning.

There is nothing left for me in Geneva but desire that will doom us all. I intend to leave, and I never intend to return. Hopefully, you understand.

I promised Lady Goth that if my lips find hers, I would wrap them around my womanhood instead—or perhaps she would. I do not remember. Instead, in my memory, give her more of what you gave me. Make her yours, and make her happy. It's a union I will remain envious of not being a part of until the end of time.

*Yours,
Morrigan*

XXIV

There was a smile forming across Lady Goth's lips as she wrote down the words, stifling her giggles as she translated his stammers and awkward phrases into something that made sense. He had...convinced her...to try and reach out to Lady Morrigan, who, by his understanding, had disappeared.

Some of the contents of this letter were coming from her own heart, too. There was a lot about Lady Morrigan that she was longing for, to feel her again in her arms, to feel her lips as she had promised. The nights they had shared could not have been the last. A sharp pang of pain shot through her heart every time her mind reminded her of that possibility.

My Lady Morrigan,

When we embraced in the roses, 'twas mine folly to forget to remember how you smell. I didn't commit our touch to memory, didn't learn by heart the shape of your body, nor the comfort of your succor, for I wanted our embrace to continue, and wake to welcome kisses in the morn.

I could not have imagined that you would escape from me so, and to have me in torturous wait for so long. Else I would have memorized every

encounter, so I may hold it in my heart and mind, to cherish and appreciate, and remember when heart desires.

I have no knowledge of your whereabouts, no news of your person. 'Tis not my wish to call upon you should you not desire it, but this creature does want and want drives me to seek closure.

I am aware you left because you are hurting, though I will admit to selfish desire when I ask if I have wronged you, or if my lustful state had you worried. My lady, I can assure you that you have calmed me like nobody else, and it is distance from you, not proximity, that I find healing in.

Should I not hear from you within the month, I have asked the good Lady Goth to help me arrange a search party or an expedition—

“You most certainly have not!”

Lady Goth stopped writing, and he protested.

“The request I would make soon, milady—”

“And you shall, before the ink dries on this.” She pointed to the letter she was writing.

“Milady, if you would please, these hands are ill suited to handle a pen.”

“I’ll help you with the words, just don’t put them where they aren’t permitted to be...yet.”

“Aren’t you concerned, milady?”

Lady Goth looked at him, a slight hint of disappointment in her face.

“Concerned I most certainly am, though more for you than her.” She put a hand on his chin, lifting his face up. “She’ll come around, just give her time.”

“But surely...milady—”

“If you think I don’t long for her than you are sorely mistaken.”

Lady Goth had a stern voice, and he lowered his head in embarrassment.

“Apologies. I didn’t mean to presume...”

“It’s quite alright, my sweetling.” She put a palm on his cheek, caressing his face. “I have to be strong, even though the thought of losing her makes me shudder with dread.”

“Then we should—”

“—and so does the thought of losing *you*.”

She got up from her chair and climbed atop him, facing him, as she held his face with both her hands, before reaching in for a kiss.

And he tried to reciprocate, but Lady Goth could tell his heart was not in it, and neither was hers for that matter. Both their minds were focused elsewhere, and the passion they had between them had been—albeit temporarily—replaced with a matter of greater urgency.

“We should be careful.” She said. “There’s a storm inside her head, and she will find nary shelter nor comfort from it on her own. We must navigate it with care, lest we draw her to wash off her sorrows in the Devil’s Bath.”

“I don’t think she—”

“I don’t either, yet it’s not always a choice.”

“I’ll ensure it doesn’t happen, milady.”

“Good.” She gave him a kiss before getting up from his lap, and he lightly grabbed her by the wrist.

“I will have to leave, then.” He said, gaze lowered, not daring to look at her.

Lady Goth sighed. “I know...I understand.” She was losing two of her favorite people, and now the warmth of their presence and company would be going away for who knows how long.

“Come here.” She said, taking his hand and pulling him up. He stood up and towered over her, and for a moment that feeling

returned, of want and need, of following her heart's desire. She wanted to make sure she would at least be able to remember him, how he felt, inside and out, like how he mentioned wanting to remember her.

"Tell me, how would you choose to take her once you find her?"

She pulled him into an embrace, laying kisses along his neck, and grabbing his hands to feel all over her. She directed him across her breasts, her waist, her backside, her neck, and she wrapped one leg around him, keeping the other on the ground for balance.

"You have taught me that what one's heart wants rarely matters in such instances when the other's is not in it, my lady." He said in between kisses.

"Oh, sweets, she's wanted you inside her since you found her in the dark hall all those months ago." She said, as he picked her up. "I will ask again. Tell me how would you take her?"

She put her legs around him, her thighs resting on his shoulders as he lifted her further.

"Would you be gentle and passionate like a lover, or would be an animal like how you found me in your frenzy, wild and fiendish?"

He lifted her dress and parted it, holding her in place in the air. "If I put my mouth onto you, would it matter?"

She grabbed his head and pulled his mouth between her legs, and he obliged in the only way he knew how. She had trained him well, to know exactly how to move his tongue, to know exactly when to suckle hard and when to be gentle, to find that sacred nub that sent the greatest of pleasures through her, and when to gently kiss around her aching sex, tease her as he lay kisses on her pale thighs, denying her.

Tonight he was all those things, and she reached her pinnacle quickly as her arousal dampened his hair and face.

He lowered her back to him, before she kissed him, and his pulsing rod found its way home, impaling her on him. He was the only support she had, and so she held on to him, as they made love one last time, before his inevitable departure, leaving Lady Goth with little else for her pleasure.

Perhaps she would have to find other outlets until then.

They made love until they she was sore and sated, and on the floor they laid naked until the sun set and twilight fell upon the sky.

Under the cover of the dark, it was time for him to leave now.

“Kiss me like you’ll never see me again.” She said as she lay atop him, feeling him between her, still engorged. They could stay there for hours on end, days even, fucking for weeks if they pleased. But pleasure was not the goal for this evening, only need, and they needed to feel each other’s embrace one last time, at least until they would reunite—weeks or months later.

He obliged, holding and kissing her with hands that traversed every edge of her form, and a tongue that mapped out the entire inner folds of her mouth, committing each sensation to memory.

EPILOGUE

The cherry red had a distinct tart profile, almond and oaks dominating the senses. He paused, as he always did, before taking a savory sip from the wine glass, careful not to tip it too far towards himself, lest it clash against the mask. Keeping that mask on and spotless was necessary, as it concealed more than just his identity, not that it wouldn't be guessed with much deliberation who he was. He couldn't carry himself with any lesser grace than he always did. It was the curse of being a charmer.

He had, almost involuntarily, sipped a bit too much from the glass than usual, though. The wine went down his gullet, but even this Tuscan red could do little to satiate his thirst. He had to calm his nerves.

The waiting had been excruciating. Standing up straight, a hand in his pocket, he stood in place, making idle conversations with whomever appeared before him. It didn't matter who they were, what they wore, or did, or talked about. Their faces might as well have not existed, masked or no. The host, of course, favored the shadows even more, donning a mask at all times rather than exclusively for now. The rest, though, couldn't have hidden themselves from the doctor's piercing gaze if they had been miles away. Once glance, and he would have revealed their darkest secret, a tame, docile blob compared to the engulfing miasma of the one he waited for.

And she saw him looking, sipping on wine herself from a goblet that seemed to materialize out of thin air. She wore a heavy black satin dress that hugged her taut figure. It was lined with velvet and colored in ox-blood, not too dissimilar to what the doctor seemed to evaluate with care, letting in the scent of the wine before taking a leisurely sip. Her fitted bodice kept her from relaxing too much, something she appreciated in this instance. Her back was straight as a result, and her

generous neckline framed her throat, drawing attention above, towards her face, and the Foxen mask she had adorned.

She was thankful at being without company at the moment. Her imagination was running marathons at the sight, at the prospect of finally seeing them together, as one. Perched atop a private balcony, as if at an opera in the seat reserved for the higher ilk, the floor was hers to surveil—though her attention was fixated on one particular person. She would not have wanted an audience if she could control this world.

And when she noticed his body language change from an anxious unease to one of rapt attention towards something in particular, she too followed the doctor's gaze across the floor of the ball.

He looked like someone misplaced in luxury—like he didn't belong there but certainly dressed the part. He adorned a dark tailcoat, black in color but had hues of deep burgundy and mahogany under the lights of the ball. Underneath was a charcoal waistcoat, and a white dress shirt with a neatly tied cravat hugging his neck.

He was undeniably dressed correctly for the occasion—almost *too* correctly, as if someone had instructed him on what to wear and he had followed the directions to the letter.

Which made it even more obvious why he was out of place. Dressed the part, but the rest of him betrayed his true nature. He was an animal seeking shelter, a man lost in the darkness, engulfed by it. His clothes were a temporary role he was taking up. They didn't belong to him. He wore them because it was required.

As he got closer, she noticed more and more of him. Slightly unruly hair, but not without some clear attempts to tame it, his own curls refusing to be disciplined. Even as he walked towards his output, his hands would find his way towards his hair, trying to put it in order, yet only making his unbelonging more apparent.

Her gaze shifted between the two. She examined the man who was unmistakably the doctor's other half. She looked at his rather simple masquerade mask as he gulped, his extra-defined jaw making obvious movements as his fragile beauty got exposed with each quiver of his thin lips.

She looked back towards the doctor, who looked nothing like the man that had raptured his gaze. The doctor's hair was perfect to her, yet not something from the arsenal of traditional attraction. His attire was almost too similar to how she saw him as she frequented the clinic, yet even sharper than ever before. There was a chain from a timepiece hanging from his tailcoat pocket, and underneath he wore a white dress shirt and a striking red waistcoat. The dress shoes felt relatively modern, styled to the century, as the both of them had forgone of breeches, stockings and pantaloons, dressing with power in long, straight trousers.

As the distance between them vanished and they stood side by side, the contrast was striking, despite their otherwise similar clothing. Where Jayce was constantly adjusting himself, the doctor was complete, still and unbothered. There was nothing about him that needed adjustment, which is when he did reach out opposite to him to straighten Jayce's cravat, his movements were slow and deliberate. His hands savored every touch, feeling every fiber of the cloth he wore, every degree of heat that radiated from his body.

Jayce. Do I know that name?

With his hands on his cravat, the doctor leaned in, eyes closed, and she saw with bated breath as he took in Jayce's scent. It was as if his aroma was a drug to the doctor. She saw how his body almost quivered, even though to anyone else he was as collected as ever. But she knew the longing in him, the veins in his neck popping at the thought of having him near. She felt it within herself, the heat

between them, all the way up in the balcony as it went through her own body.

The doctor spoke, and she read the lips, the words forming all the right sounds in her ears as she heard the doctor's gentle pronunciation of every word within the halls of her inner mind.

"Lemon, bay-leaf, and rum. Practical and timeless." The doctor said, slowly opening his eyes, a smirk on his face that Jayce returned with a smile forming across his own.

"I think you had it on, once. Thought I'd want to feel the same."

Jayce's reply sent a jolt through her, and her legs twitched as she involuntarily quivered on her seat.

The doctor's hands went busy with the cravat as his smirk grew, and the younger man's own hands just lay at his sides, occasionally wanting to reach up and grab them, longing to feel skin to skin again.

"You wanted to feel like me?"

"I wanted you as near as I could have you, know you."

The woman grabbed the balcony's railing, steadying herself. She pressed her thighs together, wanting to meet them there, pressing against her.

"In that case, let us familiarize ourselves with each other on the dance floor."

They almost reached for each other's hands, stopping themselves just in time for nobody to notice. Nobody except the one that watched them so eagerly, as if there was nobody else in the room but them. As if there was nobody else in the world.

She almost took a sigh of relief as she saw both the men go in opposite directions and take up different partners first. The masquerade ball had plenty to choose from, masked and moving to the tune of the light waltz music being played.

She could have been there, one of those people dancing. Maybe she could have partnered with both one by one, to the point that they would catch her in between, and she would melt into their waltz—a trio of longing and want, sandwiched between them.

But what they had...she could never, would never, come between them. But she also couldn't ever live with herself without being an eager witness to it.

Jayce danced with a lady first. Her mask was simple, a plain, almost wax-like porcelain color, with the contours of a face embedded in the mask's shape. She was dressed in a taupe ballgown with a corset and a silken scarf draped over her bust. She was pushing and puffing it out towards Jayce, though he wasn't returning her advances.

Meanwhile, the doctor had already begun dancing with a similar woman dressed in black-gold, her mask the most noticeable feature. It was of a parrot, or perhaps a peacock, their impressive colors on display. The choice might've been deliberate, or she might not have known at all that the birds putting on a show are often of the less fairer sex.

There was a switch, and they both got closer to each other. Jayce had another woman as his dance partner now, a brunette. Her dress was a bit more defined and masculine, and even from a distance she could see her sharp features. Strong jaw, and almost stocky build. Even her dress coat was undeniably less feminine than the rest, though everything else about her screamed femininity. Their waltz got especially interesting, as she draped a leg across Jayce when he put his arm around her back and she tilted all the way, before coming back up for a spin, and landing close to him, almost face to face.

The doctor had taken up dancing with a man, in a wolf mask. His attire felt all too clean and sleek for a masquerade ball as the pair slowly danced and talked.

Then, the music got louder. An organ played a tune, and the rest of the world disappeared. Her eyes could only see the doctor, Jayce, and blackness all around as they finally reached each other on the dance floor, and her heart started beating faster again.

They synced up immediately to the waltz, each step effortless as they gazed into each other's eyes, silent. A sidestep, and the doctor got closer. Another, and it was Jayce's turn. Soon, the remaining distance had been covered. She couldn't have placed a finger in between them as they stood chest-to-chest, one hand on each other's waist while the other was held together.

Occasionally, the doctor's hands wandered, reaching around his neck, or his shoulders, while Jayce's stayed in place, either too nervous or too lost to do what he desperately wanted to.

"Get any familiar with them?" The doctor asked, pointing with his eyes towards their most recent companions in the waltz.

"I did. The lady the rather bland dress isn't here to dance."

"What gave it away?" The doctor asked with a smirk.

"The mask." The empath replied, unable to hold back his smile.

"They rarely hide a person's true intentions. If anything, they are the most authentic of our faces, covering up the lies 'til only the truth remains."

"And what do *our* masks reveal?" Jayce asked, getting closer, but not too close. The people around them didn't need to know what they knew, though a certain voyeur was far more interested in their expression of knowing than the rest.

"They reveal the truth. We're not here to hide, only to take part. It's why what we adorn is unsophisticated." The doctor was returning Jayce's smile with the signature smirk of his own.

"What does that make us? Observers? Analyzing their weaknesses and desires, hoping to catch one of them in the act?"

The tune changed to something quicker, faster, and the waltz picked up the pace with it. The quartet had begun to play in earnest, and the crowd was following their lead.

They separated but for a moment, standing abreast of each other as they circled the dance floor, and catching their partner's hands for a switch up. Jayce got the woman he had danced with first, the one with the wax mask and the silken scarf, while the doctor danced with the woman in the masculine clothing.

Another beat, and the partners switched again, and the right pairing were back where they belonged. The two women were dancing with each other now, but they didn't matter anymore.

The doctor leaned in, getting close to Jayce's ears, who closed his eyes and exhaled slowly at the proximity of their faces, heat escaping from them despite their dark suits.

"It makes them prey." The doctor answered, slowly, whispering into his ear, as he cast a few hungry glances around the crowd.

Blackness began to separate them from the rest of the dancers. Even the sound of music died out, as if far away in some other room, audible yet muffled. She felt their closeness as she touched her own face with a gloved hand, before almost violently removing it to feel skin on skin. Beads of sweat were forming on her brow, and she wanted this party to go elsewhere, away from prying eyes except those of her own.

"Look at them, Jayce." The doctor said, as he gripped his arm tightly, and pulled him into his embrace. They danced, heads on each other's shoulders, as they surveilled the crowd. "They are but flesh and bone, and we can turn them to our delightful purpose how we want."

Jayce glanced at a woman, looking at the pair of them hungrily, mask removed unabashedly and licking her lips. She had red hair and a golden dress, and he saw flashes of the doctor holding her by the

waist as she leaned back, dancing to the music. He saw him tear into her with his hands, each blow separating limbs from her creamy skin. Jayce saw the doctor prepare a feast for him, and he gorged on it as he hadn't had a meal in a thousand years.

He saw another plump woman, and the dark vision repeated. The parrot-peacock masked woman brought a similar sensation, and then two rather attractive, tall men joined in to his fantasy. The only thing common was *him*, Jayce wanted to be taken and commanded by *his* wrath and desolation.

"What do you see, Jayce? What do their masks reveal?" The doctor asked, where he was close enough to feel the doctor press against himself, and delight filled his guts.

"Glutton." He answered, wanting to turn his head and make the crowd gasp in horror at their union. A shiver went down his spine as he spoke softly. "We could have our fill."

And she saw that hunger. Her hands had her trying to feel herself all over, her dress too much in the way to get down to business, but she could not peel her eyes from them. She wished the crowd to disappear, so she could, at least, see them in all their glory.

And when the doctor's eyes turned, glancing at her, right in her eyes, the world turned black, and darkness engulfed her vision completely.



Lady Morrigan's eyes opened to silence. She sat on a soft chair in a large room, curtained on one side. The light was diffused from the windows, making it seem like some ethereal other-world existed outside, a ball of white-hot nothingness that she would see if she'd peer out the windows.

It always felt like so, anyway.

She sat up and straightened her coat and put one leg over the other as she looked at or rather—who—was in front of her. Her suit was sharply tailored, crimson—almost a saturated red in the lights of the clinic, worn over a white turtleneck. A skirt of the same color, black lace stockings, and dark boots with a slight heel completed the ensemble. She wanted to be an image of control, and to feel it too—to be able to bring out her strength and femininity without inviting touch. Too many invitations had been given of late, too much damage caused by those who sauntered into her touch.

The coat itself was deliberately masculine, accentuating her figure yet undermining the impressive bust tucked underneath.

And if she felt wanting to exude control, the man sitting opposite to her, actually did. He felt whole in that look. A picture of something complete. A piece of well chiseled clay, where all the undesired pieces have been removed, leaving behind perfection in his essence. His attire looked nothing like hastily thrown together pieces of clothing that other, lesser men adorned. It was an *outfit*, a complete ensemble, much like her own, that spoke of something. It made him look composed, each seam on his coat placed and arranged, the way he stood up straight...everything.

His suit was dark charcoal, with a similar waistcoat over a white shirt and a maroon tie. His trousers might've been the same color, but Lady Morrigan could hardly focus on anything but the bits that

interested her most, as she eyed him up and down, quickly, before his lips tilted in a smirk and she had to look away.

For the sake of keeping control.

Everything hugged him close to his body. And Lady Morrigan wanted to join them, to *be* the clothes around him, to feel his warmth, to touch...to touch that face, somehow. That quiet face and that square jaw. That carefully groomed skin that felt extraordinarily, rousinglly inviting. She wanted to touch that composed, neutral lips of his with her own, as they bent ever so slightly—an adjustment so small it was barely noticeable—yet she did. That smile engulfing him didn't rush in at the sight of her. It took her in, first. His eyes took her in.

And she wanted to be lost in them. Pale. Steady. Unnerving. Patient. If he wanted to look at her, he would. He could. If he wanted to let his eyes linger, to control her with his pupils, he could, and she would open herself to it, inviting him to invade her however he wanted. She felt safe in his gaze suddenly. That safety made her uneasy, unable to sit upright without something to grip on and hold on to.

The warmth in his eyes made even his gaze on her—imagined to be of desire, or perhaps something else—a show of respect. He was in control of himself, in control of his desires, and he knew it.

Why does he look at me like that? Like I am a piece of meat? And yet, I don't feel ogled in the slightest.

Lady Morrigan sighed. She had come here to avoid such though, to seek treatment for her ailment of wanting physical affection from anything that struck her fancy. And the proverbial medicine had now become her greatest desire, and she kept on coming back again and again for her fix.

He had both his hands on each arm of the sofa, sitting confidently, and hers clasped together as she recovered from the exercise.

Occasionally she would rub the back of her hand with her thumb. She wanted him to speak, for a scream to go off in the distance, for a carriage crash through the windows...she wanted something to happen—anything—to avert her gaze from him, to forget what she had just witnessed, and to quench the flames radiating from between her legs.

At times, the clinic itself felt like it existed on its own plane. She felt at times to be in heaven, or hell, depending on how one could look at this situation. She looked forward to each visit but regretted it all the same. Maybe heaven was hell. Maybe she had died, and this man before her was her reward for a life well lived. Who else could make her feel like so? Or perhaps he was an incubus from down below, coming into this world to seduce her in every way an incubus would, and more, dooming her in her ecstasy.

And then he spoke. “May I fetch a glass of water for you, my lady? To calm the nerves?”

Already he was in control. What could this man not do? What could this man not do *to her*, that wouldn’t feel like heaven had become him? That he carried hell between those legs of his, searing hot and lasting forever.

“Ah, ahem. Yes, please and thank you.” She said, almost stammering at her words.

With swiftness and elegance, he almost glided through the room like a gazelle, moving behind her, towards the mahogany desk on the other side of the room. Lady Morrigan felt the air grow thin as he passed, drawing her own face towards him like he was the center of gravity. She unconsciously took a whiff of his scent as he went behind her, and she drew in the fragrance.

It wasn’t anything she recognized, yet it felt familiar. There was a hint of...orange? Sandalwood, maybe? And some kind of leathery,

animalistic musk, with something metallic on the edge, and tasting of iron. Every new session that scent grew stronger, more apparent, yet she could not place it.

It felt earthy, almost medicinal in the way it captured her senses. The smell itself wasn't sensual, but it took hold of her and spread a wave of electric warmth through her body as she heard him shuffle about in a drawer. He would have been an incubus, no doubt, with sensuality in his nature.

The warmth reached between her legs, and she heard water pouring into glass, and a vision came to her. As the glass was filled, she closed her eyes, and the heat became a fire that nothing could tame. It traveled through her, and like a tear it slowly slid down and down into the sacred depths she wanted him to explore, right before that fire became an inferno, and burned down whatever recesses were left of her sanity.

The water poured, and he poured into her, thick and full, chaining her onto a bed and leaving her helpless as he would use her as he saw fit—and he saw fit to match his hips with hers, and become a singular mechanism of pleasure.

The vision went further, and that mouth that held the smirk opposite her not long ago was wrapped around her every inch. A thousand of his lips attacked her, a thousand tongues, and a thousand degrees of heat was created between her thighs.

And then...

"Mmmnn," a moan escaped her. She hoped he hadn't heard the sound she had made right then, a sound that might as well have belonged to him with how much he had influenced it.

With a gulp, she opened her eyes, and realized she was holding her body tight, arms now on each side of the sofa-chair, with her own chest puffed out and head tilted up slightly. She took a breath, and

relaxed. The heat was there, but it simmered now. She had met the monster, and lost the battle, not that she wanted to win it in the first place.

She didn't manage to look him in the eyes as he handed her the glass of water, even though she felt him looking at her with a smile. She noticed that. The sincere smile. He knew what had occurred, and yet she didn't feel as embarrassed as she had been a split second ago.

His eyes were half lidded for a second. He was taking her in, her scent that now traveled around the room, and that scent was her. Morrigan tasted it in the air.

She took a few sips of the water and felt it cool her down. It tasted exquisite, the most delicious drink she had ever had in ages, and in that excitement, almost spilled some of it through the corner of her mouth. "Oh, apologies."

"Here, let me." He said, instantly extracting a checkered handkerchief from his pocket and reaching out to her. Their eyes met and never left as he wiped the water dripping from her cheek and down towards her chest. His scent was maddening as he grew even closer, lightly tapping her cheeks with the cloth, before handing it to her so she could attend to her other areas.

"These exercisers seem to be having an effect on you, my lady." He said as she handed it back, folding the kerchief and placing it in his pocket again. "They may seem contradictory, but such is the nature of all medicine. Without a touch of the disease itself, it can never find a way to heal you."

A touch of the disease. Is that what I should call you now, Mr. Corbeau? A disease, so you would touch me all so often? She thought. "Yes, Doctor Corbeau. Ahem. I'm..."

"Take a deep breath. Relax. I don't expect a performance out of my patients."

Lady Morrigan blinked and followed his instructions as he went back to his seat. “I’d be embarrassed to admit any other day, doctor, but clearly, a performance is not my forte.”

This time, an unmistakable smirk took over his face. A look of sheer delight. “A step in the right direction, then, my lady. It tells me we can progress further in our next session.”

“I’ll simply follow your lead, doctor.”

“And have you been, my lady?”

She knew what he was referring to, a bit of ‘homework’ for her, to find herself more grounded and in the present. “Come now, doctor, it’s right there.” Lady Morrigan used her eyes to point to a large object, covered with a gray sheet.

The doctor smiled as he pushed himself up on his feet. “A seemingly trivial necessity, my lady. To ask a question so mundane, is to let you feel present.”

The doctor moved towards the object, and Lady Morrigan turned her head towards him. She felt his body contort as he moved up to grab at the sheet and in a single, swift motion, pulled it off, revealing a canvas about three feet wide, and four tall.

It was the portrait of a woman, seemingly naked, painted only till below the shoulders. She had pale white skin, dark red lips, and her eyes were covered by a flowing veil that permeated the background. She was raven-haired, with streaks and locks of red mixed in.

The lady’s skin was perfect, lithe and graceful. Her head was slightly turned and tilted upward, where a light was coming from. The soft hollow clavicle would form a shadow against the light, which gave her accentuated collarbones a glint, perfectly framing the rest of her face. The eyes were completely obscured under the veil—no indication color or whites at all. Not even if they were open.

The lady was otherwise expressionless. There were no laugh lines, no contours or seams anywhere to focus on. Without the eyes, there was nothing. “I call it *Love Like Fire*, Doctor Corbeau.”

“Impressive work, my lady. I do not suppose you will elaborate any further?”

Lady Morrigan shook her head. “I let my work flatter me.”

“In that case,” The doctor gazed at the painting, and back towards Lady Morigan. “I hope I can do the same.”



Lying on the loveseat, she was different today—felt different. She was dressed in suit pants, a navy-blue button-up silk shirt and black heels, but those clothes did little to make her feel any less exposed to his gaze.

The clinic smelt of polished wood and old paper—faint, settled fragrances that felt like they belonged there. Lady Morrigan felt the aroma touch her skin, and her body relaxed.

“You spend a great deal of energy imagining how you are perceived. I’d like to lend you a steadier vantage point.”

“Whose vantage point will it be this time, doctor?”

“Yours...in a manner of speaking. Each new progression of these mentalization therapies is a unique one, my lady. You’ll be able to fully hear my voice, think, move, touch—though you’ll be lying here still.”

Once you are in there, it will be up to you if you want to hear my voice or not, or if you want to...continue on your own."

She gave a curt nod, and closed her eyes, her arms draped on top of her chest, clasped together.

"Perception is not entirely dependent on what the eyes see." He began, and she listened with closed eyes. "Though it is still all too important. The eyes tell you what you might feel, and the sensation of physical touch enhances it."

Lady Morrigan felt her muscles relax, and a strange scent overtaken her senses. It didn't have a distinct odor, yet she could feel a strong sensation, a subtle electric current running back and forth through her.

"Part of you wants to be able to see what you look like, to feel what you look like. You imagine yourself to be a monster, running away from herself. But there are many that look at you as you are, and you will feel that now."

In a flash, Lady Morrigan was standing in the clinic again, but everything felt different. It was mirrored, almost. She was facing the desk, yet turning to her right, where she expected to find the loveseat next to which the doctor might've been seated, and found the entrance door. When she turned back around, and looked towards the left...

She saw herself.

There she was, Lady Morrigan, dressed as she had been, laying on the loveseat, eyes closed and her arms draped over her.

When she began to walk towards her, an immediate *click* could be heard. It was unlike anything she had ever heard and felt unlike anything either. Her feet were engulfed in something, uncomfortably tight, yet she was used to the pain and discomfort. Her feet felt like

they touched something luxurious, and she looked down to see why her shoes made such a sound.

They weren't hers to begin with.

She was wearing heeled shoes, but they looked different than anything she owned. They looked expensive, and the legs wearing them were otherwise bare. Her gaze upon herself went up towards the dress skirt, and back up to her silk blouse. She raised her hands up towards her shirt, feeling the expensive material, and saw the hands were different, too. Leaner, perhaps, was the best way to describe it.

And then upon her shoulders, she saw stray locks of blonde hair hang just below her shoulders. For a split second, a memory of a golden headed woman came to her, and she recoiled.

She tumbled, catching herself on the desk, where she noticed something next to the entrance door. A full-length mirror. It had not been there before.

The face staring back at her was not her own, yet it felt eerily familiar. High, sculpted cheekbones, and a long, elegant jaw. There was a severity in the semi-confused expression of the woman in the mirror, a warmth without any softness. She had pursed lips, and a long neck. Her shoulders were narrow, and the rest of her was just as slender.

And it wasn't Junia's face, and Lady Morrigan—or whoever she was, felt relief.

Behind her, something moved, and her eyes darted back towards the loveseat. Lady Morrigan was moving and breathing heavily. One hand reached just above her thigh, rubbing it, and the other slowly moved from her stomach to her chest, and back again.

Walking slowly towards...*herself*, she saw her rub her thighs together, and place her hands in between her legs, the fabric of her dress pants still in between her and her touch.

And then, her eyes opened, and they looked right into...this woman. Or herself.

Almost as if her body moved on its own, the blonde woman sat on the edge of the loveseat, next to Morrigan, and placed a hand on her arm.

She took in every detail. Of herself, admiring it, appreciating it, and *feeling* it. She felt the woman she was...inside of...breathe heavily, a thumb caressing Lady Morrigan's arm.

Lady Morrigan looked at her own features through the blonde woman's eyes, at the small nose, the golden-brown eyes staring back at her. Her gaze drifted below, and she looked at her own neck, suddenly wanting to touch it, to caress it.

Drifting downward still, she saw the shape her breasts made against the shirt she was wearing, how her breathing made them rise and fall. She looked at her waist, the details hidden underneath the fabric, yet wanting to feel it under her palms it all the same.

Her eyes went to her hips, wide and perfectly framing the rest of her, tragically concealed by the dress pants she was wearing. Down her gaze went to the thighs Lady Morrigan's hands seem to be rubbing against. Her calves, too, were covered by her outfit, but she felt her heart stir nonetheless, before her lingering gaze ended at her feet, shoes still on. Every bit of her looked different from here, even though she had looked at herself a million times before.

Every bit of her looked different, because she wanted the woman who was there, lying on that sofa, writhing in ecstasy, begging to be serviced. She wanted her, needed her.

And she was going to have her.

The blonde woman felt a stranger sensation on her hand and saw that the woman lying on the sofa—Morrigan herself—was now touching her. Her hands raised up, towards her arms, traced her

shoulders, before coming behind her neck. Lady Morrigan's hands grabbed her, and pulled her into her own face, and she knew what was coming next.

She felt her own tongue dance and wrestle with the woman's, and yet the sensation was unlike anything she had ever experienced. It was *both* the women's senses she was feeling, as if both lips were her own. She felt her own saliva mix in with the blonde woman's and she felt the all too familiar sensations heighten, coming in full force, as the kiss progressed.

She climbed over her own body and felt Lady Morrigan's hands roam. They explored her back, feeling every muscle, examining every detail. The sound of them breathing and the smack of lips and tongues were the only things heard.

The hands reached behind her head, digging into her hair, while the other placed it firmly on her breast, pressing hard with need.

She felt Lady Morrigan's legs clash against her own, her knees and thighs brush up in between, asking, begging, to join in.

The kiss broke off, and she started planting kisses on Lady Morrigan's face, before she went down and nuzzled her face into her neck. A few kisses here, bites there, and she was sucking, as she felt Lady Morrigan's hips move, gyrating against her own.

There was no time to try to unbutton her blouse. Swiftly, the blonde woman lifted it over Lady Morrigan's chest, and pulled the fabrics covering her breasts aside, gazing upon her bare chest for the first time.

She wasted no time leaving a trail of wet kisses down from her neck to her navel, brushing her lips against her breasts as she went down, before coming halfway back up to take the tip of one into her mouth.

She felt the sensation of both their actions, and a scream of ecstasy launched Lady Morrigan's hips upward, pressing hard against her own, yearning for contact as she reached the point of no return.

Lady Morrigan felt herself move her hands to the blonde woman's thighs, moving between them, and she felt the moan of the blonde woman as pleasure filled her senses, and like a phantom feeling she felt her fingertips slicken. Lady Morrigan moved as the blonde woman to nuzzle into her own neck, laying down kisses on it, before she bit into her neck.

Lady Morrigan moaned. The blonde woman did as well, her sound muffled as her teeth sunk into the tender, heated flesh. Lady Morrigan wanted to bring her mouth to this woman's but she found that the blonde woman did not more anymore. She stayed there, on her neck, biting into it, and she felt a sharp pain shoot through her.

And yet, her hands continued to find their way inside the inner folds of the woman who was now tearing into her flesh, and through the woman's lips, Lady Morrigan felt the taste of blood, the saltiness of sweat, and the feeling of her fingers filling this woman.

She felt a chunk of the meat from her neck tear away as the woman feasted on her, the sound of teeth against flesh and the smell of pooling blood filling the room, before the sticky wetness of blood seeped onto the loveseat.

Her fingers did not stop their onslaught, and Lady Morrigan could no longer see through the blonde woman's eyes, no longer feel what she felt, losing the double-heightened sensations of pleasure.

The pain in her neck heightened as the woman above her made a guttural sound she knew to be the point of climax as her body tightened, her legs stiffened, and she saw the blood-ridden face of the blonde woman move towards her own, right before her lips locked with Lady Morrigan's.

MMMnnnnnnnaaaaha!

She heard herself scream into this woman's mouth as she then found her voice to be unrestricted by those lips, and she her voice reached the ceiling above back at the clinic.

Yet her scream was caught as she coughed, thick red liquid pooling from her mouth as she moved to her side and spat out blood on the wooden floors.

A TEASER

CREATURE CRAVINGS

HAVE A LITTLE MORE OF NOT ENOUGH

She would describe the walled garden as a place of ‘beautiful desolation.’ It did have a sense of almost deliberate decay, like it had been deliberately grown wild instead of wilderness being a thing of circumstance. Thorny roses picked apart and choked life out of formerly pristine topiaries. Ivy crept up stone walls, and at its center was a weeping willow tree, its branches often disturbing the waters of the pond just below anytime the wind picked up.

Night-blooming jasmine filled the air with a damp-earth scent, and Morrigan watched Rexas tilt his head back to catch it. He felt like a part of that place, of the flowers and the wild things that grew here. Like him, they were patchwork, makeshift pieces of un-nature mixed with primal, uncontrollable life.

He rested his hands on his knees, which were presently held by Lady Morrigan, sitting next to him in a simple black gown. The dark colors of her clothes absorbed the twilight as she looked at him with fascination, and an aching want that settled low in her belly.

The scenic display was quickly interrupted by the rustling of grass as Lady Goth appeared, clad in simple leather tunics, not a choice of attire entirely usual for her, yet she remained a thing of beauty in it all the same. Her dark hair was unbound, falling to her waist. Every time Lady Morrigan laid her eyes on Lady Goth she felt like squeezing her thighs together, and it was no different this day.

“Why are we here?” the hulking man asked. His voice came out rough, like gravel rolling in a wooden box.

Lady Morrigan wasn’t used to Rexas being so familiar with her. Seemed like in her absence, they had gotten to know each other even better...intimately so. She didn’t want to admit it to herself, but it made her a tiny bit envious towards both. She was happy for them, but she also would have wanted to *see* it happen, to watch their erotic union as it unfolded, to find those memories within their minds and

become them as one made love to the other, to be him and her as one, as well as be the breathless voyeur on their mingling of flesh.

Before that disappointment engulfed her, though, Lady Goth came up to them, a wicker basket in her hand.

“This place belonged to her.” She began. The basket had a cover, which she opened slowly. “It was a gift for one of her earliest discoveries. But she never visited the place. She was locked away, tinkering and experimenting as she always did.”

She put a hand in and brought forth a glass bottle. It had no markings, no name. It was dark green, the liquid inside sloshing about, no indication of what it was.

“But she did know that something grew here. A *special* kind of rose.”

She looked straight at Lady Morrigan and brought her hand to Morrigan’s face.

“A devil-rose. Crush it, roast it, and add it to your favorite mixture with a pinch of cinnamon. Mine is this—a red wine, any sweet red, with the devil-rose mixed in.” She pointed towards the bottle, lifting it up. “I call it the Devil’s Nectar.”

The two on the bench remained silent. They had a look of curiosity about them, eyebrows raised, and Lady Morrigan looked up as one of the woman’s fingers found their way to her lips, pushing inside.

“What does it do?”

The question came from him. Morrigan tasted Lady Goth’s fingers, rolling her tongue around them. They tasted like honey, and she could feel his scent next to her as well, contrasting with the thick, animal musk of him beneath the jasmine that Morrigan could feel at the tip of her nose. It smelt of copper and ozone.

“It’s a special kind of aphrodisiac that only grows in a handful of places in the world. Drink it...and, well.”

Lady Goth brought her lips to Morrigan’s, and with the fingers still in her mouth, kissed her.

Her lips did not stay long there, as Lady Goth moved to Morrigan’s neck, tilting it up. Her fingers left her mouth, and Morrigan could feel their wetness on her cheeks as Lady Goth bit into her neck.

“It’s a special kind of concoction.” Lady Morrigan breathed, gripping Rexas’s hands with both of her own. “It’s meant to rid you of all senses...*oohhhhh*,” Lady Goth had started suckling on her neck. “...except for the ones you wish to feel the most. It’s different for everyone, to an extent.”

“It can be quite the noise.” Lady Goth said, coming towards Rexas, and letting a soft hand caress his cheek. “Helps you forget what you don’t wish to remember, for a while, so you can focus truly on what lies before you.”

She opened the bottle and took one long swig, handing it to Lady Morrigan.

“It also...amplifies touch.” She said, as she brought her hands under his threadbare shirt. The contact made Lady Goth shiver, and Lady Morrigan could feel it in the way she was standing, making an effort to balance herself on both legs.

Lady Morrigan felt the liquid touch her lips. It tasted sweet, yes, but there was a different kind of warmth to it that found its way through to her, its aroma filling her nostrils. The effect was quicker than she had anticipated, and as soon as she swallowed it, she felt her own hands move towards Rexas, colliding with Lady Goth’s wandering touches.

The touch was electric, and all three of them shivered with anticipation. The smell was intoxicating, too, and an air of excitement filled her lungs.

Rexas took a few swigs, and Lady Goth climbed onto the bench and settled herself astride Rexas's lap.

For the next minute, all they did was drink, until there was none of the nectar left.

Then the world began to change. The dulled, wild and untended greens of the gardens faded, a desaturation in her vision. The sounds of birds and crickets and frogs became distant, a barely audible hum, and the scent of nightshade and jasmine vanished.

But she could feel the cold of that stone bench, of Lady Goth's leg and thigh pressing against her own, their shoulders in close proximity, the arms colliding every now and then, and the immediate heat from her and the rest of her form.

She felt Rexas's own musk, the breeze against her skin, the fabric of her own gown hugging her. Just sitting there was exhilarating under the effects of that drink.

Then, Rexas tilted himself towards Lady Morrigan and dragged her closer to him, and when he took hold of her, *oohh!*

The sensation was electrifying. She felt tingles on the edges of her toes, on her fingertips. She felt her nose itch in a strange, pleasurable way.

Morrigan then saw Lady Goth tilt sideways towards her, wrapping her arms around her, bringing her in closer.

Even Rexas was uttering noises of sheer, uncontrollable, unmanageable pleasure at every brush.

When Lady Goth's lips pressed against her own, she could almost instantly feel herself getting slick at the sensation, the way her tongue pressed and probed against her own making her knees shake. She felt

the softness of her skin as it roamed around her neck. She felt his hands on her breasts, her heart and heat tugging at her senses, the former threatening to burst out of her chest.

When those lips left her, they went for his, and Lady Morrigan saw them kiss each other. Their hands explored familiar bodies, reaching all the places they wanted to reach without the need for consent or approval. It had already been claimed before, given before, and with confidence their hands roamed and explored every curve and taut muscle.

Lady Goth's hips moved, gyrating. There was redness in the places where Morrigan could see her bare skin, around her neck, at her fingertips, and on her cheeks. She wanted to touch and kiss them.

She extended her hand, and put it on Lady Goth's thigh, and a moan escaped her, muffled by her kissing him. Lady Morrigan felt her body shake, writhing and tightening, as tiny, violent tremors made her twitch on Rexas's lap.

After a few moments of heavy breathing, recovering from that high, Lady Goth broke the kiss with Rexas and turned her attention towards Lady Morrigan, her dark eyes looking into hers as her fingers began to trace Morrigan's neckline. She brought her lips close to her ear, and bit her earlobe.

Lady Goth then slid from Rexas and got off the bench to kneel before Morrigan, pushing the fabric of her gown upward, exposing her thighs to the cool air. Rexas shifted behind Lady Morrigan, his chest pressing against her back, his arms wrapping around her to keep her steady as Lady Goth's mouth found the sensitive skin of her inner thigh.

Lady Goth's tongue traced upward until she found the center of Morrigan's desire. The first contact made Morrigan cry out, her head falling against Rexas's shoulder.

Her tongue circled and dipped in rhythmic patterns that made Morrigan's hips buck involuntarily. Rexas held her firmly, one hand supporting her back, the other moving to cup her breast through the fabric of her gown, his thumb brushing over her stiffened peaks in time with Lady Goth's attentions below.

Morrigan's vision was getting hazier and hazier any time she opened her eyes, and the woman was now between her legs, fading into grey. It was taking hold, as sight began to leave her, when she felt the woman's tongue pull away, and felt it on her lips, before it shifted and was firmly placed in her ear.

"Touch him." She whispered, almost like a command, but then she grabbed Lady Morrigan's hand by the wrist, and brought it towards his waist, then to his front, and then used her other hand to guide it inside of his breeches.

As she felt her hands wrap around his hardness, Lady Goth pushed her head towards him. His kiss was different from all the times before. She couldn't place it exactly, but it felt like it was a hesitant one, as if he still sought permission from her, despite having already known Lady Morrigan so thoroughly.

Lady Goth's hands joined around Morrigan's fingers, encircling his rigid length. Lady Goth's hand remained over hers, guiding her strokes as they worked him together, their hands moving in tandem, while Lady Goth used her free hand to open her dress, exposing her breasts to the night air. She guided Morrigan's mouth to one peaked nipple, and Morrigan sucked in, drawing a sharp gasp from the woman that vibrated through her entire body.

She felt movement as she kissed him, and before long, she felt Lady Goth's familiar heat next to her. She sat down on the bench beside her, draping a leg over her thigh. Lady Goth's hands poured

over her with a roughness she did not expect and shivered at the lips she found on her neck.

There was a sudden, violent shudder. It felt like her muscles were contorting the way one feels relief during a stretch, multiplied many times over. Her legs felt like jelly, the leg on her thighs and its heat not letting that sensation die down. She burned everywhere at once as she climaxed. The other two pressed themselves closer against her to keep her from moving too much, but that only heightened the pleasure.

His body was hard muscle, and hers was soft and delicate and she found herself in between them, her moans and screams occasionally muffled by a kiss from either of them as hands wandered and invaded her most intimate places. They continued as her gown vanished, the air against her skin feeling like a thousand hands moving across her body to please her. Every inch had a new set of lips laying down a kiss, feeling, touching, cupping, kneading, pressing, sucking.

Lady Morrigan did not know if her eyes were closed or not, if she could even see anymore. She didn't know where her own hands were, where her legs started, if she was still on the ground or somewhere in the air, flying. She did not know if she felt the woman or the man, or if it were her fingers that stretched her insides and gave her pleasure, or if it were his shaft pulsing inside her.

For it did not matter who was pleasuring her, and who she was showing her love to at that moment. She wanted them both, and she was having them both. Whether it was his heat splitting her apart, or if it were the woman's fingers making her tighten and convulse, it was pleasure, nonetheless. Whether her tongue found the wet slit between Lady Goth's thighs, or they dug into either of their necks, or the searingly hot sensation of his shaft around her hands—it was pleasure she gave, nonetheless.

Her senses narrowed to mouth and hands were the only thing that worked now. The rest felt numb, though she could still feel Lady Goth pressing both sets of lips to her thighs, kissing one and grinding on another. She felt him suckle on her toes, and the woman's nails digging into her back as she used her mouth on her sex from every angle. She felt his muscles and his strength as he lifted her, and as Lady Goth floated in the air to reach for a kiss at the same time.

She lost the ability to move entirely, but she could still feel two sets of tongues flicking and two sets of lips suckling on her, nursing her, as fingers from two hands stretched her open and made her scream. She felt full, pinned between them, and she shattered around them countless times with screams that tore her throat raw.

Was she on the bench, on the ground, or wrapped in soft cotton and satin sheets in some demesne her woman had found? Was she loving him or being loved by him? Where did her legs end, and Lady Goth's begin as she felt the woman press their heats together?

None of that mattered truth be told. All that mattered was her scream as she shivered into her touch, his groan as he finished inside her, and Lady Morrigan's own ecstatic screams as the both of them had her climax on their mouths, their fingers, and their sex.

The sounds of pleasure were the only sounds she could hear, as Lady Goth's tongue made her flutter and cry, and Morrigan herself found ecstasy in the ways she was asking for more, more, *more!*

And then, she felt him erupt, and he groaned next to her ear, with Lady Goth's moans on the other side. She felt Lady Goth on top of her, their mouths on each other's sex, as she violently shook with pleasure in her orgasm. She saw them in her mind's eye, their coupling, and she saw herself join them.

She could taste sweet nectar from Lady Goth as she latched onto her nubs and could taste sweet wine when Morrigan kissed him. She

could feel his length and the remnants of it bubbling inside her like magma, and she lay there, whether on grass or stone, feeling complete.

